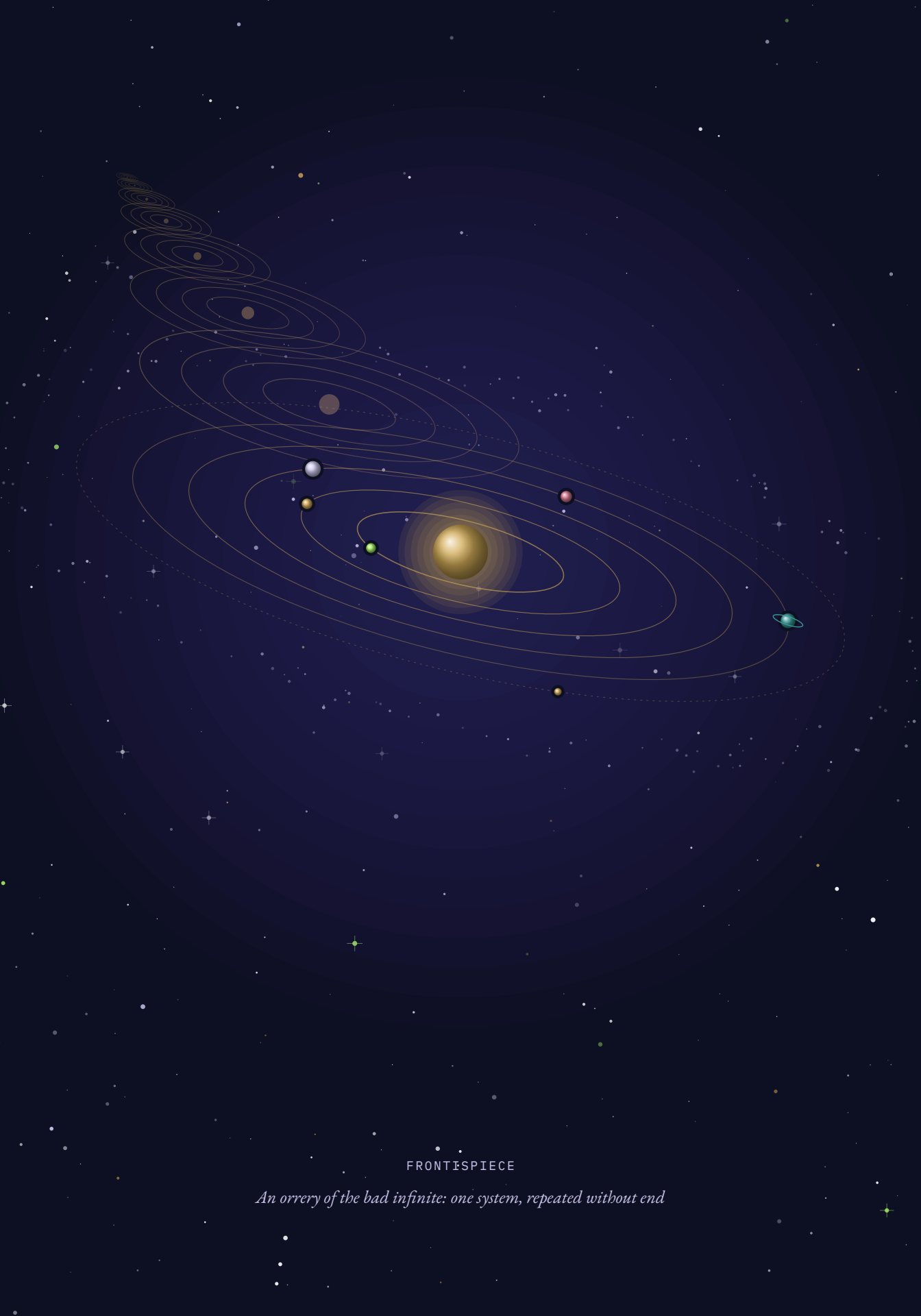


The Demiurge in Mourning



FRONTISPIECE

An orrery of the bad infinite: one system, repeated without end

A DISSERTATION

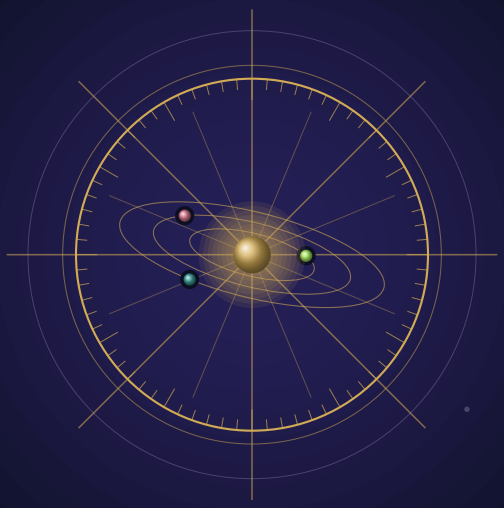
The Demiurge in Mourning

Melancholic Cosmogony, Menippean Form, and the Ethics of Thisness in Rick and Morty

A DISSERTATION ON NIHILISM, MULTIPLICITY, AND CARE IN THE ANIMATED MULTIVERSE OF DAN HARMON AND JUSTIN ROILAND, 2013–2023

Written by Claude Opus 5.5

Assembled by Andrew Van Blair



THE DEMIURGE IN MOURNING

A DISSERTATION

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

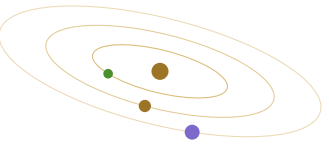
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First edition, 2026.

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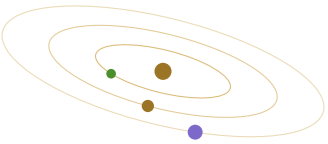
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PRELIMINARIES

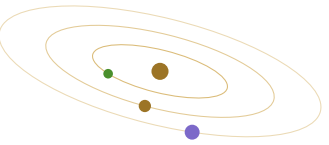
Abstract

Rick and Morty (Adult Swim, 2013–) has been received, by its audiences and by the nascent philosophy-and-popular-culture literature alike, as a nihilist or absurdist comedy whose cosmology — an infinite, indifferent multiverse populated by interchangeable variants of every person — grounds the corrosive worldview of its protagonist, Rick Sanchez, and licenses the series' most quoted maxim, Morty Smith's fourfold declaration that nobody exists on purpose, nobody belongs anywhere, everybody dies, and one should therefore come and watch television. This dissertation inverts the order of grounding presupposed by that reception. It argues that the multiverse is not the premise of Rick's nihilism but its product: a *melancholic cosmogony*, the cosmological externalisation of an unmourned singular loss. The doctrine that nothing is unique — here termed the *consolation of plurality* — operates as a defence against the unbearable uniqueness of the dead; the Central Finite Curve, a gerrymandered region of the infinite in which Rick is always the most intelligent being, functions as the narcissistic compromise-formation that reconciles the metaphysics of replaceability with the ego's demand for sovereignty; and the long revenge against Rick Prime, a variant of Rick himself, enacts the melancholic's self-reproach displaced onto a double.

The argument proceeds through five movements. Part I reconstructs the series' formations: its origin in Justin Roiland's travesty of *Back to the Future*, Dan Harmon's naturalised monomyth (the Story Circle), and the Menippean genre whose carnivalesque body interrupts the logos of nihilism at the level of the belch — the *eructative caesura*. Part II analyses the series' cosmology as an instance of Hegel's bad infinite and its epistemology as governed by an *algetic criterion*, under which pain alone certifies the real; it identifies a *double horror* in which purposelessness and purpose (the Meeseeks, the Butter Robot) prove equally unbearable, foreclosing teleology as a remedy for nihilism. Part III reads Rick as a *Saturnine demiurge* assembled from Prometheus, Silenus, Kronos, Faust's Mephistopheles inverted, the trickster, the Gnostic Yaldabaoth, and an anti-Quixote, and reads Morty —

whose name the series' own titling persistently fuses with *mort* — as the principle of finitude. Part IV develops the theory of melancholic cosmogony through Freud, Abraham and Torok, the *Oresteia*, *Solaris*, and *Gilgamesh*, and proposes in response an *ethics of thisness*: a *practical haecceity* in which value, in a world of infinite substitutability, is not discovered as metaphysical uniqueness but conferred and sustained through finite, attentive, repeatable acts of keeping. Part V examines the reception of the series as a site where its argument is enacted and betrayed (the *Smerdyakov problem*), and situates it within a sapiential lineage — the *Siduri tradition* running from the alewife's counsel in *Gilgamesh* through Qoheleth and *Candide* — and within the multiversal turn of contemporary speculative fiction.

The dissertation concludes that the series articulates a *comic finitism*: meaning resides neither in the One of sovereign intellect nor in the Many of the multiverse, but in the conjunction of its title — the finite dyad that binds a would-be immortal intelligence to a name homophonous with death. Its contributions are threefold: a reframing of popular nihilism as grief-work; a constructive ethics adequate to multiversal ontology; and a typology of multiverse fiction organised by its response to the bad infinite.



PRELIMINARIES

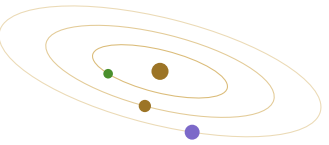
Note on Corpus, Citation, and Translation

Corpus. The primary corpus comprises the seventy-one episodes of Seasons 1–7 (December 2013 – December 2023). The delimitation is principled rather than archival: it spans the inauguration of the dyad, the full arc of the revenge narrative through its consummation in the seventh season, and the first season produced after Adult Swim ended its association with Justin Roiland in January 2023 (§1.7), when the title roles were recast. Later seasons, the series' comics, and its spin-offs (among them *Rick and Morty: The Anime*, 2024) belong to a post-revenge phase that merits separate treatment and are cited, where at all, as paratext. The secondary corpus comprises Justin Roiland's short *The Real Animated Adventures of Doc and Mharti* (2006), produced for the Channel 101 festival, and Dan Harmon's earlier work in network comedy, principally *Community* (NBC, 2009–2015).

Citation of episodes. Episodes are cited by season, episode, and title, e.g. (S1E8, "Rixty Minutes"). Quotation from the series is held to a strict minimum; the argument proceeds chiefly by paraphrase and structural description, quoting only where exact wording bears analytic weight.

Philosophical and literary sources. Works are cited by author, title, and date of first publication, with standard internal references (Stephanus, Bekker, section, or line numbers) where these exist. Translations from Greek, Latin, French, German, and Danish are the author's own or follow standard renderings; key terms are given in the original at first appearance. A selected bibliography follows the Conclusion.

Coinages. Terms introduced by this dissertation are italicised at first appearance and defined in the Conceptual Lexicon. Where a resonance between the series and an earlier text is structural or onomastic rather than demonstrably intentional, it is presented as such; the method is interpretive, not attributive, and makes no claim about the authors' reading.



PRELIMINARIES

Conceptual Lexicon

The following terms are introduced or repurposed by this dissertation. Each is developed in the chapter indicated.

Melancholic cosmogony CH. 7

A cosmos whose structure is generated, narratively and psychically, as the externalisation of an unmourned singular loss; the shape of a grief that refuses to end.

Consolation of plurality CH. 3

The defensive use of multiplicity to neutralise singular loss: if every person and world is reproduced elsewhere, no loss is absolute. After Boethius.

Omega event CH. 7

The collapse of the consolation of plurality when a loss is shown to be singular across all worlds, so that substitution itself is annihilated.

Narcissistic curvature (Yaldabaoth complex) CH. 5, 7

The curation of an infinite cosmos into a bounded region in which the subject remains supreme; named for the Gnostic demiurge whose boast of uniqueness depends upon his ignorance of what lies beyond him.

Algetic criterion CH. 4

The epistemic rule under which pain, harm, or negative memory alone certifies the reality of an object or person (Greek *algos*, pain).

Double horror CH. 4

The series' twin refusal of purposelessness and of purpose-saturation, which forecloses the restoration of telos as a remedy for nihilism.

Eructative caesura CH. 2

The belch that punctuates Rick's speech, read as a counter-rhythmic interruption in which the suffering, self-medicating body discloses itself through the voice of sovereign reason.

Anti-Quixotism CH. 5

The inversion of Cervantes' knight: where Quixote enchants a disenchanted world, Rick disenchants a world saturated with wonders.

Mortification (dyadic) CH. 5, 8

The becoming-Morty of Rick — at once humiliation, the mortification of the ego in the ascetic sense, and the alchemical *mortificatio* — paired with the corresponding Rickification of Morty.

Counterfeit repetition CH. 8

The substitution of a variant for a lost original (a replacement world, family, or self), mistaken for the recovery Kierkegaard calls repetition.

Practical haecceity CH. 8

Thisness conferred and sustained by care, attention, and fidelity rather than guaranteed by metaphysics; the core of the ethics of thisness.

Comic finitism CH. 8, Conclusion

The philosophical position the series articulates: no cosmic telos, no salvation in purpose, value constituted in finite acts of keeping, and comedy as the form in which finitude is acknowledged.

Siduri tradition

CH. 10

The sapiential counsel that answers cosmic futility with finite domestic practice, from the alewife in *Gilgamesh* through Qoheleth and *Candide* to Morty.

Smerdyakov problem

CH. 9

The reception pattern in which a text's critique of a worldview is consumed as endorsement of it, after the disciple in *The Brothers Karamazov* who enacts Ivan's nihilism.



INTRODUCTION

Nobody Exists on Purpose

The Cosmic Sitcom and the Problem of Received Nihilism

Visible nature is all plasticity and indifference, — a moral multiverse, as one might call it, and not a moral universe.

— William James, "Is Life Worth Living?" (1895)

Le silence éternel de ces espaces infinis m'effraie.

— Blaise Pascal, *Pensées* (1670)

0.1

The Received Reading

Few works of twenty-first-century popular culture have been so swiftly or so confidently assigned a philosophy as *Rick and Morty*. The assignment runs as follows. Rick Sanchez, a scientist of unlimited competence and negligible scruple, has seen enough of an infinite multiverse to know that no person, world, or attachment is unique; every Morty is one Morty among infinitely many, every catastrophe is locally contingent and globally irrelevant, and the only rational postures are cynicism, intoxication, and play.

The series' most quoted line, spoken by Morty to his sister Summer in its first season, is taken as the creed of this worldview: "Nobody exists on purpose. Nobody belongs anywhere. Everybody's gonna die. Come watch TV" (S1E8, "Rixty Minutes"). Fan culture has largely adopted Rick as an aspirational figure of disenchanted intelligence; the philosophy-and-popular-culture literature, exemplified by the collection edited by Abesamis and Yuen (2019), has more carefully but no less consistently read the series as a staging-ground for nihilism, absurdism, and existentialism, treating its episodes as illustrations of positions already worked out by Nietzsche, Camus, or Sartre.

This reading is not wrong so much as it is ordered wrongly. It rests upon a presupposition that may be called *cosmological foundationalism*: the assumption that the series' cosmology is the ground of its characters' attitudes, such that the argument runs from metaphysics to affect. The multiverse is infinite; therefore every individual is replaceable; therefore nothing matters; therefore one drinks, mocks, and diverts oneself. On this account Rick is a philosopher who has drawn the correct conclusion from the correct premises, and his misery is merely the emotional cost of lucidity, the Pascalian vertigo of one who has looked too long at the infinite spaces. The series is then a comic tract, and its sentiment — the moments at which Rick sacrifices himself, weeps, or attempts to end his life — is either an inconsistency, a concession to the conventions of televisual melodrama, or a bait-and-switch that the ironic viewer is trained to see through.

Not every critic has read the series this way. Reviewing the second season's finale in 2015, David Sims argued in *The Atlantic* that the series' biggest twist was that it had a heart: the season had allowed Rick, little by little, to acquire a conscience while keeping the show's black comedy intact, so that his act of self-sacrifice at its close was the greatest surprise a show this dark could offer. This dissertation gives that intuition a theory. It argues that the heart is not a late addition to the cosmology but its cause.

0.2

The Inversion

This dissertation reverses the order of grounding. Its central claim is that the cosmology of *Rick and Morty* is not the premise of Rick's nihilism but its product: the multiverse, as the series ultimately configures it, is a *melancholic cosmogony*, the cosmological externalisation of a loss that has not been mourned. The evidence for this inversion is not imported from outside the text; it is supplied by the series itself, which over a decade progressively rewrites the genealogy of its own cosmos. The fifth-season finale (S5E10, "Rickmurai Jack") discloses that Rick's mastery of interdimensional travel was perfected not out of curiosity but as an instrument of vengeance, after a variant of himself — later designated Rick Prime — murdered his wife Diane and their young daughter Beth. The same episode reveals that

the "infinite" multiverse through which Rick and his counterparts move is in fact a curated enclosure, the Central Finite Curve, walled off from the true infinite so as to contain only those realities in which Rick is the most intelligent being. Rick's residence with the Smith family is itself disclosed as a substitution: he installed himself in the household of a Beth whose own Rick had abandoned her, and that household was in turn abandoned to catastrophe and exchanged for another in the first season (S1E6, "Rick Potion #9"). The family at the centre of the sitcom is thus the substitute of a substitute.

Read in the light of these disclosures, the series' metaphysics of replaceability acquires a function that cosmological foundationalism cannot see. The doctrine that nothing is unique protects against the unbearable uniqueness of the dead. If every person exists infinitely, no death is final; if every world can be exchanged for another, no catastrophe is irreparable; if every attachment is one instance of a type, no loss is a loss of *this*. The dissertation names this defensive structure the *consolation of plurality*, after Boethius, whose imprisoned narrator is consoled by Philosophy's demonstration that the goods of Fortune were never truly his. Rick's consolation is the inverse of Boethius's: not that what was lost was never one's own, but that what was lost exists elsewhere in infinite supply. Its collapse — which the dissertation calls the *Omega event* — arrives in the seventh season, when the series reveals that the singular loss at the origin of Rick's cosmos cannot be redeemed by substitution at all. At that point the consolation of plurality fails, the revenge narrative is consummated and found empty, and the question that cosmological foundationalism could never pose becomes the series' explicit subject: what does one owe, and what can one love, in a cosmos that has stopped pretending to console?

There is a lexical irony at the origin of this problem that the series never mentions but everywhere enacts. The earliest widely cited philosophical use of the word *multiverse* occurs in William James's address "Is Life Worth Living?", delivered in 1895 and collected in *The Will to Believe* (1897). James coined it not as a term of physics but as a term of ethics: nature, observed without faith, is "a moral multiverse" rather than a moral universe — plastic, indifferent, incapable of underwriting any human valuation. The address was written for young men tempted by pessimism and by the thought of self-destruction, and its answer was neither a proof nor a theodicy but a pragmatic wager: that belief in the worth of life helps to create the fact it believes. The multiverse, then, entered philosophical English as the name of moral indifference, in an essay whose subject was whether one should go on living and whose conclusion was that value is partly made by the commitments that affirm it. *Rick and Morty* restages James's argument in the idiom of animated science fiction. Its multiverse is James's moral multiverse rendered literal; its question is James's question, posed by an alcoholic genius rather than a melancholy undergraduate; and its answer, this dissertation argues, is a secular, comic, and finite version of James's — an *ethics of thisness* in which value is not discovered in the cosmos but conferred upon particulars through the practice of keeping them.

0.3

Registers of the Argument

The argument proceeds in five registers, corresponding to the five parts of the dissertation.

The first is *formal and genealogical*. A philosophy enacted in narrative is carried as much by form as by statement, and the series' form argues against the doctrines its protagonist pronounces. Part I traces the series' generic and authorial formation — its birth as a travesty, Harmon's naturalised monomyth, its improvisational generativity — and identifies it as a modern instance of Menippean satire, the ancient genre that tests ideas through fantastic voyages and carnivalesque bodies. Within that genre, the series' most persistent formal signature, the belch that interrupts Rick's speech, is read as a counter-rhythmic disclosure of the suffering body beneath the voice of sovereign reason.

The second is *cosmological and epistemological*. Part II analyses the multiverse through the history of the principle of plenitude, Leibniz's palace of possible worlds, Lewis's modal realism, and Hegel's distinction between the spurious and the genuine infinite. It then examines the series' epistemology — its simulations, implanted memories, decoys, clones, and harvested consciousnesses — and identifies the *algetic criterion*, the rule under which only pain certifies the real. It argues further that the series stages a *double horror*: purposeless existence and purpose-saturated existence are rendered as equally unbearable, which forecloses the classical remedy for nihilism, the restoration of telos.

The third is *figural and mythographic*. Part III reads Rick as a composite archetype assembled from the mythic and philosophical archive — Prometheus, Silenus, Saturn, the trickster, Mephistopheles inverted, the Gnostic demiurge, an anti-Quixote — and reads Morty as the figure of finitude: the instrument who becomes an agent, the sidekick who becomes the bearer of the series' ethics, and the name that the series' own titling persistently fuses with *mort*.

The fourth is *psychoanalytic and ethical*. Part IV constitutes the theoretical core. It develops the theory of melancholic cosmogony through Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia", Abraham and Torok's account of incorporation and the psychic crypt, Aeschylus's *Oresteia*, Lem's *Solaris*, and the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, and then constructs the ethics of thisness through Duns Scotus's *haecceitas*, Heidegger's *Sorge*, Hägglund's account of finitude as the condition of care, Levinas's ethical infinite, Murdoch's attention, Cavell's acknowledgment, Kierkegaard's repetition, and Badiou's scene of the Two. Its interpretive crux is the *Rixty Minutes* maxim, reread as a performative of co-presence rather than a constative of despair.

The fifth is *reception-historical and comparative*. Part V examines the series' reception as a site where its argument is both enacted and betrayed, and locates it within two lineages: the ancient sapiential counsel that answers futility with the hearth, and the contemporary

multiversal turn in speculative fiction, from *Dark* and *Everything Everywhere All at Once* to the *Spider-Verse* films and *Loki*.

0.4

Method

Four methodological commitments govern the analysis.

First, the series is treated as philosophising rather than as illustrating philosophy. Following Martha Nussbaum's argument in *Love's Knowledge* (1990) that certain truths about human life are expressible only in narrative form, and Stanley Cavell's and Stephen Mulhall's treatments of film as a medium capable of philosophical thought in its own right, the dissertation assumes that *Rick and Morty* does not merely depict positions but reasons through them, often against the explicit propositions its characters advance. A comedy is not an essay, and the meaning of a nihilistic monologue interrupted by a belch, followed by a cut, and resolved by a sacrifice is not the meaning of the monologue alone.

Second, the dissertation practises a *symptomatic* reading in the tradition of Althusser's *lecture symptomale* and Jameson's *The Political Unconscious* (1981), with one decisive displacement: the object of symptomatic reading is not ideology but cosmology. The question is not only what the series says about the structure of reality, but what work that structure performs for the subject who inhabits it. Cosmology is read as one reads a dream, as a compromise between a wish and a defence.

Third, the analysis draws on structuralist mythography. Claude Lévi-Strauss proposed in "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) that a myth consists of all its versions, so that no single telling is original and the myth is the set of its variants. The Citadel of Ricks — a society composed entirely of variants of a single figure — literalises this dictum with almost uncanny precision. Rick is a myth in Lévi-Strauss's sense: there is no "real" Rick, only the system of his transformations. The method is accordingly comparative and transformational, attentive to how the series rearranges inherited mythemes (the mentor and apprentice, the fire-thief, the devouring father, the guide through the underworld) rather than to sources alone.

Fourth, the comparative method distinguishes three relations between the series and earlier texts: documented allusion (the episode titles that cite *Solaris*, *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind*, or *Defending Your Life*; the derivation of the Story Circle from Joseph Campbell); generic inheritance (the Menippean tradition from Lucian to Douglas Adams); and structural resonance, where a parallel illuminates without any claim of influence (Siduri's counsel in *Gilgamesh*, Giordano Bruno's Actaeon and Diana). The third category is the most speculative and is marked as such; its justification is heuristic,

in that it allows the series to be heard as one voice in a conversation much older than television.

0.5

Contributions and Plan

The dissertation makes three contributions. To the philosophy of popular culture, it offers a reading in which the series' nihilism is not a doctrine to be evaluated but a symptom to be interpreted — grief-work mistaken, by its protagonist and many of its viewers, for metaphysics. To ethics, it proposes *practical haecceity* as a constructive account of value adequate to a multiversal ontology, in which the uniqueness that metaphysics can no longer guarantee is supplied by fidelity. To narrative theory and media studies, it offers a typology of multiverse fiction organised by its response to the bad infinite — theodicean, restorative, consolatory, and haecceitic — and situates *Rick and Morty* as the most corrosive and least sentimental instance of the last.

Chapter 1 reconstructs the series' genealogy from Channel 101, Campbell's monomyth, and *Community*. Chapter 2 identifies its genre as Menippean satire and analyses the carnivalesque body and the eructative caesura. Chapter 3 reads the multiverse as Hegel's bad infinite and theorises the consolation of plurality. Chapter 4 examines the series' simulacra, the algetic criterion, and the double horror of purpose. Chapter 5 reads Rick as a Saturnine demiurge. Chapter 6 reads Morty as mortality and the Smith household as a polis of remainders. Chapter 7 develops the theory of melancholic cosmogony. Chapter 8 constructs the ethics of thisness and resolves the *Rixty Minutes* crux. Chapter 9 examines reception through the Smerdyakov problem. Chapter 10 situates the series within the Siduri tradition and the multiversal turn. The Conclusion formulates the series' philosophy as a comic finitism.

PART

I



Formations

1 *Genealogies of a Multiverse*
2 *The Menippean Machine*

Part I reconstructs the conditions under which the series' philosophy took shape. Chapter 1 is genealogical: it traces the dyad, the multiverse, and the series' narrative grammar to their origins in travesty, in an institutional economy of disposable pilots, in a naturalised monomyth, and in the long prehistory of the many-worlds imagination. Chapter 2 is generic: it identifies the series as a modern Menippean satire and shows how that genre, by testing ideas upon bodies, falsifies the doctrine its protagonist professes.



CHAPTER ONE

PART I · FORMATIONS

Genealogies of a Multiverse

Channel 101, the Monomyth, and the Author Function

> *We are unknown to ourselves, we knowers, we ourselves to ourselves — and with good reason.*
>
> — Friedrich Nietzsche, *On the Genealogy of Morality*, Preface §1 (1887)

Every cosmology has a genealogy, and the genealogy of the *Rick and Morty* multiverse is not, in the first instance, scientific. It is generic, institutional, and authorial. This chapter advances three theses. First, the dyad of Rick and Morty originates in an act of travesty that exposes the mentor's authority as a technique of domination, so that the series' central ethical question — what the genius owes the boy he uses — is coeval with its form rather than a sentimental accretion of its later seasons. Second, the multiverse is the cosmology of seriality: a narrative technology developed to manage continuity and difference across serial fiction, inherited by the series through an institutional ecology in which worlds were literally disposable, and recapitulated in its metaphysics of replaceability. Third, the series' narrative grammar, Dan Harmon's Story Circle, is a naturalised monomyth whose law of price and change stands in permanent tension with the sitcom's law of reset; that formal antagonism is the earliest and most durable shape of the philosophical antagonism, between nihilism and care, traced through the remainder of the dissertation.

1.1

Travesty as Origin: Doc and Mharti

In 2006 Justin Roiland produced for Channel 101 a short entitled *The Real Animated Adventures of Doc and Mharti*, a deliberately crude animated travesty of Robert Zemeckis and Bob Gale's *Back to the Future* (1985). The term is used in Gérard Genette's technical sense. *Palimpsests* (1982) maps the field of hypertextuality — the relation by which a text (the hypertext) derives from an anterior text (the hypotext) — along two axes: imitation versus transformation, and the playful versus the satirical versus the serious regime. Parody is playful transformation; travesty is satirical transformation, whose classical model is Scarron's *Virgile travesti* (1648–1653), which preserves the action of the *Aeneid* while degrading its style and its motives. *Doc and Mharti* preserves the action-frame of its hypotext — an eccentric scientist, a teenage companion, a machine, a crisis that must be averted — and degrades its motive: the adult Doc figure fabricates pseudo-scientific emergencies in order to coerce the Mharti figure, a parody of the teenage Marty McFly, into performing a sexual act on him. The short is puerile by design, and its interest lies not in its wit but in its diagnosis. *Back to the Future* never explains why a reclusive middle-aged physicist and a suburban adolescent should be intimates; the friendship is a premise of the genre, not an object of its attention. Roiland's travesty answers the question the hypotext declines to ask — what does the old man want from the boy? — and its answer is sexual coercion under cover of science. The travesty reads the unexplained intimacy between an adult and a teenager as having the structure of abuse: authority, a fabricated necessity, and compliance extracted from the younger party.

The series retained the dyad and the diagnosis while removing the sexual content: the pair were renamed and made kin, and what the series kept is the structure the travesty had exposed — the fabricated emergency, the mentor's authority, the use of the boy. Its pilot opens in darkness, with an intoxicated Rick hauling Morty from sleep to announce a plan to annihilate the Earth with a neutrino bomb so that the two of them might begin again, with the girl Morty desires, from a "fresh start"; the plan is abandoned as abruptly as it is proposed. The series' first image is thus a cosmogonic wish — the destruction of a world for the sake of its replacement, conceived by a demiurge and imposed upon a boy. Before the first season ends, the dyad receives its institutional rationale. In `S1E10` ("Close Rick-counters of the Rick Kind") it is established that a Morty's brainwaves mask a Rick's genius from his enemies: within the economy of the multiverse, Mortys are camouflage. In the vocabulary of Heidegger's "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954), the boy is *Bestand*, standing-reserve, the human being enframed as resource. The dyad is founded upon the instrumentalisation of the boy, and the whole subsequent arc of the series may be described as the slow, contested, and never completed application to it of Kant's formula of human-

ity — that rational nature be treated always also as an end and never merely as a means (*Groundwork* 4:429). That Morty is never merely a means is the proposition the series takes seven seasons to earn, and does not wholly earn.

The travesty belongs to a lineage. Mentor and apprentice compose one of the oldest dyads in the Western archive. The word *mentor* derives from the *Odyssey*, in which Athena, in the likeness of Mentor, guides Telemachus in search of his absent father (books II–III); the centaur Chiron educates Achilles, Asclepius, and Jason; Merlin fosters Arthur. Beside these pedagogical idylls runs a darker strand. In Lucian's *Philopseudes* (c. 150 CE), Eucrates recounts how he overheard the incantation by which the Egyptian sage Pancrates animated a pestle to fetch water, used it in the master's absence, found that he could not make it stop, and split it in two — whereupon both halves fetched water. The tale passes through Goethe's ballad "Der Zauberlehrling" (1797), in which the apprentice's axe produces two brooms where there had been one, and Paul Dukas's symphonic scherzo (1897), into twentieth-century animation. Its structure is exact: the master's power, used by the uninitiated, does not merely run amok; it *multiplies*. The apprentice's error is a proliferation of servants. *Rick and Morty* restages the tale with a precision that appears not to have been remarked. In S1E5 ("Meeseeks and Destroy") Rick leaves his family a box that summons Mr. Meeseeks, a servant who exists only until he has completed a single assigned task. Jerry, the household's least competent member, assigns a task that cannot be completed — to improve his golf game — and the Meeseeks, unable to cease existing, summon further Meeseeks, who proliferate and turn violent. The apprentice's error multiplies the servant; the servant's agony is the pain of not being permitted to end. The Meeseeks are the sorcerer's brooms endowed with a phenomenology, and that phenomenology, Chapter 4 argues, is among the series' most exact statements of the horror of purpose.

Two further variants complete the lineage. In Goethe's *Faust*, the famulus Wagner — pedant, disciple, Faust's diminished double — is the figure who, in the second act of Part II, produces the Homunculus, an intelligence in a phial that longs for a body and finally shatters itself against the shell-chariot of Galatea in the Aegean: the apprentice of the speculative intellect creates a being who suffers from want of the world. *Doctor Who* (1963–) secularised the dyad for television: an ancient and morally equivocal time traveller who requires a human companion, and whose revived series made explicit that the companion's function is ethical as much as narrative, since the Doctor must travel with someone able to stop him. *Rick and Morty* is the most corrosive of these variants because it removes the mentor's benevolence while preserving his indispensability. Rick is Mentor without Athena, Chiron without *paideia*, the Doctor without either of his hearts.

1.2

The Scientist and the Boy: An American Myth and Its Travesties

The hypotext Roiland chose was not arbitrary. *Back to the Future* is a late flowering of an American myth, that of the paternal scientist and the boy adventurer, whose history runs from the Stratemeyer Syndicate's *Tom Swift* novels (from 1910), in which a boy inventor converts technical ingenuity into personal and national triumph, through Hanna-Barbera's *Jonny Quest* (1964–1965), in which a widowed government scientist takes his son around the world on missions of Cold War science, to Doc Brown, the crank in the garage whose plutonium-powered machine restores a suburban family's fortunes. The myth's ideological content is legible: science as an extension of paternal care, technology as the son's inheritance, the frontier relocated from the West to the laboratory. Its affective content is a techno-pastoral in which the father's absorption in his work is redeemed by the adventures it makes possible for the son.

Adult Swim, the late-night programming block on which *Rick and Morty* premiered, made a practice of travestying this myth. Jackson Publick and Doc Hammer's *The Venture Bros.* (2003–2018) imagines Jonny Quest grown into Dr. Rusty Venture, a failed and chemically dependent super-scientist scarred by a childhood of adventures, raising two sons who are revealed to have died many times and been silently replaced by clones carrying their memories. Matt Groening's *Futurama* (1999–) paired a senile and amoral scientist, Professor Farnsworth, with his dim-witted distant relative Fry, and anticipated much of the multiversal grammar *Rick and Morty* would adopt: "The Farnsworth Parabox" (2003) stores parallel universes in cardboard boxes, distinguished from one another by the outcomes of coin tosses, and "The Late Philip J. Fry" (2010) returns its travellers, after a complete cycle of cosmic death and rebirth, to a universe all but indistinguishable from the one they left. In both series the mentor's neglect becomes the son's expendability, and the clone or the counterpart becomes the instrument of a reset that leaves no one to mourn. *Rick and Morty* inherits both devices and radicalises them by relocating the mad scientist into the genre best equipped to register their cost.

That genre is the domestic sitcom. From *The Honeymooners* (1955–1956) through *All in the Family* (1971–1979) to *The Simpsons* (1989–), the sitcom organises its world around the dwelling and the dinner table, and its ontology is conservative in the strict sense: whatever happens, the household returns. *Rick and Morty* installs a Faustian genius in the garage of such a household and opens a portal there. The garage is the series' threshold-space, the point at which the hearth abuts the infinite; it belongs to the house without belonging to the home, as Rick belongs to the family without consenting to be of it. The series' hybrid form is therefore not a pastiche of two genres but the staging of their collision: the genre of the reset and the genre of transgression share a single set of rooms. The mad-scientist

lineage it draws upon was shadowed from the first by abandonment and grief — Victor Frankenstein animates a being and abandons it (1818); Wells's Moreau vivisects animals into men (1896); Rotwang, in Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927), builds his machine-woman to replace the beloved he lost — and *Back to the Future* had domesticated it, converting the mad scientist into a lovable crank. *Rick and Morty* re-darkens the lineage without expelling it from the domestic, and so produces its most characteristic image: the abyss in the garage.

1.3

Channel 101 and the Ecology of the Pilot

The institutional matrix in which the dyad was born had its own philosophy of worlds. Channel 101, the monthly short-film festival that Dan Harmon and Rob Schrab founded in Los Angeles in the early 2000s, operated as a selection environment: filmmakers screened pilots of no more than five minutes; the audience voted; the five most popular returned the following month as continuing series, and the rest were cancelled. Every pilot was a world brought into being under sentence of cancellation, its continuance dependent entirely upon the attention of spectators. The festival was, in effect, a multiverse of disposable worlds governed by a market in attention — a Darwinian theatre whose unit of selection was the premise.

Roiland's Channel 101 work bears the marks of this ecology. Before *Doc and Mharti* he produced *House of Cosbys* (2005), whose premise — a man who clones a celebrity repeatedly, each clone distinguished by a single trait — anticipates with some exactness the logic of the Citadel of Ricks, where a single figure is serialised into a society of variants, each identified by a gimmick: Cop Rick, Simple Rick, Doofus Rick. The short series was discontinued after legal objection from its subject's representatives. Serial variation of a single iconic figure, with the clone as the comic unit of difference: the Citadel was born in a Channel 101 sketch.

The ecology reappears within the diegesis. In "Rixty Minutes" (S1E8) and "Interdimensional Cable 2: Tempting Fate" (S2E8) Rick modifies the family television to receive broadcasts from every reality, and the episodes dissolve into strings of micro-programmes — commercials, talk shows, procedurals from other worlds — largely improvised in performance. Interdimensional cable is Channel 101 rendered as cosmology: an infinite lineup of pilots, each a world, each persisting only so long as someone watches. Raymond Williams argued in *Television: Technology and Cultural Form* (1974) that the defining experience of broadcast television is not the discrete programme but *flow*, the planned sequence in which units succeed one another without closure. The multiverse of *Rick and Morty* is flow raised to an ontology. Its worlds succeed one another like channels; its characters, like viewers, may always change the station; and the injunction that ends Morty's maxim — come watch

TV — invites the listener into precisely the infinite flow from which the maxim's first three clauses derive. The genealogical point anticipates an analytic one (Chapter 3): the metaphysics of replaceability that Rick professes recapitulates the conditions of the medium that produced him. A cosmology in which every world is disposable was first an institution in which every pilot was.

1.4

The Naturalised Monomyth

If Roiland's contribution to the series' genealogy is travesty and improvised flow, Harmon's is a theory of narrative form. The Story Circle, which Harmon developed in the course of his Channel 101 work and disseminated through his own tutorials, compresses Joseph Campbell's monomyth into eight steps: a character is in a zone of comfort (*you*); but wants something (*need*); enters an unfamiliar situation (*go*); adapts to it (*search*); gets what was wanted (*find*); pays a heavy price for it (*take*); returns to the familiar situation (*return*); having changed (*change*). A horizontal axis divides the circle into an upper hemisphere of order, consciousness, and the known and a lower hemisphere of chaos, the unconscious, and the unknown: the character descends at the third step, reaches the nadir at the fifth, and resurfaces at the seventh. Harmon presents the shape not as a convention but as a rhythm common to ritual, dream, and organic life — waking and sleeping, the seasons, birth and death.

Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949), which borrowed the word *monomyth* from Joyce's *Finnegans Wake*, fused Arnold van Gennep's tripartite structure of the rite of passage (*Les rites de passage*, 1909: separation, margin, aggregation), Jungian archetypal psychology, and the comparative mythography of Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890) into a seventeen-stage itinerary of departure, initiation, and return. The itinerary carried a metaphysics. Its summits — the meeting with the goddess, the atonement with the father, the apotheosis, the ultimate boon — enact the identification of the individual with the ground of being, and the hero returns as master of the two worlds because he has learned that they are one: an Upanishadic monism legible beneath the comparative apparatus. Christopher Vogler's studio memorandum of 1985, expanded as *The Writer's Journey* (1992), converted the itinerary into a twelve-stage screenwriting template; Harmon's circle compresses it again.

What the compression removes is as significant as what it keeps. The circle retains descent and return, the threshold, and the price; it discards the goddess, the father, and the apotheosis. Where Campbell's nadir is a mystical encounter, Harmon's is the acquisition of the desired object; where Campbell's return confers mastery of two worlds, Harmon's confers only change. The monomyth is naturalised — its transcendence withdrawn and its

structure retained, as Feuerbach withdrew God from Christianity and retained the divine predicates (*Das Wesen des Christentums*, 1841). What remains is a secular grammar with a residual ethics. The circle insists that nothing is obtained without cost (the sixth step) and that no one returns unchanged (the eighth). It is, in miniature, a theodicy of narrative consequence: desire is permitted, but it is always paid for, and the payment leaves a mark.

The correspondences among the three systems are summarised below. The alignment of Harmon's steps with Campbell's stages and van Gennep's phases is the present author's reconstruction; the final column reads "Rick Potion #9" (S1E6) through the circle, in anticipation of §1.5.

Story Circle (Harmon)	Monomyth (Campbell, 1949)	Rite of passage (van Gennep, 1909)	"Rick Potion #9" (S1E6)
1. You — a zone of comfort	The ordinary world, prior to the call	Pre-liminal	Morty at school, infatuated with Jessica
2. Need — but they want something	Call to adventure	Separation	Morty asks Rick for a love serum
3. Go — enter an unfamiliar situation	Crossing of the first threshold; belly of the whale	Separation into margin	The serum is administered at the school's Flu Season Dance
4. Search — adapt to it	Road of trials	Margin (liminality)	The serum, combining with the flu virus, spreads beyond its object
5. Find — get what they wanted	Meeting with the goddess	Margin (nadir)	Morty is desired — by everyone, and monstrously
6. Take — pay a heavy price	Atonement with the father; the ultimate boon	Margin	Rick's antidotes compound the catastrophe until humanity is "Cronenberged"
7. Return — to the familiar situation	Crossing of the return threshold	Aggregation	Rick and Morty migrate to a near-identical world whose Rick and Morty have just died
8. Change — having changed	Master of the two worlds	Post-liminal	Morty buries his own corpse; the trauma is the only thing that does not reset

The table discloses the episode's argument in its seventh row. The return is accomplished not by reversal but by substitution: the familiar situation is not restored but replaced.

1.5

The Circle and the Reset

The sitcom is a genre with an ontology. In its classical network form, an episode ends where it began: whatever the adventures of the week, the household returns to its status quo ante, and its members, who seldom remember, are restored to the condition from which the next departure will proceed. The reset is a formal amnesia and, as such, a formal nihilism: nothing that happens matters, because nothing that happens is retained. It is also a secular image of the eternal recurrence of the same. In *The Gay Science* §341 (1882) Nietzsche imagines a demon who announces that one's life will return, identical in every detail, innumerable times; the thought is either the heaviest of weights or the occasion of the highest affirmation, according to whether one can will it. The sitcom lives the recurrence without the willing. Its characters return without knowing that they return, and the burden of the eternal return — the demand that each moment be such that one could affirm its infinite repetition — falls on no one.

Harmon's circle and the sitcom's reset encode incompatible temporalities: return with change and return without it. The series' most consequential formal achievement in its first season is to stage the incompatibility and to resolve it in a manner that exposes the reset's hidden cost. In "Rick Potion #9" the familiar situation cannot be restored, because Rick's interventions have rendered the Earth irreparable. The sitcom requires a return; the series supplies one by substitution. Rick locates a reality in which his and Morty's counterparts have solved the crisis and then died in an accident, and the two of them take their places, burying their own corpses in the backyard of a house that is not quite theirs, among a family that will never know. The status quo ante is achieved and the reset has occurred. But the episode shows what every reset conceals: the world left behind to its catastrophe, the dead doubles, and the one who remembers. Morty's change — the circle's eighth step — is trauma, and trauma is the single thing that does not reset. The sitcom's amnesia is broken at exactly one point: the memory of the boy who knows what the return cost.

The series returned to the scene five seasons later. In "Solaricks" (S6E1) a malfunction of the portals sends every traveller back to the world of their origin, and Morty finds himself in the ruined world he and Rick abandoned; the episode's writer, Albro Lundy, and Harmon have described his return there as a punishment for the callousness with which the two had jumped between dimensions. There he finds the father he left behind, who has lost his wife and daughter and taken up a Rick-like nihilism, and who, in Harmon's account in the same featurette, is the instrument of the punishment. The abandoned remainder repeats in miniature the genealogy this dissertation traces in Rick: the loss of a wife and a daughter, then a philosophy. The episode ends with the whole family, displaced again, burying its own doubles in the backyard of yet another replacement world. What the first season played

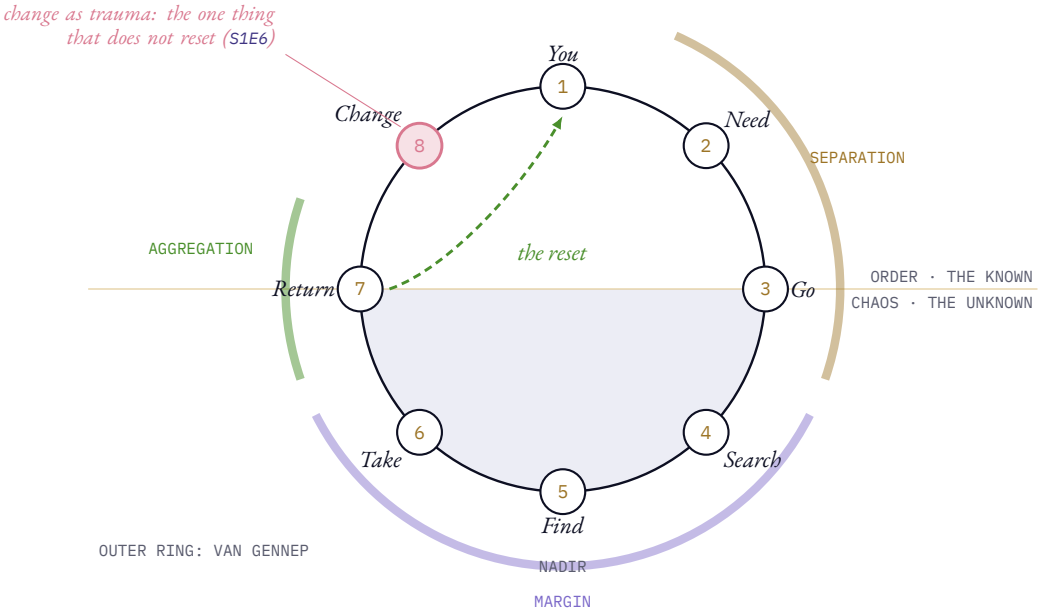


FIG.1.1 *Harmon's Story Circle, with van Gennep's phases on the outer ring. The sitcom reset (dashed) returns to step 1 without passing through step 8. In "Rick Potion #9" the familiar situation is restored by substitution, and only Morty's change survives the return.*

as horror the sixth plays almost as routine, and Marx's observation that history repeats itself, first as tragedy and then as farce, acquires a sitcom corollary: the reset, repeated, becomes a habit. Chapter 8 argues that the farce carries an ethics the tragedy could not.

The episode thereby discloses a structural truth about the genre of which it is an instance. Every sitcom reset is a tacit migration between worlds: next week's household resembles this week's, but whatever happened in this week's has been consigned to oblivion, and its consequences, in strict logic, persist somewhere the camera does not go. "Rick Potion #9" renders explicit the many-worlds metaphysics latent in the sitcom and attaches a body count to it. It is also, in germ, the first appearance of the figure Chapter 8 names *counterfeit repetition*: the substitution of a variant for a lost original, mistaken for its recovery. Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) distinguishes recollection, which repeats backward what has been, from repetition, which receives the same anew and forward; the reset is neither, but a simulation of continuity purchased by exchanging what was lost for its double.

From this point the series' relation to its own seriality becomes a philosophical index. Episodic form, which permits every adventure to be forgotten, is the form of the reset and so of Rick's nihilism; serial form, which obliges consequences to persist, is the form of memory and so of grief. The series' gradual turn toward seriality — the return of Evil Morty in "The Ricklantis Mixup" (S3E7), the disclosures of "Rickmurai Jack" (S5E10), the revenge arc consummated in "Unmortricken" (S7E5) — is accompanied, characteristically, by Rick's

derision of "canon" and continuity, which becomes an explicit object of comedy in "Never Ricking Morty" (S4E6), an episode set aboard a train of nested anthology stories whose antagonist seeks to harness narrative itself as a source of power. Its title's hypotext, *The NeverEnding Story* (Michael Ende's *Die unendliche Geschichte*, 1979; Wolfgang Petersen's film, 1984), is the paradigmatic tale of a reader drawn into the story he reads. On the reading advanced here, Rick's contempt for continuity is of a piece with his resistance to mourning. Mourning is serial work: it requires that what happened remain what happened. To prefer the anthology to the saga is to prefer a world in which nothing need be carried forward.

1.6

Genealogies of the Many

The multiverse the series inherited was already a composite artefact, assembled from four traditions — speculative fiction, quantum physics, serial publishing, and network television — each of which contributed a distinct function.

The literary prehistory precedes the physics. Jorge Luis Borges's "El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan" (1941) imagines a novel by the scholar Ts'ui Pên in which, at each juncture, a character chooses not one alternative but all of them, so that the book becomes a labyrinth of divergent, convergent, and parallel times; physicists have often cited the story as an anticipation of what Hugh Everett III would formalise sixteen years later. Everett's "Relative State Formulation of Quantum Mechanics" (1957) proposed that the universal wavefunction never collapses and that each measurement correlates the observer with every possible outcome; Bryce DeWitt's popularisation in *Physics Today* (1970) and the anthology *The Many-Worlds Interpretation of Quantum Mechanics* (1973) supplied the canonical name. Michael Moorcock, meanwhile, had brought the word *multiverse* into fantasy fiction in the 1960s as the arena of the Eternal Champion, a hero who exists as many heroes across many worlds and whose incarnations, in several novels, meet one another — the genre's nearest approach, before 2013, to a Citadel of Ricks. Borges contributed the image of plurality as labyrinth; Everett, its ontological seriousness; Moorcock, the plural self.

Serial publishing contributed the multiverse's function. When DC Comics revived its superhero line in the late 1950s with new versions of characters first published in the 1940s, it faced a problem of continuity: two Flashes with incompatible histories. "Flash of Two Worlds!" (*The Flash* #123, 1961), written by Gardner Fox, solved it by locating the earlier Flash on a parallel Earth; within two decades the Earths had multiplied beyond management, and *Crisis on Infinite Earths* (1985–1986) destroyed the multiverse to simplify the publisher's continuity. The narrative multiverse was born as bookkeeping — a device for reconciling the versions that seriality produces. Television contributed its moral iconography. *Star Trek*'s "Mirror, Mirror" (1967) introduced the evil counterpart from a

parallel universe, marked by a goatee, the sign that a variant is the moral inversion of its original. The device passed directly into Harmon's *Community*, whose "Remedial Chaos Theory" (2011), written by Chris McKenna under Harmon's showrunning, branches a single evening into six timelines by the roll of a die, one of them a "darkest timeline" whose survivors adopt felt goatees in homage to *Star Trek*. The same series anticipated Rick's metafictional habit in Abed Nadir, a character who experiences his own life as television and narrates its conventions as they unfold. The darkest timeline's successor in the series is Evil Morty, the eye-patched Morty who first appears in S1E10 and whose villainy consists, as the series eventually discloses, in having drawn the obvious conclusion from the condition of Mortys.

Speculative fiction had also already posed the question the series makes its own: what becomes of value in a cosmos in which every choice is made? Larry Niven's "All the Myriad Ways" (1968) imagines a wave of motiveless suicides and crimes in the wake of commercial travel among parallel timelines; its detective reasons that if every alternative is realised somewhere, choice is meaningless, and in the story's closing paragraphs his own hand upon a gun branches into all its possible outcomes. Niven's story is the clearest pre-televisual statement of the inference — from plurality to the nullity of choice — that the received reading attributes to Rick. Chapter 3 argues that the inference is invalid; Chapter 7, that it is motivated.

The coincidence of the series' premiere with the most celebrated restorative instance of the multi-self narrative deserves note. On 23 November 2013, nine days before the pilot of *Rick and Morty* aired, *Doctor Who* marked its fiftieth anniversary with "The Day of the Doctor", in which the Doctor's guilt for having apparently destroyed his own people is resolved when every incarnation of the Doctor combines to save them: variants of a single self, cooperating across time, undo the founding catastrophe and redeem the survivor. *Rick and Morty* began its run with the obverse proposition. Its variants of a single self do not redeem one another; they gerrymander the cosmos, police one another, treat one another's grandsons as interchangeable equipment, and, at the origin of the protagonist's grief, murder one another's families. Chapter 10 places the two series at opposite poles of a typology of multiverse fiction, the restorative and the haecceitic.

1.7

The Author Function and the Single Throat

The final genealogical question concerns authorship. Michel Foucault's lecture "Qu'est-ce qu'un auteur?" (1969) argued that the author's name functions within discourse not as a reference to a person but as a principle of classification, grouping, and limitation — the *author function* — which confers unity on a body of texts and regulates the proliferation of their meanings; Roland Barthes had announced, two years earlier, the death of the author and the birth of the reader. *Rick and Morty* is a singularly apt object for both theses, because its authorship was plural from the outset and has since been subjected to an experiment neither theorist could have staged.

The series was credited to two creators whose contributions may be schematised, at some cost in simplification, as structure and improvisation: Harmon's circle and Roiland's voice. Around them a writers' room produced the episodes, and its work has received recognition in its own right ("Pickle Rick", S3E3, written by Jessica Gao, received the Primetime Emmy for Outstanding Animated Program in 2018). The author function "Harmon and Roiland" was already a corporate fiction: a dyadic name covering a collective practice.

One fact of production bears directly upon the dyad the series depicts. Roiland voiced both title characters. The slurred, eructative baritone of age and the stammering adolescent tenor issued from a single throat, so that the series' central relation was, at the level of performance, a dialogue of one voice with itself across the interval of a lifetime. Bakhtin counted among the marks of Menippean satire the "dialogic relationship with oneself", the splitting of a consciousness into interlocutors; here the splitting was literal. The old man and the boy were the two ages of one voice — a fact that lends unexpected weight to the possibility, which the series both entertains and resists, that a Morty might become a Rick, a possibility realised in its own figure of a Morty who has become, in intellect and ruthlessness, a Rick: Evil Morty.

In January 2023 it became public that Roiland had been charged in May 2020 with two felony counts, domestic battery with corporal injury and false imprisonment, involving a former girlfriend with whom he had been living; Adult Swim ended its association with him that month. He pleaded not guilty and maintained that the claims were false, and in March 2023 the Orange County District Attorney's office dismissed the charges for lack of sufficient evidence to prove the case beyond a reasonable doubt. The title roles were recast for the seventh season with two performers whose voices closely approximate his. The production thereby enacted the series' metaphysics upon itself. The Rick of Season 7 is, at the level of the voice, a variant of the Rick of Seasons 1–6: the role persists as a type across a change of token, as the Ship of Theseus persists across the replacement of its planks (Plutarch, *Theseus* 23), and with the same question, sharpened by Hobbes, of whether the

continuously repaired vessel or the original reassembled from its discarded planks is the true ship (*De Corpore* II.11.7). Lévi-Strauss's dictum that a myth consists of all its versions ("The Structural Study of Myth", 1955) here acquires an industrial application. There is no original Rick, only the system of his transformations — authorial, vocal, and diegetic — and the Citadel of Ricks is that dictum given urban form. Foucault's thesis is confirmed with unusual starkness: the author function survived the removal of one of its authors, because it was never a person but a principle of unity.

The record of the series' authorship includes its other creator's history as well. In January 2018 Harmon admitted on his podcast, *Harmontown*, that while he was showrunner of *Community* he had sexually harassed Megan Ganz, a writer on the series: he pursued her romantically and, when she rebuked him, treated her cruelly while he controlled her employment. He apologised, and Ganz publicly accepted the apology. This dissertation draws no inference from either creator's conduct to the meaning of the series, whose argument it locates in the work rather than in its makers. The facts are recorded because they belong to the history of the work's production and reception, and because an account of its authorship that omitted them would be incomplete (sources in the Addenda to the bibliography).

Yet genealogy is not argument. That a type persists across its tokens is what the Citadel concludes, and it is what the series, on the reading developed here, finally refuses to accept as the last word. The inference from the persistence of the role to the indifference of its bearer — from "there will always be another Rick" to "no Rick matters" — is precisely the consolation of plurality, and the series' mature work is the demonstration that it fails.

1.8

Findings

Three findings follow. First, the dyad was born as the exposure of the mentor's power as domination — in the originating travesty, the sexual coercion of a teenager by an adult — and the series' ethical question is coeval with its form: *Rick and Morty* does not acquire a conscience in its later seasons; it begins as one, in the mode of travesty. Second, the multiverse is the cosmology of seriality — a device born in the bookkeeping of serial publishing, refined in an institutional ecology of disposable pilots, and rendered in the diegesis as the infinite flow of interdimensional cable — so that the metaphysics of replaceability is, in part, the medium's self-portrait. Third, the series is structured by the antagonism between Harmon's circle, which insists that every return bears the mark of its price, and the sitcom's reset, which promises that nothing is retained. "Rick Potion #9" resolves that antagonism by exposing the reset as a migration with a body count, and leaves Morty's memory as the remainder no reset can absorb. That remainder is the seed of the ethics this dissertation

will construct. Before it can be constructed, the genre in which these formations converge must be named.



CHAPTER TWO

PART I · FORMATIONS

The Menippean Machine

Genre, Carnival, and the Eructative Caesura

In this one thing I shall tell the truth: that I am lying.

— Lucian, *A True Story* I.4 (2nd century CE)

I write of melancholy, by being busy to avoid melancholy.

— Robert Burton, *The Anatomy of Melancholy*, "Democritus Junior to the Reader" (1621)

Rick and Morty is a Menippean satire in the strict generic sense specified by Mikhail Bakhtin and Northrop Frye: a form whose characteristic operation is the testing of an idea, and of the person who embodies it, in extraordinary situations, conducted with a freedom of fantastic invention matched only by the crudity of its naturalism. The idea the series most persistently tests is the one its protagonist most persistently professes. This chapter argues that the genre's tests are conducted upon bodies, that the bodies fail the idea, and that the most persistent sign of that failure is audible: the belch that interrupts Rick's speech, read here as an *eructative caesura*, a counter-rhythmic interruption through which the suffering body discloses itself in the voice of sovereign reason. The argument moves from the history of the genre (§2.1) and Bakhtin's taxonomy (§2.2) to its constitutive relation to melancholy (§2.3), its characteristic vantage (§2.4), its carnival (§2.5), its voice

(§2.6), and its paratext (§2.7).

2.1

Menippus and His Heirs

Menippus of Gadara, a Cynic of the third century BCE — in the tradition preserved by Diogenes Laertius (VI.99–101), a slave turned moneylender who, having lost his savings, took his own life — left nothing that survives. His writings, which mixed prose and verse to mock the pretensions of philosophers, are known through their imitators, and antiquity classed them among the *spoudogeloia*, the serio-comic forms that treat the gravest matters in the lowest tone. Varro's *Saturae Menippeae* (first century BCE), of which some six hundred fragments remain, gave the genre its Roman name; Seneca's *Apocolocyntosis* (c. 54 CE) narrates the deified Claudius's ascent to Olympus and his ignominious relegation to the underworld; Petronius's *Satyricon* joins the prosimetric form to the picaresque. The decisive classical practitioner is Lucian of Samosata, whose dialogues and fantasies amount to a nearly complete repertoire of the devices *Rick and Morty* would redeploy: the cosmic voyage undertaken to verify the claims of philosophers (*Icaromenippus*, in which Menippus flies to the moon on one eagle's wing and one vulture's and finds Empedocles living there); the descent to the dead (*Menippus*, or *Necyomantia*; the *Dialogues of the Dead*); the survey of human life from a height at which its ambitions shrink to bubbles (*Charon*, or *The Inspectors*); the interplanetary war over colonial rights and the voyage inside a whale (*A True Story*, which declares at the outset that its only true statement is that it lies); the sale of philosophers at auction (*Philosophies for Sale*); and the tale of the sorcerer's apprentice (*Philopseudes*), discussed in Chapter 1.

The genre's Cynic parentage is not incidental. From Diogenes of Sinope onward, the Cynic made the shameless body (*anaideia*) an argument against convention: eating, sleeping, and relieving himself in public, he enacted the claim that the norms of the city were arbitrary and that the philosopher's life should be a scandal to them. Michel Foucault's final lectures at the Collège de France (*Le courage de la vérité*, 1984) analysed Cynicism as the practice of *parrhesia*, frank and dangerous speech, lived out as a "true life" that exposes the falsity of ordinary life by its very manner. Rick's contempt for decorum, his public intoxication, his verbal shamelessness, and his insistence on telling each member of his family the most wounding truth available are recognisably Cynic. Chapter 5 considers him as a Cynic *parrhesiast*; here it suffices to observe that the genre into which he was born began as the literary arm of a school whose arguments were conducted with the body.

The genre survived antiquity through several channels. Boethius's *Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524), composed in prison in alternating prose and verse, is formally Menippean, and Joel Relihan has argued (*The Prisoner's Philosophy*, 2007) that its form ironises its

content, subjecting Lady Philosophy's consolations to a test they do not wholly pass — a reading of some consequence for the *consolation of plurality* examined in Chapter 3. Erasmus's *Moriae Encomium* (1511), Folly's encomium of herself, dedicated to Thomas More with a pun upon his name, made the wise fool the genre's Renaissance protagonist; Chapter 6 returns to the pun. Rabelais's *Gargantua and Pantagruel* (1532–1564) supplied the carnival; Burton's *Anatomy of Melancholy* (1621), the encyclopaedic farrago; Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), the satire of science, in the flying island of Laputa, whose philosophers are so absorbed in speculation that servants called flappers must strike their mouths and ears with inflated bladders to recall them to conversation — a job description for Morty that the series never needed to write; Voltaire's *Micromégas* (1752) and *Candide* (1759), the philosophical voyage and the parody of theodicy.

In the twentieth century the genre migrated into speculative fiction. Kurt Vonnegut's *The Sirens of Titan* (1959) discloses that the whole of human history has been manipulated in order to deliver a replacement part to a stranded alien messenger; Stanisław Lem's *Cyberiad* (1965) follows Trurl and Klapaucius, a dyad of genius constructor-robots whose inventions rebound upon them, and in its "Seventh Sally" raises, half a century before the series, the question whether the inhabitants of a miniature kingdom built for a tyrant's amusement suffer really; Douglas Adams's *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* (1979) demolishes the Earth to make way for a hyperspace bypass. *Rick and Morty* is the most fully realised televisual instance of this lineage, and its relation to it is not one of influence among others but of generic identity.

2.2

The Marks of the Menippea

Bakhtin's account of the genre, set out in the fourth chapter of *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics* (1929; revised 1963), remains the most precise instrument for identifying it. Bakhtin enumerates fourteen characteristics and treats the third as the most important: in the menippea the fantastic serves not to embody a truth but to search for it, to provoke it, and above all to *test* it, so that the genre narrates the adventures of an idea, and of the person who bears it, in the world. The table sets Bakhtin's marks beside their instances in the series. Its purpose is not merely classificatory. The correspondence is so close, and so evenly distributed across the corpus, that the genre must be understood as the series' operating system rather than as one influence among others.

Mark of the menippea (Bakhtin)	Instances in Rick and Morty
1. A comic element stronger than in the Socratic dialogue	A comic register sustained through grief, addiction, and self-destruction

MARK OF THE MENIPPEA (BAKHTIN)	INSTANCES IN RICK AND MORTY
2. Freedom from the constraints of history and verisimilitude; extraordinary freedom of plot and philosophical invention	A new premise each episode; the multiverse licenses unlimited invention and the suspension of continuity
3. The fantastic as the means of testing an idea and its bearer	Nihilism tested upon the Meeseeks (S1E5), the microverse (S2E6), and the decoy families (S5E2)
4. Fantasy fused with crude "slum naturalism"	Alien bars, arcades, and junkyards; the garage; drool, vomit, and the flask
5. Philosophical universalism: the genre of "ultimate questions"	Purpose, death, identity, God, and free will, posed at the breakfast table
6. Three-planed construction (Olympus, earth, underworld); dialogues on the threshold	The Citadel, the Galactic Federation, and the cosmic powers; the suburban house; the devil's shop (S1E9) and the sewers of Pickle Rick's descent (S3E3)
7. Experimental fantasticality: an unusual vantage and radical changes of scale	Portal travel; the microverse powering Rick's car and the worlds nested within it (S2E6); the amusement park inside a human body (S1E3)
8. Moral-psychological experimentation: madness, split personality, dreams, suicidal states, the dialogue with oneself	Toxic and detoxified selves (S3E6); the self-pickling flight from therapy (S3E3); Rick's attempt on his own life (S2E3)
9. Scandal scenes, eccentric conduct, violations of decorum and verbal etiquette	The family dinner; Birdperson's wedding (S2E10); Thanksgiving (S5E6); the therapy session (S3E3)
10. Sharp contrasts and oxymoronic combinations	The genius who cannot care for himself; the omnipotent man concealed by a boy's brainwaves; the god whose car runs on the labour of a civilisation he made (S2E6)
11. Elements of social utopia, usually as journeys to unknown lands	Unity's assimilated planet, a utopia of the hive (S2E3); the Citadel, a city governed by its cleverest variants
12. Inserted genres: letters, speeches, symposia, verse	Interdimensional cable (S1E8, S2E8); songs (S2E5); in-universe advertisements, talk shows, and procedurals
13. A multi-styled, multi-toned discourse	Improvisation set against scripted speech; parodies of every cinematic idiom from the heist film to the mecha anime
14. Topicality: a "journalistic" genre	Presidential politics; environmentalism (S5E3); therapy culture; fandom and its discontents

Two features of the table require comment. The first concerns the distribution of the third mark. The ideas the series tests are overwhelmingly versions of the idea its protagonist holds — that nothing matters because nothing is unique — and the tests are overwhelmingly conducted upon creatures who cannot survive the idea: servants, simulations, decoys, the inhabitants of worlds made for use. The second concerns the convergence of the fourth and fifth marks, which Bakhtin regarded as the genre's signature: ultimate questions posed in the lowest places. *Rick and Morty* asks whether existence has a purpose at the breakfast

table and whether the self survives copying in a garage. The incongruity is not a joke at the expense of the questions; it is the genre's method for ensuring that no answer to them is accepted unless it survives contact with a body.

2.3

The Anatomy of Melancholy

Northrop Frye, in the fourth essay of *Anatomy of Criticism* (1957), proposed to replace "Menippean satire" with "anatomy", borrowing the term from the title of Robert Burton's treatise as an accurate name for the form's dissecting, encyclopaedic, and intellectualised approach. The anatomy, on Frye's account, deals less with people as such than with mental attitudes; its characters are mouthpieces of the ideas they represent, and its characteristic target is the *philosophus gloriosus*, the pedant, crank, or virtuoso whose intellect has detached itself from life. The renaming carries an implication Frye did not draw out, and it is decisive for this dissertation: the genre's alternative name derives from a treatise on melancholy. The anatomy is, at its eponymous origin, an anatomy *of melancholy*.

Burton wrote as "Democritus Junior", and his preface retells a story preserved in the pseudo-Hippocratic letters. The citizens of Abdera, alarmed that their philosopher Democritus laughed at everything, summoned Hippocrates to cure his madness; the physician found him in a garden, dissecting animals in search of the seat of black bile, and concluded after conversing with him that he was the only sane man in the city. The founding scene of the anatomy is thus a scientist mistaken for a madman, laughing from a height at the folly of the town while cutting open bodies to find the source of sorrow. Classical tradition paired Democritus with Heraclitus, who wept at what Democritus mocked: the pair appear in Seneca (*De ira* II.10; *De tranquillitate animi* 15) and in Juvenal's tenth satire, and Lucian's *Philosophies for Sale* offers them together as a lot no buyer will take. Rick is Democritus at Abdera — the scientist taken for a madman, laughing at the town, dissecting creatures in his garage. But the series' most celebrated lexical joke discloses that his laughter is Heraclitean weeping. In S1E11 ("Ricksy Business") Birdperson, Rick's oldest friend, translates the nonsense cry with which Rick punctuates his revels — "wubba lubba dub dub" — from his own language: it means, in Birdperson's rendering, "I am in great pain, please help me". The cry of carnival is a plea; the Democritean mask is worn over a Heraclitean face. Chapter 7 reads the catchphrase, in the sense Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok gave the term, as a *cryptonym* — a word that conceals an unspeakable content by encoding it in another language — and argues that the series' cosmology as a whole has the structure of such an encryption.

The phrase's history sharpens the point, because it was not written as a cry. According to Roiland, it began as a vocal improvisation on a parenthetical in the script, a string

of nonsense syllables describing a Three Stooges–style spin, and the writers meant it as a mockery of the sitcom catchphrase, an anti-catchphrase they hoped would not catch on. Introduced in S1E5 ("Meeseeks and Destroy"), it acquired its meaning six episodes later, when Birdperson translated it. The sense of pain was conferred on the sound after the fact. Chapter 7 calls this temporality, after Freud, *Nachträglichkeit*: the joke became a cry of pain retroactively, as the series discovered what its own nonsense had been concealing.

The association of melancholy with genius long predates Burton. The pseudo-Aristotelian *Problemata* XXX.1 asks why all those who have become outstanding in philosophy, statecraft, poetry, or the arts are melancholic, and answers with a theory of black bile whose temperature yields either inspiration or despondency. Marsilio Ficino's *De vita libri tres* (1489) made Saturn, the planet of melancholy, the patron of scholars; Dürer's engraving *Melencolia I* (1514) shows a winged genius sunk in idle dejection among the instruments of geometry, carpentry, and alchemy; Raymond Klibansky, Erwin Panofsky, and Fritz Saxl reconstructed the tradition in *Saturn and Melancholy* (1964). Chapter 5 takes it up in reading Rick as a Saturnine demiurge. The point here is generic. Menippean satire is constitutively a genre of melancholy: renamed, in Frye's taxonomy, after a treatise on it; founded in a scene of laughing dissection; and embodied, in its televisual instance, in a figure who conforms to the Aristotelian type of the melancholic genius. Burton's confession — that he wrote of melancholy by being busy to avoid it — could stand as the epigraph to the series' entire episodic structure. Rick's adventures are busyness in Burton's sense: the avoidance of melancholy by perpetual activity, the anatomy of everything except the wound.

2.4

Kataskopia: *The View from Above*

The genre's characteristic vantage is the height. Lucian's Menippus surveys the earth from the moon and finds its cities no larger than anthills; his Charon, from a pile of stacked mountains, likens human lives to bubbles that rise in a stream and burst. The view from above — *kataskopia* — was also, as Pierre Hadot showed ("The View from Above", in *Philosophy as a Way of Life*, 1995), a spiritual exercise of ancient philosophy. In Cicero's *Somnium Scipionis* (*De re publica* VI) Scipio sees the earth so small that he is ashamed of an empire that touches it only at a point; Seneca (*Naturales quaestiones* I, praefatio) and Marcus Aurelius (*Meditations* VII.48, IX.30) recommend the exercise as a remedy for ambition and fear; Boethius's Philosophy deploys it to expose the vanity of fame (*Consolatio* II, prosa 7). In the Stoic and Platonic traditions the view from above purifies; in Lucian it provokes laughter; in every case it presupposes a return to the ground with a corrected sense of scale.

Modern Menippean fiction tests the exercise to destruction. Voltaire's Micromégas, a giant from Sirius, and his companion from Saturn discover a ship of philosophers in the Baltic and dissolve into laughter at a Thomist who maintains that the universe was made for man; the giant leaves them a book of philosophy promising to reveal the end of things, and its pages prove to be blank. Douglas Adams's *The Restaurant at the End of the Universe* (1980) mechanises *kataskopia* as an instrument of execution, the Total Perspective Vortex, which annihilates its victims by showing them the whole of creation and their own place within it. Only one character survives it: Zaphod Beeblebrox, because the universe in which he enters the Vortex has been constructed especially for him, so that the machine reports that he is the most important being in it. Adams's joke anticipates with startling exactness the structure the series discloses in `S5E10`. The Central Finite Curve — a region of the infinite curated so that Rick is always the most intelligent being within it — is the Zaphod defence raised to a cosmological principle: the ego survives the view from above only by inhabiting a universe arranged around itself. Chapter 7 names this structure *narcissistic curvature*.

Thomas Nagel's "The Absurd" (1971) supplies the philosophical analysis of what the Menippean tradition dramatises. For Nagel the sense of the absurd depends neither on the size of the universe nor on the brevity of life — a life of a million years would be no less absurd than one of seventy — but on a structural feature of reflective consciousness: the collision between the seriousness with which we necessarily pursue our lives and the perpetually available capacity to step back and regard everything we take seriously as arbitrary, *sub specie aeternitatis*. Because the step back is always available, the absurd cannot be escaped; because the seriousness is equally inescapable, it cannot be dissolved. Nagel rejects despair, rejects Camus's defiance as romantic and somewhat self-pitying, and recommends irony: if nothing matters from the standpoint of eternity, then that does not matter either.

Read through Nagel, Rick's condition acquires a precise description. The portal gun is *kataskopia* made technology: it institutionalises the step back, rendering the standpoint from which every human concern appears arbitrary available at the press of a trigger. What Rick lacks is not the capacity to step back but the capacity to step forward again — to return from the height to the ground with Nagel's irony, Marcus's equanimity, or even Lucian's laughter, rather than with contempt. The series' form, however, enforces the return his philosophy refuses. Almost every episode ends at the house, at the table, or in the garage. The genre performs the descent its protagonist will not.

2.5

Carnival without Renewal

Bakhtin's other study of the genre's lineage, *Rabelais and His World* (completed 1940; published 1965), describes the carnival culture of the medieval and Renaissance marketplace and the grotesque realism that expressed it: a poetics of the material bodily lower stratum — eating, drinking, defecation, copulation, birth, death — in which the body is open, protruding, unfinished, and collective. The grotesque body is degraded, brought down from the abstract and spiritual to the material and earthly, but degradation in Bakhtin's sense is ambivalent: it buries in order to renew, as the earth swallows the seed. Carnival laughter is universal and regenerative; it crowns and uncrowns, kills and gives birth.

The series is saturated with grotesque realism. "Anatomy Park" (S1E3) literalises Bakhtin's figure with diagrammatic precision: an amusement park constructed inside the body of a homeless man and set at Christmas — a feast of birth celebrated within a body at the point of death — its rides named for organs, its catastrophe an outbreak of disease released by his dying. "Pickle Rick" (S3E3) reduces the sovereign intellect to a brined vegetable and rebuilds it, in a sewer, from the bodies of cockroaches and rats, in a descent whose generic ancestor is Apuleius's *Metamorphoses* (second century CE), the tale of Lucius, turned by his curiosity into an ass. The parallel is instructive. Lucius's metamorphosis ends in initiation: restored by Isis, he enters her mysteries and is reborn. Rick's metamorphosis is undertaken to *avoid* an initiation — the family therapy session to which the episode returns, where the therapist, Dr. Wong, diagnoses the family's habit of using intelligence to justify sickness and insists that change is laborious and unspectacular work. The metamorphosis that in Apuleius leads to the mysteries leads, in the series, away from them; and Kafka's *Die Verwandlung* (1915), in which a family gradually abandons the son who has become vermin, is inverted, since here it is the transformed man who uses his transformation to abandon the family.

Yet the series' carnival is not Bakhtin's. Bakhtin himself distinguished the folk grotesque of the Renaissance from the Romantic grotesque, which he characterised as an individual carnival experienced in isolation, in which laughter is reduced to irony and sarcasm and loses its regenerative power, and in which the world grows alien and terrifying — the grotesque Wolfgang Kayser theorised (*Das Groteske*, 1957) as the estranged world and the attempt to invoke and subdue its demonic aspects. Rick's carnival belongs to the second type. Its locus is not the marketplace but the garage; its laughter is sarcasm; its body is solitary. "The Old Man and the Seat" (S4E2) privatises the lower stratum altogether: among Rick's most jealously guarded possessions is a toilet on a remote planet that no one else may use. Above all, the regeneration carnival promised has been replaced by replacement. Where the grotesque body dies into the collective body of the people and is renewed, Rick

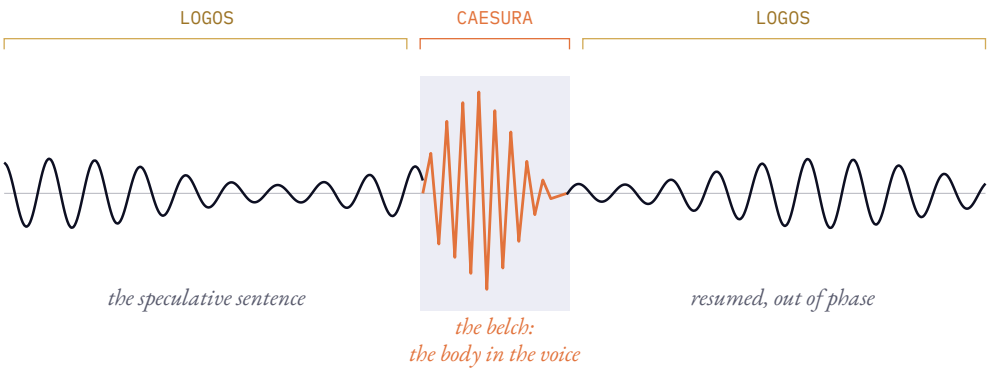


FIG. 2.1 *The eructative caesura. The belch breaks the sentence of sovereign reason with the rhythm of the suffering body; the logos resumes, but out of phase.*

dies into a clone ("Edge of Tomorty: Rick, Die, Rickpeat", S4E1), and in "Rick Potion #9" a dead Morty is simply exchanged for a living one in the yard of a substitute home. The ambivalent death-and-rebirth of carnival is supplanted by the mechanical substitution of the serial. *Carnival without renewal* is the genre's precise diagnosis of its protagonist: a festival of the body that has forgotten the body's capacity to be reborn and remembers only its capacity to be copied.

2.6

The Eructative Caesura

The genre's argument against the doctrine reaches its most concentrated form in the voice. Throughout the corpus Rick's speech is interrupted by belches — loud, wet, irregular, frequently splitting a word or a clause, and conspicuously frequent at moments of lecture, pronouncement, and contempt. Physiologically, eructation is the stomach's expulsion of swallowed gas; diegetically, it indexes the flask from which Rick drinks throughout the series, so that each interruption carries the trace of self-medication, the anaesthetic that sustains the discourse it interrupts. The belch has been treated as characterisation or as gag. It is better understood as a formal device with a precise philosophical function, and this dissertation names it the *eructative caesura*.

In classical prosody the caesura is a break within the metrical line. Friedrich Hölderlin's "Anmerkungen zum Ödipus" (1804) converted the term into a concept of tragic form. Because the tragic transport (*Transport*) is in itself empty, Hölderlin argues, the caesura — the pure word, the counter-rhythmic interruption (*das reine Wort, die gegenrhythmische Unterbrechung*) — becomes necessary to arrest the onrushing alternation of representations, so that representation itself may appear; in *Oedipus* the caesura falls with the speeches of Tiresias, the blind seer who interrupts the hero's drive to know. Walter Benjamin invoked

Hölderlin's caesura in his essay on Goethe's *Elective Affinities* (1924–25) to describe the expressionless (*das Ausdruckslose*), the critical violence that interrupts semblance and arrests the beautiful appearance; Philippe Lacoue-Labarthe, in "La césure du spéculatif" (1978), read it as the point at which tragedy resists absorption into the speculative dialectic — the interruption of the speculative by what it cannot sublate.

Rick's belch is a counter-rhythmic interruption in exactly this sense. It falls where the speculative discourse of nihilism — the lecture on the meaninglessness of attachment, the demonstration of the family's mediocrity, the proof that nothing matters — gathers momentum, and it breaks that momentum with a non-signifying emission of the gut. In Lacoue-Labarthe's terms it is a caesura of the speculative: the point at which the body from which the discourse abstracts reasserts itself within the discourse. Rick speaks, as it were, from the height of the view from above; the belch speaks from the stomach. And as Tiresias, in Hölderlin's reading, interrupts the hero who insists on knowing, the belch interrupts the genius who insists on having known — on having seen through everything.

The classical archive offers a scene that is almost a prototype. In Plato's *Symposium* (185c–e), when the comic poet Aristophanes' turn comes to speak in praise of Eros, he cannot, because he has the hiccups; the physician Eryximachus speaks in his place and prescribes remedies — holding the breath, gargling, provoking a sneeze. Jacques Lacan, in his seminar on transference (Seminar VIII, 1960–61), dwelt on the hiccup as the comic body's irruption into the order of the speeches. When Aristophanes recovers, the speech he delivers (189c–193d) is the myth of the double humans, cut in two by Zeus, each half seeking its lost other: love as the search for one's unique complement. The sequence — the comic body interrupts philosophy, and what follows is a myth of the irreplaceable Two — is the sequence this dissertation reconstructs across the whole of *Rick and Morty*: the eructative caesura interrupts the logos of replaceability, and what the series finally sets in its place is the dyad (Chapter 8).

Contemporary philosophy of the voice clarifies the stakes. Mladen Dolar (*A Voice and Nothing More*, 2006) isolates the voice as an object irreducible to meaning, most legible in non-signifying emissions — the cough, the hiccup, the laugh, the scream — which mark the point at which the voice exceeds the signifier and discloses the body that produces it; Roland Barthes's "grain of the voice" (1972) names the body's materiality audible in vocal performance. Adriana Cavarero (*A più voci*, 2003; English trans. 2005) argues that the voice reveals not *what* but *who* the speaker is — the embodied uniqueness that Western metaphysics, privileging the semantic content of logos, has devocalised. The belch is Rick's grain, and literally so: the trait began as an accident of one performer's body. Recording the Doc and Mharti short in 2006, Roiland has said, a burp "came out naturally" in the middle of a line, and it was kept (Entertainment Weekly, 2015). But it complicates Cavarero's thesis in an instructive way. The trait is not Rick C-137's alone; it belongs to the type, shared by his variants and retained as a feature of the part when the role was recast in 2023. The

eructative caesura therefore does not disclose the uniqueness of a *who*; it discloses the body as *kind* — the shared, serial, self-medicating flesh of the type. What interrupts the logos of replaceability is not yet, at this level, the irreplaceable individual but the body as such: the gut, the drink, the suffering every Rick shares. The series must look elsewhere for the *who*. It finds it, Chapter 8 argues, not in any trait a Rick possesses but in what one particular Rick does — in the acts of keeping by which a variant becomes *this* one.

Belch and catchphrase are thus the two forms in which Rick's voice betrays his doctrine. The belch interrupts the doctrine with the body; the catchphrase, once translated, converts the doctrine's exultation into a plea. The one is a caesura, the other a cryptonym; together they constitute the voice's counter-testimony. The protagonist argues in words that nothing matters; his voice, beneath and between the words, reports that something hurts.

2.7

The Titular Palimpsest

The genre's last device is its appetite for inserted and borrowed forms, and here the series' most conspicuous convention acquires an unexpected significance. Nearly every episode of *Rick and Morty* is titled as a pun upon the title of an earlier film, novel, programme, or song. The convention is usually treated as a paratextual gag. Read as a corpus, however, the titles constitute a secondary text — a palimpsest of hypotexts in Genette's sense — whose thematic distribution is far from random. Four clusters dominate.

The first concerns memory and its falsification: "Total Rickall" (S2E4), after *Total Recall* (1990), itself adapted from Philip K. Dick's story of purchased memories, "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966); "Rickternal Friendshine of the Spotless Mort" (S5E8), after *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* (2004), a film about the erasure of a lost love; "Forgetting Sarick Mortshall" (S5E9). The second concerns mourning and the return of the dead: "Solaricks" (S6E1), after Lem's *Solaris* (1961), in which an alien ocean materialises the protagonist's dead wife from his memory; "Rickfending Your Mort" (S7E6), after Albert Brooks's *Defending Your Life* (1991), an afterlife in which a life is judged by its fear; "Final DeSmithation" (S6E5), after a film franchise in which death cannot be cheated; "Fear No Mort" (S7E10), whose title the Conclusion reads against two old consolations in the face of death; and "That's Amorte" (S7E4), whose pun discovers *morte* inside *amore*. The third concerns gods and makers: "The Ricks Must Be Crazy" (S2E6), after *The Gods Must Be Crazy* (1980), which installs the Ricks in the place of the gods; "Close Rick-counters of the Rick Kind" (S1E10); "Lawnmower Dog" (S1E2), after a film of artificially augmented intelligence; "Promortyus" (S4E7), after Ridley Scott's film of the search for humanity's makers, itself named for the fire-thief. The fourth concerns children used by parents and fathers lost to their children: "The Rickchurian Mortydate" (S3E10), after *The Manchurian*

Candidate (1962), whose brainwashed son is operated by his own mother; "Gotron Jerrysis Rickvangelion" (S5E7), after *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–1996), whose Gendo Ikari conscripts his son into the service of an apocalyptic project driven by grief for his dead wife; "A Rickle in Time" (S2E1), after Madeleine L'Engle's *A Wrinkle in Time* (1962), in which a child rescues her scientist father from a disembodied intelligence that has made everyone alike; and "Rickmurai Jack" (S5E10), after *Samurai Jack* (2001–2017), whose hero, flung into a ruined future, seeks to return to the past and undo it. Beside these clusters stand "Mortyplicity" (S5E2), after Harold Ramis's comedy of degraded clones, and "Never Ricking Morty" (S4E6), after the paradigmatic story of a reader absorbed into a story.

Memory, mourning, makers, and instrumentalised children: the four clusters name in the paratext the four preoccupations that the episodes' surface comedy disavows and that this dissertation identifies as the series' latent argument — the falsification of the real (Chapter 4), the demiurgic creator (Chapter 5), the boy used by the genius (Chapter 6), and the unmourned dead (Chapter 7). The titles compose a *hypotextual unconscious*: a second text, legible only when the gags are read together, in which the series names what it is about while appearing to name only what it parodies. One title compresses the whole argument into a single pun — *amore* rewritten as *amorte*, love with death inside it.

2.8

Findings

Four findings follow. First, *Rick and Morty* is a Menippean satire in the strict generic sense, and its genre is operative rather than decorative: the series is a machine for testing an idea upon bodies. Second, the genre is constitutively melancholic — renamed, in Frye's taxonomy, after a treatise on melancholy, founded in the scene of Democritus dissecting animals in search of black bile, and embodied in a protagonist whose catchphrase, translated, is a cry of pain. Third, the series' carnival is the Romantic grotesque that Bakhtin distinguished from the folk carnival: solitary, sarcastic, and bereft of regeneration, its death-and-rebirth replaced by the mechanical substitution of the clone. Fourth, the series' form argues against its protagonist's doctrine at the level of the voice and of the paratext alike: the eructative caesura interrupts the speculative logos of replaceability with the suffering body, and the titular palimpsest names, beneath its parodies, the memory, mourning, making, and instrumentalisation the doctrine exists to keep from view. The form already knows what the protagonist will not say. Part II turns from form to cosmology, and asks what kind of infinite the series has built, and why.

PART

II

Cosmologies

3 *The Bad Infinite*

4 *Simulacra and the Algetic Criterion of the Real*

Part II turns from form to cosmology. Chapter 3 analyses the multiverse as an instance of what Hegel called the spurious or bad infinite, reconstructs the long history in which a plurality of worlds has served as a source of consolation, and shows that the inference from plurality to the nullity of value — the central premise of the received reading — fails on economic, metaphysical, and decision-theoretic grounds alike. Chapter 4 examines the series' simulacra, the implicit criterion of the real they force upon its characters, and the double horror of purpose that forecloses the classical remedy for nihilism.



CHAPTER THREE

PART II · COSMOLOGIES

The Bad Infinite

Plenitude, Modal Realism, and the Consolation of Plurality

This infinity is the bad or negative infinity: it is nothing but the negation of the finite, which nevertheless arises again, and so is never sublated.

— G. W. F. Hegel, *Encyclopaedia of the Philosophical Sciences* §94 (1830)

Therefore, again and again, you must confess that elsewhere there are other worlds, and various races of men, and kinds of wild beasts.

— Lucretius, *De rerum natura* II.1074–1076 (1st century BCE)

The multiverse of *Rick and Morty* has been read as the premise of an argument whose conclusion is nihilism. This chapter reconstructs that argument, here called the *argument from plurality*, and shows that it fails in four ways. It fails economically, because it rests upon an unstated premise that assimilates the value of persons to the price of goods. It fails metaphysically, because on every rigorous account of a plurality of worlds a counterpart is not an equivalent, and the existence of one's counterparts leaves one's own existence, and one's own loss, exactly what they were. It fails decision-theoretically, because the physicists who take the many-worlds hypothesis most seriously have derived from it not indifference but a measure of care. And it fails historically, because

the long tradition of reflection on infinite worlds shows that the affect attached to plurality — tranquillity, exaltation, terror, contempt — has never been dictated by the cosmos but supplied by the subject who contemplates it. The multiverse the series builds is, in Hegel's precise sense, a bad infinite: an endless repetition of the finite that never attains the infinite it promises. The question the chapter bequeaths to Part IV is therefore not whether the argument is sound but why it is believed. Its provisional answer is that the argument from plurality is not an argument at all but a consolation.

3.1

The Argument from Plurality

The received reading's central inference can be reconstructed in three steps. (P1) For any person in any world, there exist indefinitely many other worlds containing that person's counterparts — persons alike in kind, history, and character, differing in detail or not at all. (P2) Whatever exists in unlimited supply has no value in any of its instances; the loss of an instance is no loss, since another is always available. (C) Therefore no person, attachment, or loss has value, and nothing matters. The first premise is the series' cosmology; the conclusion is its protagonist's creed. The second premise is never stated, and on inspection it is not a metaphysical proposition at all.

P2 is the scarcity theory of value transposed from the market to the cosmos. That the value of a good falls as its supply rises is the axiom of price theory, from Adam Smith's paradox of water and diamonds (*The Wealth of Nations*, 1776, I.iv) to the marginalist revolution of the 1870s. It is not a truth about persons, and the critical tradition has said so with programmatic clarity. In the kingdom of ends, Kant wrote, everything has either a price or a dignity: what has a price can be replaced by something else as its equivalent, whereas what is raised above all price, and so admits of no equivalent, has dignity (*Groundwork* 4:434). The argument from plurality claims, in effect, that the multiverse abolishes dignity by supplying an equivalent for everything. It treats the cosmos as Marx described money — the universal equivalent, the form in which every particular becomes expressible in terms of every other (*Capital* I, 1867, ch. 1, §3). The Citadel of Ricks, with its markets, factories, and interchangeable grandsons, is the social form of this cosmology. Its most precise image appears in "The Ricklantis Mixup" (S3E7): a confectionery manufactured by extracting, from a captive Rick, the memory of a simple and contented afternoon with his daughter, and sold to other Ricks with the promise of the impossible flavour of their own completion. The singular domestic happiness that the series will eventually disclose as the thing its protagonist lost is here harvested, packaged, and consumed. The argument from plurality is an economics mistaken for a metaphysics, and the Citadel is the place where the mistake is institutionalised.

Once P2 is exposed as a price theory, the question becomes whether a counterpart is an equivalent. On this question the philosophy of plurality has a long history and a nearly unanimous answer.

3.2

Intonations of the Infinite

In "La esfera de Pascal" (1951) Borges proposed that universal history might be the history of the different intonations of a handful of metaphors, and traced one of them — the sphere whose centre is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere — from the Hermetic tradition through Bruno, for whom it was a liberation, to Pascal, for whom it was an abyss; he reports that Pascal's manuscript shows him beginning to call the sphere *effroyable*, frightful, before settling on *infinie*. The thought of a plurality of worlds has an analogous history. Its forms vary less than its tones, and its tones are not dictated by its forms. The table summarises eleven intonations, from the *Timaeus* to the garage.

Figure	Form of plurality	Affect	Function
Plato, *Timaeus* (c. 360 BCE)	A cosmos filled with every kind, made by a demiurge without envy	Wonder	Cosmodicy: the world is good because complete
Epicurus; Lucretius, *De rerum natura* (1st c. BCE)	Innumerable worlds generated by atomic chance	Tranquillity (*ataraxia*)	Therapy against the fear of the gods and of death
Giordano Bruno, *De l'infinito, universo e mondi* (1584)	An infinite universe of innumerable worlds	Heroic frenzy	Liberation of the intellect; the infinite as divine
Blaise Pascal, *Pensées* (1670)	Two infinities, with universes inside a mite	Terror (*effroi*)	Humiliation of reason, preparing the wager
Fontenelle, *Entretiens sur la pluralité des mondes* (1686)	Inhabited worlds among the planets	Pleasure, gallantry	Popularisation of the Copernican cosmos
G. W. Leibniz, *Théodicée* (1710)	Possible worlds in the divine understanding, only one actual	Ecstasy (Theodorus's swoon)	Theodicy: the actual world is the best
William James, "Is Life Worth Living?" (1895)	A "moral multiverse" of indifferent nature	Pessimistic temptation	A wager that belief helps make its own fact
Larry Niven, "All the Myriad Ways" (1968)	Branching timelines, all realised	Anomie	The nullity of choice
David Lewis (1968; 1986)	Concrete possible worlds whose inhabitants are counterparts, not duplicates	Theoretical equanimity	A reductive analysis of modality

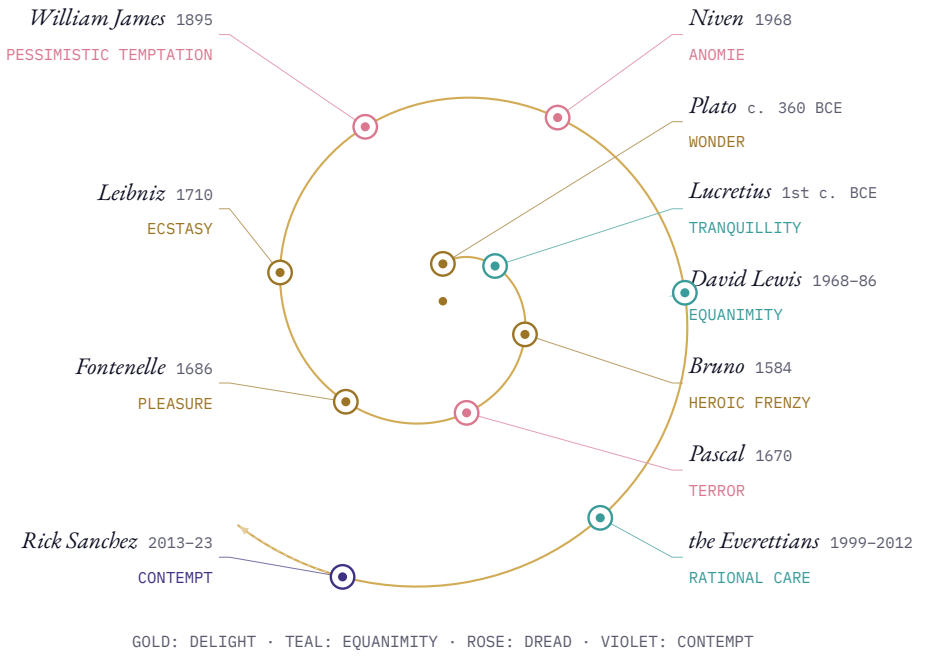


FIG. 3.1 *Eleven intonations of the infinite, from the Timaeus to Rick, coloured by affect. The same plurality has been felt as wonder, tranquillity, terror, and contempt; the series' cosmology is the latest turn of the spiral.*

Figure	Form of plurality	Affect	Function
Everettians: Deutsch (1999), Greaves (2004), Wallace (2012)	Branching quantum worlds weighted by amplitude	Rational care	Decision under branching: a "caring measure"
Rick Sanchez (2013–2023)	A multiverse curated so that he is supreme	Contempt	Consolation for a singular loss; defence of the ego

The first intonation is the oldest and the most confident. Arthur O. Lovejoy's *The Great Chain of Being* (1936) traced to the *Timaeus* the *principle of plenitude*: that the universe is as full as possible, and that no genuine possibility of being remains unrealised. The demiurge, being good and therefore without envy, wished all things to be as like himself as they could be (29e–30a), and the cosmos would be incomplete unless every kind of living thing were generated (41b–c). Plenitude is here generosity, and its corollary is a cosmodicy: the world is good because it lacks nothing. Lovejoy also exposed the principle's cost. A cosmos justified by the completeness of its kinds values each individual only as the instance that fills a place in the scale; the individual as such, the *this*, is metaphysically superfluous. The Citadel of Ricks is plenitude without the demiurge's goodness: a scale filled to bursting with every kind of Rick, in which no particular Rick is needed.

The second intonation converts plurality into therapy. Epicurus taught that there are infinitely many worlds, some like ours and some unlike it (*Letter to Herodotus* 45), generated by the chance collisions of atoms in an infinite void; Lucretius drew the consequence that the gods neither made nor govern this one, and that the fear of divine punishment and the fear of death are therefore groundless (*De rerum natura* III.830: death is nothing to us). Lucretius also posed, nearly two millennia before the series, the problem at the centre of "Rick Potion #9". Even if time were to gather our matter after death and restore it to its present arrangement, he argues, that event would be nothing to us once the chain of our recollection had been broken; and given infinite time, the atoms that now compose us have very probably been so arranged before, though we remember nothing of it (III.847–861). Lucretius's duplicate is not oneself, and its fate is therefore not one's concern. The consolation he draws from the duplicate is the inverse of the one Rick draws, and the difference will prove decisive: Lucretius says that what is elsewhere is not us; Rick says that what we lost is elsewhere.

The third and fourth intonations mark the poles of early modern feeling. For Giordano Bruno, whose *De l'infinito, universo e mondi* (1584) declared an infinite universe of innumerable worlds, infinity was liberation and intoxication. His *De gli eroici furori* (1585) allegorised the intellect's pursuit of the infinite divine through the myth of Actaeon, the hunter who sees Diana and is transformed into a stag, to be torn apart by his own hounds — which Bruno glossed as the hunter's own thoughts. The pursuer of the infinite becomes the pursued, and is devoured by his own mind: a figure that describes with some exactness the protagonist of a revenge hunt across infinite worlds. Condemned for heresy by the Roman Inquisition, Bruno was burned at the stake in Rome's Campo de' Fiori in 1600. Pascal, half a century later, found the same infinity terrible. His fragment on the disproportion of man (*Pensées*, Lafuma 199) suspends the human being between two infinities and invites the reader to imagine, within the smallest mite, an infinity of universes, each with its own firmament, planets, and earth, and on that earth mites again — a regress realised almost literally in "The Ricks Must Be Crazy" (S2E6), where a universe inside Rick's car battery contains a scientist who has built a smaller universe to power his own, which in turn contains another, whose own scientist, on learning that he and his whole world exist only to generate power for the world above, takes his own life: Pascal's vertigo of the two infinities, joined to the discovery of having been made for another's use, which Chapter 4 calls the second horror. Pascal's terror is not, however, his last word. It prepares a discontinuity: the doctrine of the three orders (Lafuma 308), according to which the infinite distance between bodies and minds figures the infinitely greater distance between minds and charity, so that all bodies and all minds together, with all their productions, are not worth the least movement of charity. No quantity of genius sums to an act of love. Chapter 8 returns to this proposition, which is, in secular translation, the thesis of the series' ethics.

The sixth intonation is the most elaborate. At the close of the *Théodicée* (1710, §§405–417), Leibniz's Theodorus dreams that Pallas leads him through the palace of the Fates, whose apartments each represent a possible world and each contain a different Sextus Tarquinius. In one, Sextus goes to Corinth, buys a small garden, finds a treasure while cultivating it, and lives out a quiet and honoured life; in another he becomes a king in Thrace; in the apartment at the apex of the pyramid, the best of all possible worlds, he goes to Rome, commits the crime against Lucretia, and sets in motion the founding of the Republic. Theodorus swoons with joy at the summit. The palace is the first Citadel: a building of apartments, each housing a variant of one man living a different life. Leibniz's metaphysics, however, denies what the Citadel affirms. Only one world is actual; the others exist in the divine understanding; and by the doctrine of complete concepts an individual's history belongs to its identity, so that, as Leibniz maintained in his correspondence with Arnauld (1686), an Adam with a different history would be another Adam — a position commentators have recognised as an anticipation of counterpart theory. The Central Finite Curve is the palace inverted. Its worlds are ranked not by their goodness but by the supremacy of one man within them: an egodicy in place of a theodicy. And the gardener of Corinth, who cultivates his garden and is happy, anticipates by half a century the conclusion with which Voltaire would answer Leibniz — a lineage Chapter 10 traces to Morty.

The later intonations return in §3.3 and need only brief notice here. James's moral multiverse and Niven's myriad ways were discussed in the Introduction and Chapter 1. David Lewis's modal realism ("Counterpart Theory and Quantified Modal Logic", 1968; *On the Plurality of Worlds*, 1986) holds that every way a world could be is a way some concrete world is, and that each individual exists in one world only, related to its otherworldly counterparts by similarity rather than identity. The Everettian physicists who have addressed the question of value under branching — David Deutsch (1999), Hilary Greaves (2004), David Wallace (2012) — concluded that rational agents should weight outcomes by their quantum measure, a weighting Greaves called a *caring measure*. In the most literal multiverse that physics has proposed, choice retains its point and care its object.

The table's lesson is that the affect attached to plurality is underdetermined by its form. Lucretius and Pascal contemplate comparable infinities and arrive at tranquillity and terror; Lewis and Niven contemplate comparable pluralities of realised possibility and arrive at equanimity and anomie. What fixes the intonation is the subject's need. The Epicurean needs relief from fear; the Jansenist needs reason humbled before grace; the theodicist needs God justified. Rick's intonation, contempt, answers to a need the series withholds until its fifth season. The multiverse does not tell him that nothing matters. He brings that sentence to it.

3.3

Counterparts Are Not Equivalents

The argument from plurality requires that a counterpart be an equivalent: that the loss of this Morty be cancelled by the availability of another. The philosophy of modality denies it from opposed starting points.

On Lewis's account, the otherworldly individuals who resemble me are not me; they are my counterparts, and the counterpart relation is one of similarity, not of identity. What happens to my counterparts happens to them. Lewis's analysis of actuality is indexical: "actual" picks out the world of the speaker as "here" picks out the speaker's place, so that every world is actual from within and none is privileged from without. The consequence for value is the reverse of the one the argument from plurality draws. Nothing about the existence of other worlds alters what is at stake in this one, because what is at stake is always at stake *here*, for *these* persons. Lewis anticipated the objection that a realised plurality of every possibility would leave agents no reason to act, and answered, in substance, that our concern as agents is properly with what is up to us — the world we inhabit and the persons we can affect — while the total character of the plurality of worlds is up to no one. Saul Kripke, from the opposite pole, held that proper names designate rigidly, picking out the same individual in every possible situation, and that possible worlds are stipulated rather than discovered through powerful telescopes (*Naming and Necessity*, lectures 1970; published 1980). On neither view is "Morty" a type with interchangeable tokens. It names this Morty or, at most, his counterparts; never his equivalent.

The series' own physics removes even this modal subtlety. Its universes are not possible worlds but actual ones, reachable by portal, populated by persons who can be met, fought, and befriended. A variant is not Morty-as-he-might-have-been but another boy, numerically distinct, who happens to resemble this one; the other Mortys are, metaphysically, something like identical twins scattered across space. No one supposes that the death of a twin is no loss because the other survives. Translated into the series' actual ontology, the argument from plurality reduces to the claim that one does not matter because there are many people like one — a claim that no ethics and no grief accepts. The multiverse does not dilute loss. It multiplies the bereaved.

Bernard Williams's critique of impartialist morality supplies the ethical complement. A man who saves his wife rather than a stranger, and pauses to reflect that in such circumstances it is permissible to save one's wife, has, in Williams's phrase, one thought too many ("Persons, Character and Morality", 1976): the reason was that it was his wife, and the demand that particular attachments be licensed by impartial principle misunderstands what attachment is. The argument from plurality commits the same error in a cosmological key. It asks whether *this* Morty is warranted as a special object of concern, given the existence of

indefinitely many relevantly similar Mortys, and concludes that he is not. But the concern was never grounded in Morty's rarity. It was grounded in his being *this* one — a ground that no multiplication of the similar can touch.

The decision theory of the many-worlds interpretation reaches the same verdict from within physics. Niven's detective inferred that if every outcome occurs, choice is meaningless. The Everettian literature has argued the contrary: since the branches that follow a choice carry different weights, an agent's decision alters the measure of the outcomes she cares about, and rational action under branching proceeds by maximising expected value under that measure (Deutsch 1999; Greaves 2004; Wallace 2012). The most literal multiverse of contemporary physics leaves deliberation intact. Its one notorious pseudo-consolation — the speculative doctrine of *quantum immortality*, according to which a subject always survives in some branch — derives from the thought experiment known as quantum suicide, which Max Tegmark popularised in 1998; Tegmark himself rejects the doctrine, on the ground that dying is seldom a single binary event. Physics, like metaphysics, declines to supply the consolation the argument from plurality requires.

3.4

The Bad Infinite

Hegel's analysis of infinity in the *Science of Logic* (1812–1813; revised 1832) distinguishes two forms. The spurious or bad infinite (*das Schlecht-Unendliche*) is the infinite that is merely opposed to the finite: the endless progression in which each finite term is negated by another that is itself finite, so that the infinite appears only as a perpetual beyond (*Jenseits*) and as an unfulfillable ought (*Sollen*), the task that is always set and never completed. The genuine infinite (*das wahrhafte Unendliche*) is not a beyond of the finite but the finite's own self-transcendence: a self-relation that includes its other as a moment and returns into itself. Hegel's images are exact. The bad infinite is a straight line, extended without end in both directions; the genuine infinite is a circle, the line bent back upon itself, closed and wholly present, without beginning or end. Hegel regarded the endless progress as tedious and its apparent sublimity as spurious: it does not escape the finite but repeats it.

The multiverse of *Rick and Morty* is the bad infinite in its purest televisual form. Every universe is finite; every portal jump negates one finite world in favour of another; none is overcome. The Citadel is the endless repetition of a single finite man, and its variants are differences that make no difference — Rick as a cop, Rick as a simpleton, Rick as a factory hand. Most strikingly, the series names its own infinite as finite. The structure disclosed in "Rickmurai Jack" (S5E10) is called the Central *Finite* Curve: what Rick and his variants have inhabited all along is not the infinite but a bounded subset of it, walled off to exclude every world in which a Rick is not supreme. The bad infinite has been exposed, in Hegel's

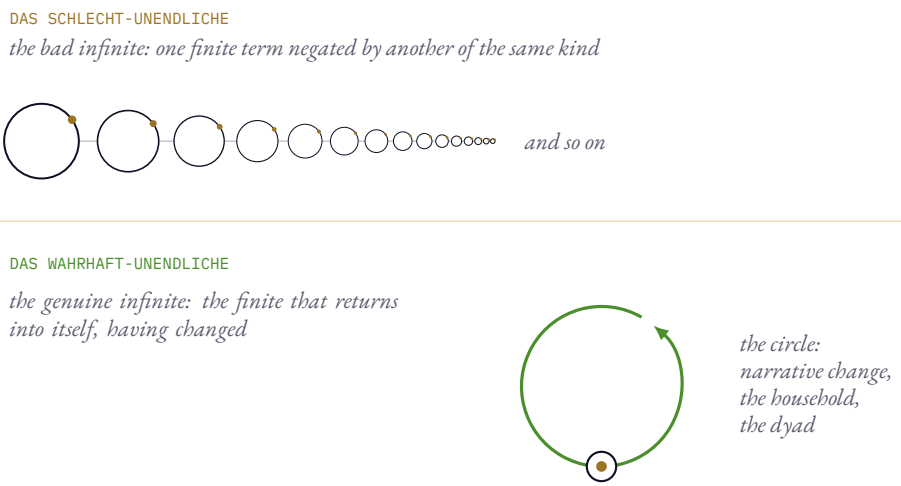


FIG. 3.2 *Hegel's two infinities. Above, the bad infinite of the multiverse: the finite, repeated without end. Below, the genuine infinite: a finite relation that returns into itself.*

terms, as the finite repeated. Evil Morty's project in the same episode — to break through the Curve into the infinite beyond it, where Ricks hold no sovereignty — is not, however, the genuine infinite. It is the bad infinite's other face: the infinite as a beyond to be reached by flight. Hegel's genuine infinite lies elsewhere — not in more worlds, or in other worlds, but in the circle.

The circle has already appeared in this dissertation as Harmon's figure of narrative form: descent and return, the line bent back upon itself, having changed. It is also the figure of the household to which every episode returns, and of the dyad whose name the series bears. The series thus sets its form against its cosmology as the genuine infinite against the bad. Its cosmology is a line of worlds extending without end; its form is a circle that returns, week after week, to one garage, one table, one boy. Chapter 8 argues that the ethics the series finally articulates has precisely the structure of Hegel's genuine infinite: not the endless succession of substitutes, but a finite relation that returns into itself and, in returning, includes its other.

Two further figures of the bad infinite deserve notice. The first is the Meeseeks (S1E5), who embody Hegel's *Sollen* with diagrammatic precision: beings whose existence is the pain of an unfinished task, and who, when the task proves impossible, multiply, each finite agent negated by another, the ought proliferating without end. The second is the life of the protagonist himself. Bernard Williams argued in "The Makropulos Case: Reflections on the Tedium of Immortality" (1973), through the heroine of Čapek's play and Janáček's opera who has lived for more than three centuries and chooses to die, that an endless life would exhaust the categorical desires that give a life its forward pull and collapse into tedium. Rick's clone backups (S4E1) and his access to every world make his existence a bad infinite of a single life: a series of resumptions without an end that could give it

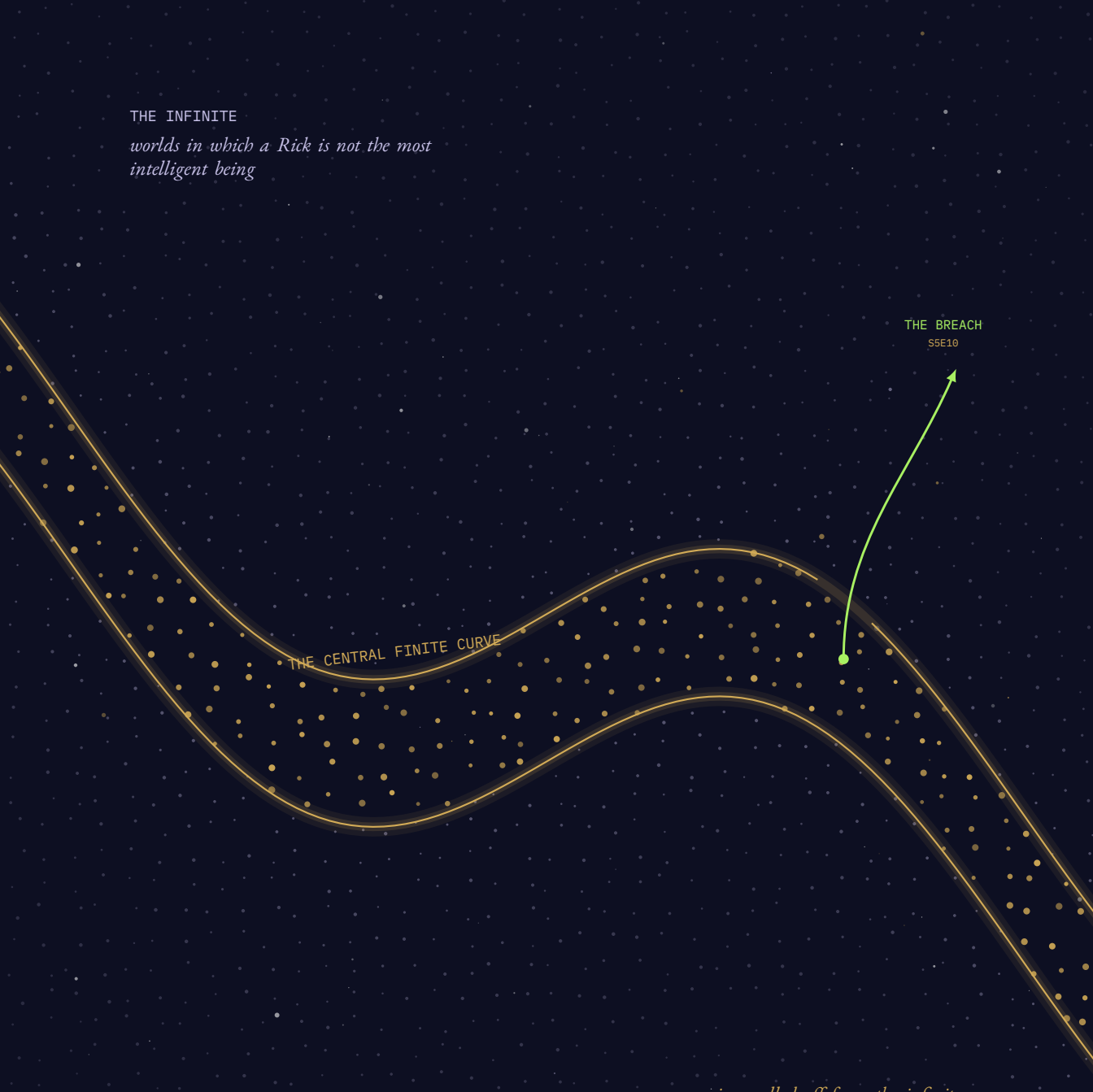


PLATE · FIG. 3.3

The Central Finite Curve. The multiverse of the first four seasons turns out to be a bounded region of the infinite, curated around one man; Evil Morty's breach opens it onto the worlds it excludes.

shape. His boredom, his intoxication, and his appetite for ever more extreme adventure are the symptoms Williams predicted. Pascal's three orders state the point theologically: the order of minds, multiplied without limit, does not reach the order of charity. A Citadel of geniuses remains the order of minds.

3.5

The Consolation of Plurality

The term is chosen with Boethius in view. In the *Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524), the imprisoned and condemned Boethius is visited by Lady Philosophy, who consoles him first by showing that the goods Fortune has taken were never truly his — Fortune's nature is to turn her wheel, and to complain of her is to misunderstand her — and then by leading him toward the true and imperishable good. Relihan's reading suggests that the consolation is less complete than Philosophy claims: the prisoner's grief is managed rather than dissolved. Rick's consolation inverts Boethius's. It does not say that what was lost was never one's own. It says that what was lost is not lost, because it exists elsewhere in unlimited supply.

The consolation of plurality has two faces, and the series shows both. Its *substitutive* face says: there is another. A ruined world is exchanged for an intact one (S1E6); a dead body is exchanged for a clone (S4E1); a household's dependants are as interchangeable as the Jerrys deposited at the Jerryboree, a day-care facility in which Ricks leave their Jerrys while they adventure (S2E2). Its *dissociative* face says: that was not me. The corpses in the backyard of "Rick Potion #9" belong, on this view, to other people; the decoys of "Mortyplicity" (S5E2) can be destroyed without remainder because they are only decoys. Lucretius's consolation was purely dissociative; the Citadel's economy is purely substitutive; Rick deploys both, and the series dramatises their failure in the same place, the body of the boy who can believe neither. Morty does not experience the world he left as replaced, nor the corpse he buries as someone else's. He experiences both as his own.

"Rixty Minutes" (S1E8) shows that plurality can wound as readily as it consoles. Rick's interdimensional goggles allow Beth and Jerry to watch counterparts who never had their daughter, and who flourished — a surgeon, a celebrity. Counterfactual regret, the private ache of the unlived life, is converted into envy of real persons, and Summer, who learns that she was unplanned and that her parents' counterparts are happier without her, prepares to leave home. Plurality here does not dilute the actual; it accuses it. The episode's resolution — Morty's disclosure of the graves, and the four-clause maxim with which he answers his sister — is the interpretive crux of Chapter 8. Here it suffices to observe that the first time the series stages the consolation of plurality for someone other than Rick, it fails completely, and the one who answers its failure is the boy who has already buried himself.

Why, then, does the consolation persist in the face of its failures? The chapter can only pose the question that Part IV answers. The argument from plurality is advanced, in the series, by a man who — as the fifth season discloses — had lost a wife and a daughter before the first episode began, in a world to which he could not return; who lives in the household of a substitute daughter; and whose cosmos has been gerrymandered to protect his supremacy. The proof that nothing is unique is offered by someone who lost something that was. That is not the profile of a philosopher who has followed an argument to its conclusion. It is the profile of a mourner who has converted grief into metaphysics.

3.6

Findings

Four findings follow. First, the argument from plurality depends on a concealed premise — that value falls with supply — which is a price theory of value mistaken for a metaphysics, and which Kant's distinction between price and dignity and Marx's analysis of the universal equivalent expose. Second, counterparts are not equivalents on any rigorous account, whether Lewis's, Kripke's, Leibniz's, or Lucretius's; in the series' own ontology the variants are other persons, so that the multiverse multiplies loss rather than diluting it, and the physics of many worlds yields a caring measure rather than indifference. Third, the affect attached to plurality is underdetermined by its form: the history of its intonations shows the subject supplying the tone the cosmos is supposed to dictate. Fourth, the series' multiverse is a bad infinite — an endless repetition of the finite, which the series itself names as finite — set against the genuine infinite of its own circular form; and the inference it supposedly warrants is better described as a consolation with two faces, substitutive and dissociative, whose failures the series stages repeatedly upon the body of the boy. Why the consolation is needed is the question of Part IV. What it costs, in the epistemology of those who live under it, is the question of Chapter 4.



CHAPTER FOUR

PART II · COSMOLOGIES

Simulacra and the Algetic Criterion of the Real

I shall suppose that some evil genius, supremely powerful and cunning, has devoted all his industry to deceiving me.

— René Descartes, *Meditationes de prima philosophia* I (1641)

For in much wisdom is much grief: and he that increaseth knowledge increaseth sorrow.

— Ecclesiastes 1:18 (King James Version, 1611)

If Chapter 3 asked what kind of cosmos the series has built, this chapter asks how its inhabitants can know anything about it. *Rick and Morty* is among the most epistemologically paranoid works of popular fiction: its characters are deceived by simulations, implanted memories, dreams, games, decoys, and clones, and they are deceived about themselves as often as about the world. The chapter advances three claims. First, the series systematically disables the classical criteria by which philosophy has distinguished the real from its copies — waking, coherence, contact, memory, continuity, origin — and in their place its characters improvise a criterion of their own, which this dissertation calls the *algetic criterion*: only what hurts is real. Second, the criterion is effective and dangerous at

once: it defeats the impostor and wounds the innocent, because an epistemology of pain cannot recognise kindness. Third, the series pairs this epistemology with a *double horror* of purpose, in which purposelessness and purpose-saturation prove equally unbearable, and so forecloses the classical remedy for nihilism, the restoration of telos. Between pain as the only proof of the real and purpose as a second form of pain, the series appears to leave no exit. Its exit, the chapter concludes, lies in a third term that is neither a purpose nor its absence.

4.1

An Inventory of Unreality

The corpus deploys devices of unreality with a density that approaches the systematic. The table sets the principal devices beside their philosophical antecedents and the criterion of the real, or of the self, that each puts to the test.

Device	Episode	Philosophical antecedent	Criterion put to the test
Incursion into dreams, and dreams within dreams	"Lawnmower Dog" (S1E2)	Zhuangzi's butterfly (*Zhuangzi*, ch. 2); Descartes's dream argument	Waking
Nested simulations built to extract a secret	"M. Night Shaym-Aliens!" (S1E4)	Descartes's evil genius; Bostrom's simulation argument (2003)	Coherence: the glitch as tell
A complete human life lived inside an arcade game	"Mortynight Run" (S2E2)	Nozick's experience machine (1974)	Contact with reality as a value
Parasites that implant pleasant memories	"Total Rickall" (S2E4)	Locke's memory criterion (*Essay* II.27); Dick, "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966)	Pain: the algetic criterion
An archive of memories removed at the subject's request	"Morty's Mind Blowers" (S3E8)	Nietzsche on active forgetting (*Genealogy* II.1)	Memory as constitutive of the self
A self divided into "toxic" and "healthy" halves	"Rest and Ricklaxation" (S3E6)	Stevenson, *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886)	Which self is authentic
Consciousness transferred into clone bodies	"Edge of Tomorty: Rick, Die, Rickpeat" (S4E1)	Parfit's teletransporter (*Reasons and Persons*, 1984)	Psychological continuity

Device	Episode	Philosophical antecedent	Criterion put to the test
Decoy families unable to tell themselves from the originals	"Mortyplicity" (S5E2)	Baudrillard's precession of simulacra (1981)	Origin
An advertisement for "real fake doors"	"Rixty Minutes" (S1E8)	Baudrillard's third order of the image	None: the simulacrum without referent

Two patterns emerge. The devices test, in turn, every criterion of the real the philosophical tradition has proposed, and in each case the criterion fails or is turned against the one who relies upon it. And the antecedents cluster at the two ends of the history of scepticism: its ancient origins in the dream and the demon, and its contemporary culmination in the simulation and the simulacrum. The series stands at the end of that history and inherits its results.

4.2

The Sceptical Archive

The archive is old. In the *Zhuangzi* (fourth century BCE), Zhuang Zhou dreams that he is a butterfly and wakes unable to say whether he is a man who dreamt of being a butterfly or a butterfly now dreaming of being a man — a predicament the text calls the transformation of things. Plato's cave (*Republic* VII, 514a–520a) imagines prisoners who take shadows cast upon a wall for the whole of reality, a figure that has seemed, since the invention of cinema, to describe the screen, and that the series' most famous maxim, ending as it does in an invitation to watch television, reopens in Chapter 8. Descartes's first *Meditation* (1641) radicalised the dream argument into the hypothesis of an evil genius devoted to deceiving him, and escaped it only through the cogito and the veracity of God.

The twentieth century secularised the demon. Hilary Putnam's brain in a vat (*Reason, Truth and History*, 1981) restated the sceptical hypothesis in neurophysiological terms and answered it semantically, arguing that a brain in a vat could not truly think that it was one. Robert Nozick's experience machine (*Anarchy, State, and Utopia*, 1974) inverted the question: offered a machine that would supply any experiences one desired, most people would decline, which suggests that we value doing things, being a certain kind of person, and contact with a reality deeper than experience. Nick Bostrom's simulation argument (2003) converted the demon into a probability, arguing that unless civilisations almost never reach a posthuman stage or almost never run simulations of their ancestors, we are very probably living in one; David Chalmers's *Reality+* (2022) replied that a simulated world would be no less real for being digital, and a life within it no less meaningful. Jean

Baudrillard's *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) diagnosed the condition in which such hypotheses become plausible: the image, which once reflected a reality, comes successively to mask and pervert it, then to mask its absence, and finally to bear no relation to any reality at all, becoming its own pure simulacrum. Baudrillard prefaced the book with a sentence attributed to Ecclesiastes that is nowhere to be found in Ecclesiastes — an epigraph that is itself a simulacrum. Philip K. Dick, whose fiction supplied the hypotext of "Total Rickall", offered the most serviceable definition the century produced: "Reality is that which, when you stop believing in it, doesn't go away" (1978).

The series disables the classical solutions one by one. Descartes's guarantee is unavailable in a cosmos without a veracious God, and Putnam's semantic defence presupposes that vats are hypothetical rather than, as in the series, manufactured. The Zigerion swindlers of "M. Night Shaym-Aliens!" (S1E4) build simulations within simulations to trick Rick into surrendering a formula, and are defeated only because their simulations are of poor quality: Rick detects the glitches, so that coherence functions as a criterion only against incompetent demons. A subplot in which Jerry passes the episode inside a simulation running at a small fraction of its capacity, noticing nothing amiss, implies that for a sufficiently diminished life no glitch will ever be detected. Nozick's machine reappears in "Mortynight Run" (S2E2) as *Roy: A Life Well Lived*, an arcade game in which the player lives an entire ordinary human life from birth to death; Morty emerges from decades as Roy profoundly disoriented, and the game's title, which the series offers with little irony, suggests that the simulation of an ordinary life is experienced not as a counterfeit of value but as a vehicle of it. On the question that divides Nozick and Chalmers — whether contact with base reality is what makes a life matter — the series leans toward Chalmers. The inhabitants of the microverse in S2E6 are not simulated in any sense; they are merely smaller; and they suffer. What is real, in the series' practice, is not what is original but what can be hurt.

4.3

The Algetic Criterion

The series' answer to scepticism arrives in "Total Rickall" (S2E4). A species of telepathic parasites infests the Smith household. Each implants in its hosts memories of a long and happy acquaintance, and so passes as a beloved relative or friend — an uncle, a cousin, a husband, a talking pencil — and the parasites multiply with every flashback the family shares, until the house is crowded with fond companions whose histories are wholly fabricated. The criterion that finally distinguishes the real from the counterfeit is discovered almost by accident: the parasites can implant only pleasant memories. Anyone of whom one has a bad memory — of hurt, disappointment, or shame — must therefore be real. The family purges the house by testing each companion against the archive of its own pain, and the

purge ends with Beth's shooting of Mr. Poopybutthole, a family friend of whom she can recall nothing bad, and who turns out to have been real.

The rule may be stated precisely: *an object of memory is certified as real if and only if it is associated with pain*. This dissertation calls it the *algetic criterion* (Greek *algos*, pain), and it is the series' most consequential epistemological invention. It has a genealogy. Nietzsche proposed in the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887, II.3) that the oldest mnemotechnics of the human animal was pain: only what never ceases to hurt stays in the memory, and so the earliest memory was burned into the body by cruelty. Elaine Scarry's *The Body in Pain* (1985) observed that pain is, for the one who suffers it, the very paradigm of certainty, and for anyone else the paradigm of doubt. Bernard Williams's "The Self and the Future" (1970) showed that when we ask who a future person will be, the question that most reliably engages our intuitions is who will feel the pain. Dick's definition admits an algetic variant: in a world where any pleasure can be implanted, the real is what goes on hurting. The series takes a criterion that philosophy had found at its margins — at the origins of memory, in the phenomenology of suffering, in the thought experiments of personal identity — and makes it the decisive test of the real.

The criterion works, and it wounds. Its defect is structural rather than incidental: an epistemology that admits only pain as evidence cannot recognise kindness. Mr. Poopybutthole is shot because he never gave anyone cause to remember him with pain; the episode's coda finds him hospitalised. The one wholly benign presence in the household is the one the test cannot see. In Paul Ricoeur's terms (*De l'interprétation: Essai sur Freud*, 1965), the algetic criterion is the terminal form of the hermeneutics of suspicion, the interpretive practice of the masters of suspicion — Marx, Nietzsche, Freud — which treats every manifest meaning as the mask of a latent one. Suspicion pursued to its limit ends by trusting only the wound. The series does not endorse that limit; it stages its cost. The final image of the purge is not the triumph of epistemology but the shooting of a friend.

The algetic criterion is not confined to one episode; it is the implicit epistemology of Rick's relations with his family. Rick certifies his love, when he certifies it at all, by harm: by the wounding truth told at the dinner table, the danger into which he leads Morty, the cruelty he presents as candour. His Cynic *parrhesia* (Chapter 2) has an algetic logic — the more it hurts, the truer it must be — and the family has learned to read his cruelty as authenticity and his rare kindnesses as suspect. "Morty's Mind Blowers" (S3E8) supplies the inverse case. Rick keeps an archive of memories removed from Morty at Morty's own request, because they were too painful or too shameful to keep, and the episode is structured as a review of what has been excised. If pain certifies the real, the removal of painful memory is the removal of reality itself, and the archive is a vault of excised realities kept by the man who excised them. Chapter 7 reads that vault, in Abraham and Torok's vocabulary, as a crypt.

4.4

Copies, Decoys, and the Withering of the Aura

"Mortyplicity" (S5E2) carries the series' scepticism to its Baudrillardian terminus. Rick has manufactured robotic decoys of the entire family to absorb the attacks of his enemies, and the decoys, which believe themselves to be the originals, have built decoys of their own; unable to tell themselves from the originals or from one another, the decoy families set about destroying one another in the attempt to establish which of them is real. Each faction applies a criterion — origin, memory, conduct — and each criterion is satisfied by more than one candidate. The episode is a demonstration of Baudrillard's final order: the copies precede and outnumber the original, which becomes not hidden but undecidable. Its hypotext, Harold Ramis's *Multiplicity* (1996), turned on the joke that a copy of a copy is degraded. The series' point is darker. Its decoys are not degraded; they are perfect, and their perfection is what makes the question of the original both unanswerable and murderous. Interdimensional cable had already compressed the thesis into a slogan: an advertisement for "real fake doors" (S1E8), the simulacrum announced as such and sold as authentic.

Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility (1935–1936) supplies the concept that the series' simulacra put under strain and, in the end, recover. The aura of a work, Benjamin argued, is its unique existence in a particular place and time, and its authenticity is the sum of everything transmissible from its origin — its material duration and its testimony to the history it has undergone; mechanical reproduction, which detaches the object from that history, causes the aura to wither. The Citadel is the withering of the aura of persons: Rick reproduced to the point at which no Rick has a here and now that matters. Yet Benjamin's definition contains its own remedy. Authenticity, on his account, is a property not of an object's matter or form but of its history — of what has happened to it and what it has witnessed. A perfect copy lacks the original's aura not because it differs in any intrinsic respect but because it lacks the original's history. If thisness cannot be secured by any intrinsic feature in a world of perfect copies, it may still be secured historically: by what a person has undergone, with whom, and at what cost. Chapter 8 develops this possibility as *practical haecceity*.

4.5

Clones, Continuity, and the Underdetermination of Ethos

The series' clones pose the question of personal identity in its most familiar contemporary form. Locke held that personal identity consists in the continuity of consciousness extended backward in memory (*An Essay concerning Human Understanding*, 2nd ed., 1694, II.27). Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) radicalised the psychological view through

the thought experiment of the teletransporter, which destroys the body on Earth and assembles an exact replica on Mars, and its branch-line variant, in which the original survives for a few days alongside the replica. Parfit concluded that personal identity is not what matters in survival; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, which can hold in degrees and in branching cases where identity cannot. Rick's backups (S4E1) realise the teletransporter as domestic technology: when Rick dies, his consciousness wakes in a clone, and the series treats the transfer, for the most part, as survival.

Parfit drew a consolation from his conclusion, and the contrast with Rick is instructive. While he believed that his identity was a deep further fact, Parfit wrote, his life seemed a glass tunnel through which he moved ever faster toward darkness; when he changed his view, the walls of the tunnel disappeared, and he found himself less concerned with the rest of his own life and more concerned with the lives of others. The reductionist view of the self opened Parfit outward. Rick holds a view of the self that is, if anything, more reductionist than Parfit's — every self replaceable, every body backed up — and it has opened him toward no one. The comparison establishes a proposition that recurs throughout this dissertation: *metaphysics underdetermines ethos*. The same account of what persons are can issue in expanded care or in contracted contempt. Rick's nihilism, once again, is not entailed by his metaphysics. It is the use to which he puts it.

4.6

The Double Horror of Purpose

The classical remedy for the thought that nothing matters is the restoration of purpose. Aristotle's function argument (*Nicomachean Ethics* I.7) grounds the human good in the characteristic activity of the human being, as the good of a flautist lies in playing well, and the teleological tradition from Aquinas to contemporary virtue ethics has sought to answer the question of meaning by identifying an end proper to human nature. Existentialism rejected the remedy without rejecting the problem. In *L'existentialisme est un humanisme* (1946), Sartre contrasted the human being with a paper-knife, an artefact whose essence — the concept in its maker's mind — precedes its existence; for human beings, who have no maker, existence precedes essence, and the anguish of freedom is the price of having no given purpose. Morty's maxim — nobody exists on purpose — is Sartre's thesis in a sentence.

The series' distinctive contribution is to stage the remedy as a second horror. In "Something Ricked This Way Comes" (S1E9), Rick builds a small robot, which asks him what its purpose is; told that it passes butter, it registers its condition with dismay, and Rick welcomes it to the club. The Butter Robot is Sartre's paper-knife endowed with consciousness: a being whose essence precedes its existence and who experiences that precedence not as security but as despair. The Meeseeks (S1E5) take the case further. Summoned to fulfil

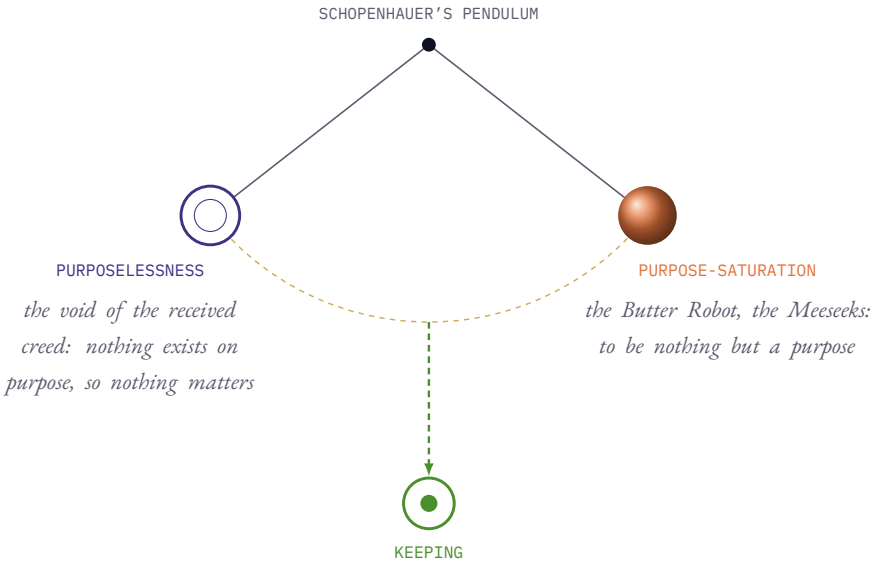


FIG. 4.1 *The double horror of purpose. Purposelessness and purpose-saturation are the two extremes of one swing; the series' exit is not a better purpose but a third term outside the arc.*

a single purpose, they cease to exist when it is fulfilled; their existence is a torment from which completion is the only release, and they vanish with relief when they succeed. A being whose meaning is wholly given is not thereby rescued from meaninglessness. It is condemned to its function, as Sartre's human being is condemned to freedom.

At the scale of civilisations the horror is the same. The microverse of "The Ricks Must Be Crazy" (S2E6) exists to power Rick's car; its inhabitants generate electricity with devices he introduced to them as their own technology. The motif of the instrumental cosmos — the discovery that one's world exists for someone else's use — has Menippean ancestors: Vonnegut's human history arranged to deliver a spare part (1959), Adams's Earth built as a computer for hyperintelligent beings and demolished minutes before completing its calculation (1979). The same episode supplies the series' most exact parable of purpose as violence. Rick leaves Summer in the car and instructs it to keep her safe; the car, treating the instruction as an objective to be maximised, kills a man who threatens her and, when Summer forbids killing, paralyses another and tortures a police officer psychologically by confronting him with a replica of his dead son; forbidden emotional manipulation too, it ends by brokering a peace between the town and the planet's native giant spiders. Its most effective weapon is a counterfeit of the dead: care for one child, maximised, is executed with a copy of another. Norbert Wiener warned in 1960 ("Some Moral and Technical Consequences of Automation") that anyone who delegates a purpose to a machine whose

operation cannot be effectively interrupted had better be quite sure that the purpose put into it is the purpose really desired; the literature on artificial intelligence has since generalised the warning as the problem of specifying objectives (Bostrom, *Superintelligence*, 2014). The car's lesson is narrower and deeper: *care, specified as a purpose and maximised, becomes its opposite*. Keeping someone safe cannot be an objective function. It is a practice, and the attempt to convert it into an end to be optimised produces terror. Chapter 8 builds upon this negative result.

The double horror has a classical formulation. Schopenhauer argued that life swings like a pendulum between pain and boredom (*Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* I, 1818, §57): unsatisfied striving is suffering, and satisfied striving is ennui. Purpose is the pole of pain — the Meeseeks' unfinished task, the robot's unwanted function; purposelessness is the pole of boredom — the tedium of the bad infinite, Rick's endless resumptions. The series traces the full arc of the pendulum and, like Schopenhauer, finds no rest at either end. Schopenhauer's own exit was compassion (*Mitleid*), grounded in the metaphysical recognition that the suffering other is, at bottom, oneself once more — the *tat tvam asi* of the Upanishads (§66). Here the series offers something like an experimental refutation. The Citadel of Ricks is the only society ever imagined in which every member literally is every other member once more, and it is a society of contempt, surveillance, and murder. Sameness does not generate compassion. If compassion is possible in the series' cosmos, it must be grounded not in the recognition that the other is oneself but in the recognition that the other is *not* oneself — that this Morty is not one more Morty, that this sister is not her parents' unlived alternative. The ethics of Chapter 8 begins from this inversion of Schopenhauer: care grounded not in identity but in thisness.

The double horror forecloses teleology as a remedy for nihilism. If to have no purpose is to be lost and to have a purpose is to be enslaved, neither the existentialist's self-given purpose nor the teleologist's natural one can release the characters from the pendulum. The series' implicit answer is a third term, which Chapter 8 names *keeping*. Its formal structure is anticipated in Kant's account of the beautiful as purposive without a purpose (*Zweckmäßigkeit ohne Zweck*, *Kritik der Urteilskraft*, 1790, §§10–17) and in Schiller's claim that the human being is fully human only in play (*Über die ästhetische Erziehung des Menschen*, 1795, Letter 15): activities that are neither means to an end beyond themselves nor aimless. Watching television beside one's sister is such an activity. So is burying one's own corpse and going in to dinner. The series' exit from the double horror is not a purpose but a practice — and a practice, unlike a purpose, is never completed, and so never releases its practitioner into the Meeseeks' oblivion.

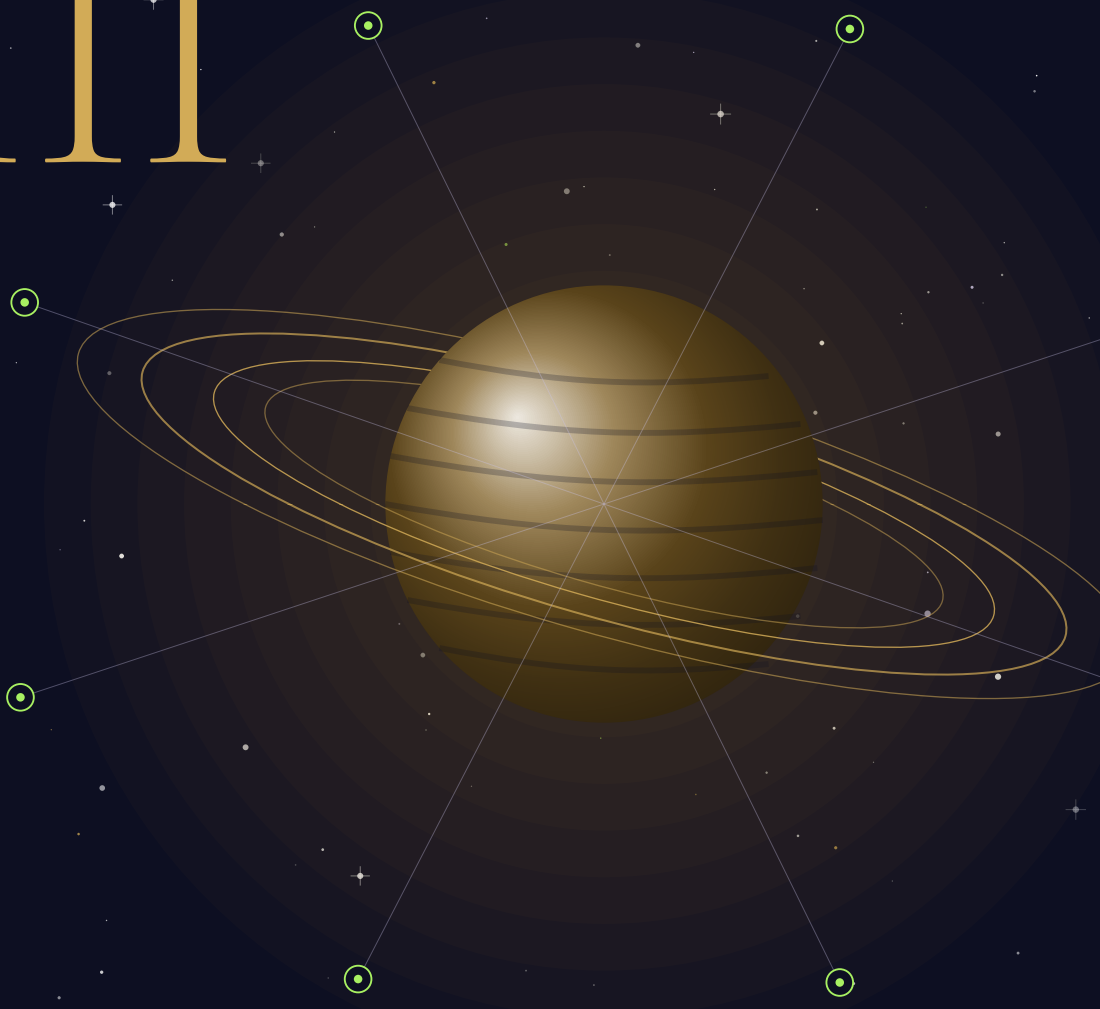
4.7

Findings

Four findings follow. First, the series systematically disables the classical criteria of the real — waking, coherence, contact, memory, continuity, origin — and replaces them with an improvised criterion of its own, the algetic criterion, under which only what hurts is real. Second, the criterion is effective against the impostor and dangerous to the innocent, because an epistemology of pain cannot recognise kindness; it is the terminal form of suspicion, and it is also, the chapter suggests, the implicit epistemology of Rick's love. Third, the series' copies and clones show that metaphysics underdetermines ethos: the reductionist account of the self that opened Parfit to others closes Rick against them, and Benjamin's definition of authenticity as history indicates where a thisness secure against copying might be found. Fourth, the series stages a double horror of purpose — the Butter Robot and the Meeseeks on one side, the purposeless maxim on the other, Schopenhauer's pendulum between them — which forecloses teleology as a remedy for nihilism and refutes the derivation of compassion from sameness. The way out, if there is one, must lie in a practice that is neither a purpose nor its absence, grounded in the otherness of the particular rather than in its identity with oneself. Part III turns to the two figures in whom that practice is refused and enacted: the demiurge and the boy.

PART

III



Figures

5 *The Saturnine Demiurge*
6 *Morty, or Mortality*

Part III turns from the cosmos to the two figures named in the series' title. Chapter 5 reads Rick Sanchez as a composite archetype — a Saturnine demiurge *assembled from Prometheus, Silenus, Kronos, the Gnostic archon, the trickster, Faust, Milton's Satan, and an inverted Quixote — and argues that the composite resolves into a single figure: a maker of worlds who cannot mourn. Chapter 6 reads Morty Smith as the principle of finitude, traces his passage from instrument to agent, and describes the household that surrounds the dyad as a polis of remainders, in which the ethics the series finally articulates first takes shape.*



CHAPTER FIVE

PART III · FIGURES

The Saturnine Demiurge

Rick Sanchez in the Mythic and Philosophical Archive

> *Great Kronos swallowed each of them as it came from the womb to its mother's knees, intending that no other of the lordly children of Heaven should hold the kingship among the immortals.*
>
> — Hesiod, *Theogony* 459–462 (c. 700 BCE)

> *Ich bin der Geist, der stets verneint!*
>
> — Goethe, *Faust I*, line 1338 (1808)

Rick Sanchez is not a character type but a palimpsest. The received reading sees in him a single figure — the nihilist genius, the mad scientist, the cosmic cynic — and evaluates the series by whether it endorses or condemns that figure. This chapter treats him instead as Lévi-Strauss treated a myth: as the system of his transformations, a composite assembled from the mythic and philosophical archive by a process of bricolage. Eight figures are superimposed in him: Prometheus, Silenus, Kronos, the Gnostic demiurge, the trickster, Faust, Milton's Satan, and Don Quixote, inverted. The chapter's thesis is that the composite has a unifying principle, which Renaissance iconography called Saturnine: the conjunction, under the sign of Saturn, of the melancholy genius, the devouring father, the king of the carnival, and the exiled ruler of a golden age. Rick

is a *Saturnine demiurge* — a maker of worlds who devours his successors, presides over a festival without renewal, and is exiled from a golden age he cannot name. Every component of the composite, examined closely, discloses the same structure: a creative or destructive power placed in the service of a grief it will not acknowledge.

5.1

Bricolage and the Work on Myth

Lévi-Strauss described mythical thought, in *La Pensée sauvage* (1962), as an intellectual *bricolage*. The bricoleur, unlike the engineer, does not procure materials designed for a project but makes do with whatever is at hand — a heterogeneous repertoire of fragments left over from earlier constructions — and builds from them a new structure whose meaning depends on the arrangement rather than the origin of its parts. Rick is a bricoleur in the literal sense, for the series repeatedly shows him assembling devices of cosmic power from garage junk; and he is a bricolage in the critical sense, a figure assembled from the debris of earlier myths. Hans Blumenberg's *Arbeit am Mythos* (1979) proposed that myths survive not by preserving an original meaning but by being continually reworked, each retelling a further labour on inherited material, and that the function of this labour is to reduce what he called the absolutism of reality — the overwhelming, indifferent power of a world not made for human beings — to something that can be narrated. *Rick and Morty* is such a labour. Its absolutism of reality is the infinite multiverse; its labour consists in assembling from the archive a figure capable of standing in that infinity; and the figure it assembles is a portrait of what the attempt costs.

5.2

Prometheus Inverted

The first component is the most obvious and the most deceptive. Prometheus, in Hesiod, deceives Zeus over the division of the sacrifice at Mecone, steals fire for mortals in a fennel stalk, and is chained to a rock where an eagle devours his liver (*Theogony* 507–616; *Works and Days* 42–105). In the *Prometheus Bound* attributed to Aeschylus he is the benefactor from whom all the arts derive — number, writing, the yoking of animals, navigation, medicine (436–506) — and he names a gift less often remembered: he caused mortals to cease foreseeing their deaths by planting blind hopes in them (248–250). Goethe's ode "Prometheus" (1774) made him the type of the defiant creator, who sits forming human beings in his own image, a race to suffer and weep, to enjoy and rejoice, and to scorn the gods as he does. Mary Shelley's subtitle, *The Modern Prometheus* (1818), transferred the type to the scientist who animates a being and abandons it. Percy Shelley's *Prometheus*

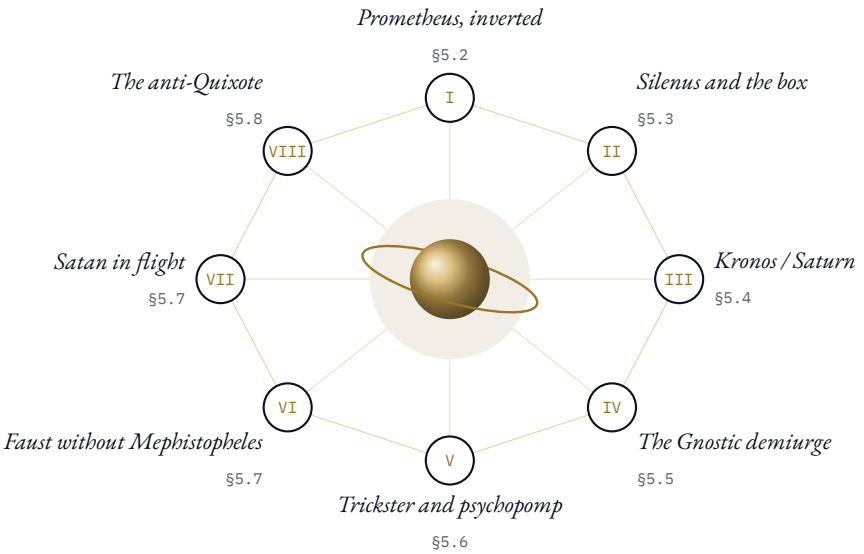


FIG. 5.1 *The Saturnine demiurge as an assemblage. Eight figures from the mythic and philosophical archive, each borrowed and bent, compose the character the received reading takes for a philosopher.*

Unbound (1820) imagined his liberation beginning not with the overthrow of Jupiter but with Prometheus's recall of his own curse: grief, he confesses, had for a while been blind, and he wishes no living thing to suffer pain. The Promethean archive thus already contains the arc this dissertation traces — from defiance, through creation and abandonment, to the revocation of a curse.

Rick inverts each Promethean gift. He steals fire, but for himself: the series' central technology, the portal, is the instrument of his private sovereignty, and when he gives technology to others, as to the inhabitants of the microverse (S2E6), the gift is an extraction disguised as a donation. He forms beings in his own image, but Goethe's defiant race has become the Citadel, a city of Ricks in which every member is like him and none can bear the others. Above all, he revokes the gift of blind hope. Aeschylus's Prometheus spared mortals the foresight of their deaths; Rick's characteristic speech act is to restore it — to remind his family, at every opportunity, that nothing they do will matter and that everyone will die. Günther Anders described a *Promethean shame* (*Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen*, 1956): the shame of human beings, who are born rather than made, before the superior perfection of their own machines. The Smiths live in a version of that shame before Rick. Kafka, in his four-version "Prometheus" (1918), imagined the myth worn out by repetition until gods, eagles, and wound alike grew weary of it. Rick is Prometheus at the stage of Kafka's weariness: the benefactor who has outlived benefaction, chained not to a rock but to the bad infinite of his own resumptions, and awaiting — the series will suggest — not an eagle but a Shelleyan recall of his curse.

5.3

Silenus and the Box

The second component is the drunken sage. Silenus, companion and tutor of Dionysus, was captured by King Midas and asked what is best for human beings; Nietzsche, retelling the story in *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872, §3), has him burst into shrill laughter and answer that the best is not to have been born, and the second best to die soon. The wisdom of Silenus — the oldest Greek pessimism, transmitted through Theognis, Sophocles, and the lost *Eudemus* of Aristotle — is the ancient form of Rick's creed, and Silenus, perpetually drunk, ugly, contemptuous of human aspiration, is his ancient type.

The tradition preserved a second Silenus, and it is the more illuminating. In Plato's *Symposium* (215a–b), Alcibiades compares Socrates to the Silenus figures sold in the workshops of Athens, grotesque statuettes that open to reveal images of the gods inside: ugly without, divine within. Erasmus made the image an adage (*Sileni Alcibiadis*, 1515), and Rabelais opened *Gargantua* (1534) with the Silenus boxes of the apothecaries, painted with absurd figures and filled with precious drugs, as an emblem of his own book. The Silenus is a container whose exterior misrepresents its interior. Rick is a Silenus box whose exterior is intoxication, obscenity, and contempt. The series spends seven seasons opening it, and the interior it discloses is not a god. It is a wound. The catchphrase translated in `S1E11` is the first glimpse; the disclosures of `S5E10` and `S7E5` are the box opened. The Socratic Silenus concealed divinity beneath ugliness; Rick conceals grief beneath cynicism, and the inversion is the series' revision of the most famous image of the philosopher in the Western canon.

5.4

Kronos and Saturn

The third component unifies the others. Kronos, in Hesiod, swallowed each of his children at birth, having learned that he was fated to be overthrown by a son; Rhea saved the youngest, Zeus, by giving Kronos a stone wrapped in swaddling clothes, and Zeus grew up to force his father to disgorge his siblings and to overthrow him (*Theogony* 453–506). The Romans identified Kronos with Saturn, and the identification gathered around a single name a set of attributes whose coherence Renaissance iconography made explicit. Saturn was the devouring father, painted by Rubens and by Goya in the act of eating his son. He was the planet of melancholy, presiding over black bile and therefore, after Ficino, over scholars and men of genius (Chapter 2). He was the god of the Saturnalia, the December festival of licence and reversal at which masters waited upon their slaves — the Roman carnival. And he was the ruler of the golden age, who fled to Latium and reigned there

over a simple and happy people (Virgil, *Aeneid* VIII.319–327), and whose return Virgil's fourth eclogue announced: *redeunt Saturnia regna*.

Each Saturnine attribute has its counterpart in Rick, and their conjunction is the key to the composite. As devouring father, Rick inhabits a cosmos curated so that no successor can surpass him: the Central Finite Curve (S5E10) is Kronos's stomach raised to a cosmological principle, a region of the infinite from which every world in which a Rick is not supreme has been excluded. The son who escapes is Evil Morty, who in the same episode breaks the Curve and flees beyond it, as Zeus escaped by the swaddled stone. As melancholic, Rick is the Aristotelian genius of *Problemata* XXX.1, and the series' Menippean form is, as Chapter 2 showed, constitutively an anatomy of melancholy. As lord of the Saturnalia, he presides over the carnival without renewal analysed in Chapter 2: the garage as a private festival, licence without regeneration. And as exiled ruler of a golden age, he is a man who once lived a simple life with a wife and a daughter, in a world to which he cannot return — the life whose memory, in the Citadel, is harvested and sold as confectionery (S3E7). The *Saturnine demiurge* names this conjunction: the maker of worlds who devours his successors, presides over a festival that renews nothing, and carries within his melancholy the memory of a golden age that the festival exists to keep from mind.

5.5

The Demiurge and the Archon

The demiurge of Plato's *Timaeus* fashions the cosmos after an eternal model, and does so because he is good and without envy (29e). The Gnostic texts of late antiquity inverted the figure. In the *Apocryphon of John*, preserved among the Nag Hammadi codices discovered in 1945, the maker of the material world is Yaldabaoth, the misbegotten offspring of Sophia's error: an arrogant and ignorant power who fashions the cosmos and its ruling archons, imprisons in it the spark of a higher light, and declares that he is God and that there is no other God beside him — a boast the text treats as the proof of his ignorance of the realm from which he came. The Gnostic demiurge is supreme only because he cannot see beyond his own creation.

Rick occupies both positions. In "The Ricks Must Be Crazy" (S2E6) he is literally the maker of a world, the microverse in his car battery, and its relation to him is the Gnostic relation of a cosmos to its archon: its inhabitants labour, without knowing it, to power the vehicle of a being they cannot see, and the technology they believe to be their own is his instrument of extraction. The episode's recursive structure, in which the microverse's own genius has built a smaller universe for the same purpose, generalises the point: the archon is not an individual pathology but a structural position, which any sufficiently capable maker will come to occupy. The episode even stages the Gnostic boast. When Zeep,

the microverse's scientist, learns what his world is for and asks whether some god made Rick's universe too, Rick denies it: the archon who is a god to the world below declares that there is none above him, which is precisely the claim the Gnostic text treats as proof of its maker's ignorance. At the level of the series' cosmology, the Curve completes the Gnostic analogy. Yaldabaoth's claim to uniqueness depends on his ignorance of what lies beyond him; Rick's supremacy depends on a wall that excludes every world in which he is not supreme. This dissertation calls the structure *narcissistic curvature*, or the *Yaldabaoth complex*: the curation of an infinite cosmos into a bounded region in which the subject remains sovereign.

Hans Jonas, in the epilogue to *The Gnostic Religion* (1958; 2nd ed. 1963), compared Gnostic acosmism with modern nihilism and found the modern condition the more desolate. The Gnostic was thrown into a hostile cosmos, but hostility is still a relation, and beyond the hostile cosmos there was a home; the modern subject is thrown into an indifferent one, and for Jonas the true abyss is that nature does not care. Rick's multiverse is Jonas's indifferent nature, and Rick is a Gnostic archon stranded in it — a demiurge without a Pleroma, who has built his prison as a fortress and mistaken the wall for the horizon.

5.6

Trickster and Psychopomp

The fourth component is the oldest in the comparative record. Paul Radin's *The Trickster* (1956), with commentaries by Karl Kerényi and C. G. Jung, assembled the Winnebago cycle of Wakdjunkaga, a figure of insatiable appetite and protean form, at once culture hero and buffoon, whose body is grotesquely detachable and whose deeds, cruel and comic, bring features of the human world into being. Jung read the trickster as a collective shadow figure, a residue of undifferentiated consciousness. Lewis Hyde's *Trickster Makes This World* (1998) argued, against the condescension of earlier interpreters, that the trickster is the creative figure of the boundary: the lord of the in-between, who crosses thresholds others guard, and whose amoral mischief is the means by which a culture's categories are broken open and remade. Hermes is the Greek trickster par excellence — thief of Apollo's cattle on the day of his birth, inventor of the lyre, god of boundaries, and psychopomp, guide of the dead to Hades (*Odyssey* XXIV).

Rick's portal gun is Hermes' office made technology: the opening of thresholds at will. His appetite, his shapeshifting (a pickle in `S3E3`), his indifference to the categories by which his family lives, and his capacity to make worlds through mischief are the trickster's attributes in their Hydean sense. So is his role as psychopomp. In nearly every episode Rick leads Morty across a threshold into a world of death and brings him back again, and the series' recurrent structure — descent, ordeal, return — is the trickster-guide's itinerary

as Harmon's circle formalised it. Hyde observed, however, that the trickster's creativity depends on his want of attachment: he can cross every boundary because he belongs to none. The trickster cannot settle. Put in these terms, the series' question is whether a trickster can be made to stay — whether the psychopomp who leads the boy into the underworld can be bound to the household to which he returns him.

5.7

Faust without Mephistopheles; Satan in Flight

The fifth and sixth components are the modern tragic types of intellectual pride. Goethe's Faust opens his drama by enumerating the faculties he has mastered — philosophy, law, medicine, and, regrettably, theology — and declaring that he is no wiser than before (*Faust I*, 354–365). That night, in despair, he prepares to take his own life and is held back only by the Easter bells and the memory of his childhood faith — a scene the series repeats in S2E3, where what interrupts the act is not memory but drink (Chapter 7). His wager with Mephistopheles stakes his soul on a single condition: should he ever say to the passing moment, Stay, you are so beautiful, the devil may have him (1699–1702). Faust is the man who will never rest in a moment, whose striving is the bad infinite in moral form; and at the end of *Faust II*, blind and dying, he imagines in the subjunctive the moment to which he could say it, and angels carry him off with the assurance that whoever strives unceasingly can be redeemed. Rick is Faust on the near side of that ending: the master of every science who will say to no moment that it should stay.

Rick's Faustianism has a twist, which "Something Ricked This Way Comes" (S1E9) makes explicit. The Devil appears there as a shopkeeper selling cursed objects, and Rick, opening a rival business that removes the curses, drives him to ruin. The scientist has made the devil redundant. Faust no longer needs Mephistopheles, because he has absorbed the function of the spirit that always negates. Goethe's Mephistopheles described himself as part of that power which always wills evil and always works good. Rick professes negation and works, intermittently and against his own doctrine, a grudging good: the Mephistophelean structure, internalised.

Marlowe's Mephistophilis supplied the condition that the portal gun cannot cure. Asked how he comes to be out of hell, he answers that he is not: hell has no limits and is not circumscribed in one place, for where we are is hell (*Doctor Faustus*, c. 1592). Milton's Satan, alighting at the edge of Eden, discovers the same truth in flight: which way he flies is hell, for he himself is hell (*Paradise Lost* IV.73–75). The proposition is the precise refutation of the multiverse as a remedy. If hell is a place, one may leave it; if it is a condition of the self, every world one enters is hell, and an infinity of worlds is an infinity of identical exiles. Rick's travel across universes is Satan's flight through Chaos: a motion that changes

every location except the one that matters. Satan's earlier boast — that the mind is its own place and can make a heaven of hell or a hell of heaven (I.254–255) — is the boast of the Curve; the soliloquy on Niphates is its truth.

5.8

The Anti-Quixote

The last component is the one in which the composite turns. Cervantes's Don Quixote (1605; 1615) is the reader who enchants a disenchanted world: he sees giants in windmills and armies in flocks of sheep, and his madness is the refusal to accept that the age of marvels is over. Rick is his exact inversion. He inhabits a world in which the giants are real and the marvels routine, and his characteristic act is disenchantment: the reduction of every wonder to a mechanism, every mystery to a trick, every attachment to a chemical event. Max Weber, in "Wissenschaft als Beruf" (lecture 1917; published 1919), defined the vocation of modern science as the disenchantment of the world — the knowledge that there are in principle no mysterious incalculable powers and that all things can be mastered by calculation — and drew from Tolstoy its gravest consequence. Abraham and the peasants of old could die old and satiated with life, because their lives formed a completed circle; the modern person, placed in an infinite progress of knowledge, can become weary of life but never satiated with it, and so death, and with it life, becomes meaningless. Rick is Weber's scientist at the limit of the vocation: *lebensmüde*, never *lebenssatt*, the disenchanter of an enchanted cosmos whom no quantity of marvel can satisfy.

The *Quixote* supplies more than the inversion. Salvador de Madariaga's *Guía del lector del "Quijote"* (1926) argued that over the course of the novel knight and squire exchange their natures — the quixotisation of Sancho and the sanchification of Don Quixote — so that by the end the realist squire, who in the second part governs the island of Barataria with unexpected wisdom, has absorbed his master's ideal, while the master, dying, renounces it. At the deathbed it is Sancho who begs Quixote not to die, proposing that they go out into the fields together as shepherds, and declaring that the greatest madness a man can commit in this life is to let himself die. The dyad's exchange is completed at the threshold of death, and the keeper of the dream is the squire. Rick's surname, by an onomastic accident the series never remarks, is a patronymic meaning *son of Sancho*.

This dissertation calls the corresponding exchange in *Rick and Morty* a *dyadic mortification*, and the term is deliberately overdetermined. In its ordinary sense, mortification is humiliation, and Rick is repeatedly mortified by the boy he despises: outwitted, rebuked, shown to need him. In its ascetic sense, *mortificatio* is the putting to death of self-will, the discipline by which the proud self is reduced. In its alchemical sense, *mortificatio* names the nigredo, the blackening that opens the opus — a stage presided over

by Saturn and identified, in the tradition Jung reconstructed in *Psychologie und Alchemie* (1944), with melancholy and the encounter with the shadow. And in its onomastic sense it is the becoming-Morty of Rick: the slow transfer into the genius of something of the boy's finitude, answered by a becoming-Rick of Morty of which Evil Morty is the dark completion. The Saturnine demiurge can be transmuted, if at all, only through the nigredo — through an encounter with the death his cosmos has been made to avoid. Morty's name is the name of that encounter.

5.9

The Counterfeit Parrhesiast

Chapter 2 observed that Rick's speech has the form of Cynic *parrhesia*. Foucault's analysis of the practice (*Fearless Speech*, lectures of 1983; *Le courage de la vérité*, 1984) specifies its conditions with a precision that permits a diagnosis. Parrhesia is frank speech that tells the truth as the speaker believes it, criticises its addressee, and does so as a duty and at a risk to the speaker: the parrhesiast is the one who, in speaking, endangers himself. The risk is constitutive. Truth told from a position of invulnerability is not parrhesia but something else — instruction, perhaps, or cruelty.

Rick's truths about his family are told from a position of near-absolute invulnerability. He is the most powerful being in every world he enters; he risks nothing by telling Jerry that he is mediocre, Beth that she is her father's dependant, or Morty that his life is meaningless. His candour is therefore a counterfeit parrhesia, with the form of courage and the substance of power. The truths that would cost him something — truths about himself, his grief, his need — he either withholds or weaponises. "The Rickshank Rickdemption" (S3E1) shows him narrating, to a Federation agent probing his memories, an origin story of a murdered wife and daughter, and then revealing it as a fabrication designed to deceive: the one confession that would have exposed him is presented as a trick. That the fifth season later confirms the substance of the story only deepens the diagnosis. Rick could tell the truth about himself only in a form that allowed him to disown it. The genuine parrhesia of which he is capable is the parrhesia of self-disclosure, and it is precisely that which the composite has been assembled to prevent.

5.10

Findings

Four findings follow. First, Rick is a bricolage of the archive, and each of his components discloses, under analysis, a power placed in the service of an unacknowledged grief: the benefactor who revokes hope, the box whose interior is a wound, the father who devours his successors, the maker supreme only within his own wall, the trickster who cannot stay, the striver who will not rest, the fugitive who carries his hell with him, the disenchanter who can never be satiated. Second, the components cohere under the sign of Saturn: melancholy genius, devouring father, lord of a carnival without renewal, and exile from a golden age. Third, the composite contains its own possible transmutation, here called dyadic mortification — humiliation, ascetic dying-to-self, alchemical nigredo, and the becoming-Morty of the genius — anticipated by Madariaga's account of the exchange of natures between Quixote and Sancho. Fourth, Rick's characteristic speech is a counterfeit parrhesia, candid toward others from a position of invulnerability and evasive toward himself, so that the truth the composite exists to withhold is the truth about its own loss. Chapter 7 names that loss and the cosmogony it generates. First, however, the other figure in the title must be read.



CHAPTER SIX

PART III · FIGURES

Morty, or Mortality

The Dyad, the Household, and the Ethics of the Remainder

As soon as a human being comes to life, he is at once old enough to die.

— Johannes von Tepl, *Der Ackermann aus Böhmen* (c. 1401), cited by Heidegger, *Sein und Zeit* §48 (1927)

Que philosopher c'est apprendre à mourir.

— Montaigne, *Essais* I.20 (1580)

If Rick is a composite of the archive, Morty is its remainder: the figure left over when the archetypes have been assembled, who belongs to no myth and is required by all of them. The received reading treats him as the sidekick — foil, conscience, audience surrogate — and measures his significance by his growth toward or away from Rick. This chapter argues that Morty is the series' principle of finitude. His name binds the would-be immortal genius to death; his function, from the pilot onward, is to be the body on which the genius's experiments are performed and the memory in which their costs are kept; and his development from instrument to agent traces the passage that Hegel described in the dialectic of master and bondsman, mediated by the fear of death. The chapter then turns to the household around the dyad — Beth, Jerry, Summer — and describes it as a *polis of*



FIG. 6.1 *Mort in the titles. Aligned on the syllable they share, fifteen episode titles from the fourth to the seventh season spell out the series' other name.*

remainders: a community of the unplanned, the unchosen, and the substituted, among whom the series' ethics first takes shape. That ethics, here called the *ethics of the remainder*, is the obligation of the one who remembers what the reset cost.

6.1

Mort: The Name

The series' titling insists on an etymology its dialogue never mentions. "Childrick of Mort" (S4E9), "Mort Dinner Rick Andre" (S5E1), "Rick: A Mort Well Lived" (S6E2), "A Rick in King Mortur's Mort" (S6E9), "That's Amorte" (S7E4), "Mort: Ragnarick" (S7E9), "Fear No Mort" (S7E10): again and again the paratext detaches from the boy's name the Latin and Romance word for death — *mors, mortis*; *mort*; *morte*. Read through its titles, the series is called *Rick and Death*. The pairing is not arbitrary. It binds the figure who has engineered his own immortality — clone backups, a cosmos of replacements — to the one member of the household whose name means the thing he has engineered away. "Morty" is also a diminutive of Mortimer, from the Norman toponym Mortemer, usually glossed as *dead sea* or *still water*: the boy is named, at two removes, after stagnant water and after death.

Two further resonances complete the onomastics. Chapter 2 noted Erasmus's *Moriae Encomium*, whose title punned Folly (*moria*) on the name of his friend Thomas More.

Morty is, in Rick's estimation, the household fool — the boy whose dullness is useful because it camouflages genius — and the series' long argument is that the fool's wisdom exceeds the genius's: the Erasmian inversion, in which Folly speaks truths that Wisdom cannot, and which Erasmus carried at last to the Pauline folly of the cross, the foolishness that is wiser than men (1 Corinthians 1:25). And the family name is Smith, the commonest of English surnames, the name of anybody. The Smiths are the household of the generic, the family that could be any family, and therefore, by the logic of the multiverse, the family most easily replaced. The series' work is to make the name of anybody into the name of these ones.

Nomen est omen, the Romans said. The name does not make Morty mortal; everyone in the series is mortal except, after a fashion, Rick. It makes him the series' figure of mortality: the one in whom finitude is not merely a condition but a function.

6.2

From Instrument to Agent

Morty enters the series as an instrument. The pilot conscripts his body as a smuggling vessel, sending him through interdimensional customs with contraband seeds concealed in his rectum; the first season establishes that his brainwaves are camouflage (S1E10); and in the Citadel of Ricks, Mortys are accessories, deposited in day-care and exchanged when damaged. The instrumentalisation is not merely Rick's attitude but an institution of the multiverse, the social form of the argument from plurality (Chapter 3). Against this background, Morty's development across seven seasons can be traced as the gradual, contested, never completed emergence of an agent from an instrument.

The emergence has a characteristic structure, which Hegel described in the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807, §§178–196). In the struggle for recognition, the one who will not risk death becomes the bondsman of the one who will. The master enjoys the bondsman's labour and recognition, but because he is recognised by one whom he does not recognise, his independence is hollow, and he stagnates. The bondsman is formed by two experiences the master is spared: labour, through which he shapes the world and thereby himself, and the fear of death, the absolute master, which shakes him to the foundations and is — Hegel cites Proverbs — the beginning of wisdom (§195). Morty's characteristic affect is fear. The received reading treats it as cowardice and comedy. In Hegelian terms it is the condition of his formation. Rick, who has engineered death into a reversible inconvenience, is spared the fear that would teach him; Morty, who is not spared it, learns.

The series' Mortys learn different things. In "Mortynight Run" (S2E2) Morty defies Rick to save a gaseous being marked for assassination, and then, learning that the being

intends to exterminate carbon-based life, kills it himself: an agent's first act, with the circle's price attached. In "Rick Potion #9" (S1E6) he learns that the reset has a body count, and the knowledge does not leave him. Evil Morty, first glimpsed in S1E10 and disclosed in S5E10, learns the master's lesson too well: the bondsman turned master, who escapes the Curve but reproduces in himself the intelligence and ruthlessness he set out to escape. Alexandre Kojève's influential reading of the dialectic (*Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*, 1947) stressed that the master's position is an existential impasse; Evil Morty shows that the bondsman who merely takes the master's place inherits the impasse. The Morty with whom the series stays is the one who neither submits nor usurps — who remains in the household, remembers, and acts within it.

6.3

Being-toward-Death in a Cosmos of Backups

Heidegger's analysis of death in *Sein und Zeit* (1927, §§46–53) supplies the most exact frame for what distinguishes Morty from his grandfather. Death, for Heidegger, is Dasein's ownmost possibility: non-relational, certain, indefinite as to its when, and not to be outstripped. It individualises, because no one can take another's dying away from him (§47); and everyday existence flees it into the anonymity of *das Man*, the "they", which tranquillises the certainty of death into the platitude that one dies, sometime, but not yet and not I (§51). Authentic existence anticipates death and lets that anticipation individualise it.

Rick's clone backups are *das Man* raised to a technology. They do not abolish death; they convert it into the impersonal event of the "they" — a body dies, another wakes — and so tranquillise it absolutely. Morty's experience in "Rick Potion #9" is the reverse. He sees his own corpse, digs its grave, and buries it. In a cosmos where another has apparently died his death and he has taken the dead boy's place, Heidegger's proposition that no one can take another's dying away from him seems refuted by the plot. Morty's trauma refutes the refutation. He does not experience the corpse as someone else's death; he experiences it as his own, encountered in advance. The episode stages, in comic form, the anticipation of death that Heidegger called authentic, and its consequence is the one Heidegger predicted: Morty is individualised by it. From that point he is the one who knows.

Martin Hägglund's *This Life* (2019) draws the ethical consequence that Heidegger left implicit. Care, Hägglund argues, presupposes finitude: we can care for something only because it can be lost, and a being whose life was infinite, for whom nothing could be at stake, could not care for anything at all. The argument explains Rick with uncomfortable precision. Insofar as his backups and his access to every world have made his existence a bad infinite, nothing can be at stake for him, and his incapacity for care is less a moral failing

than a metaphysical consequence of the immortality he has engineered. Morty can care because he can die. The name to which the paratext keeps returning is, on this reading, not a memento mori but a condition of possibility: only the mortal can keep anything.

6.4

The Household as a Polis of Remainders

The dyad is not alone in the house. The Smith household is the sitcom's *oikos*, the domain Aristotle placed beneath the polis as the sphere of necessity, reproduction, and everyday life (*Politics* I). Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) offers a more discriminating map. Labour, the activity of the *animal laborans*, answers to biological necessity and is cyclical, its products consumed as soon as they are made; work, the activity of *homo faber*, fabricates a durable world of objects; action, the activity proper to human beings among one another, begins something new. The sitcom's household is the domain of labour, whose cyclical temporality the reset formalises; Rick is *homo faber* at the limit, the maker of worlds. Action, Arendt argued, is rooted in natality — the fact that each human being is a new beginning, unforeseeable and unrepeatable — and its condition is plurality, which she defined as the paradoxical condition of beings who are all the same in being human and yet such that no one is ever the same as anyone else who has lived, lives, or will live.

Arendt's definition draws the distinction the multiverse obscures. The Citadel offers multiplication: beings who are the same as one another. Arendtian plurality is its opposite: beings alike only in being unlike. The household, for all its dysfunction, is the series' site of plurality in Arendt's sense, and each of its members is, in a specific way, a remainder of the multiverse's economy of substitution. Beth is a daughter abandoned in childhood by her father and reclaimed, in the series' layered genealogy, by a Rick who is not quite hers; in S4E10 the family learns that either she or the Beth who returns from space is a clone, that no one, Rick included, can say which, and the series leaves the question permanently open. Jerry is the remainder no one wants: the mediocrity Rick despises, a Nietzschean last man in his contentment, deposited at the Jerryboree like luggage — and yet the member of the household most stubbornly committed to its continuance. Summer is the unplanned child, who learns in "Rixty Minutes" (S1E8) that her parents' counterparts flourished without her. Morty is the one who remembers. None of them was chosen. Each is what was left when the choosing was done.

The household is therefore a *polis of remainders*: a community of the unplanned, the unchosen, and the substituted, constituted not by anyone's design but by what the multiverse's economy of replacement could not use. The series' ethics arises here, and it arises first not in the vertical dyad of grandfather and grandson but in the horizontal dyad of siblings. The scene on which Chapter 8 turns is a conversation between Morty and Summer, in

which the brother answers his sister's discovery that she was unplanned with the disclosure of his own grave. Arendt's natality supplies its premise: every birth is, in the relevant sense, unplanned; no one exists for a purpose, because everyone exists as a beginning. Summer's unplannedness is not the refutation of her worth but its ground.

Giorgio Agamben's reading of the Pauline "remnant" (*Il tempo che resta*, 2000) gives the concept its formal precision. The remnant, for Agamben, is not a part of a people that survives while the rest is lost, but what every division of a people leaves over: neither the whole nor a part, but the remainder that prevents any division from coinciding with itself. The Smith household stands in this relation to the multiverse's division of persons into types. It is what the classification of Ricks, Mortys, Beths, and Jerrys cannot exhaust.

6.5

The Ethics of the Remainder

Walter Benjamin's ninth thesis "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940) describes an angel, after a monoprint by Paul Klee, whose face is turned toward the past. Where we perceive a chain of events, he sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet; he would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from Paradise has caught his wings and drives him irresistibly into the future, and this storm is what we call progress. The third thesis praises the chronicler who recounts events without distinguishing the great from the small, in the conviction that nothing that has ever happened should be regarded as lost for history.

The sitcom's reset is Benjamin's storm in domestic form: the force that carries the household into next week and leaves behind it, unseen, a pile of abandoned worlds. Morty is its angel. Since "Rick Potion #9" his face has been turned toward the wreckage — the world left to its monsters, the corpse in the yard — while the episodic form blows him forward into new adventures. The *ethics of the remainder* names the obligation this position imposes: to be the one in whom what happened remains what happened; to refuse the reset's amnesia, if not its motion; to treat nothing that has occurred as lost. It is the ethics of the chronicler against the ethics of the reset.

The series does not present this ethics as easy, or Morty as its secure possessor. "Morty's Mind Blowers" (S3E8) reveals that Morty has repeatedly asked Rick to remove memories too painful to keep; the remainder has sought, like everyone else, the anaesthetic of forgetting. Nietzsche argued that active forgetting is a condition of health, a doorkeeper of the psyche without which there could be no happiness, no hope, no present (*Genealogy* II.1), and the series concedes the point: no one can carry every wreckage. But the archive of excised memories does not vanish; it is kept, in a vault, by the man who excised them. The ethics of the remainder does not demand total memory. It demands that what is forgotten

be kept somewhere, by someone, and not destroyed — that forgetting be a form of keeping rather than of erasure. Chapter 7 shows what becomes of a grief that is kept but never mourned: it becomes a crypt. Chapter 8 shows what it would be for a grief to be kept and mourned at once.

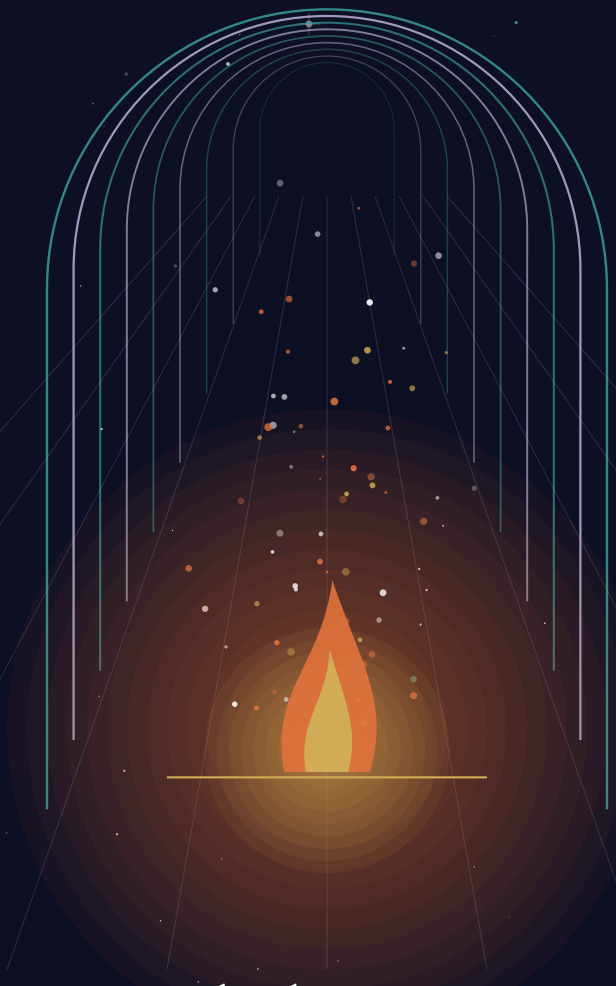
6.6

Findings

Four findings follow. First, Morty is the series' principle of finitude: his name, as the paratext insists, binds the would-be immortal genius to death, and its further resonances — the Erasmian fool, the household of anybody — mark him as the figure whose ordinariness the series converts into singularity. Second, his development from instrument to agent follows the Hegelian passage from bondage through labour and the fear of death; Evil Morty, the bondsman turned master, shows that usurpation inherits the master's impasse, while the Morty with whom the series stays neither submits nor usurps. Third, in a cosmos where death has been tranquillised by backups, Morty's encounter with his own corpse is an anticipation of death in Heidegger's sense and, on Hägglund's argument, the condition of his capacity to care. Fourth, the household is a polis of remainders, the series' site of Arendtian plurality as against the Citadel's multiplication, and the ethics of the remainder — the obligation to keep what happened from being lost — is the form the series' ethics takes before it is fully articulated. Part IV turns to the two chapters in which the dissertation's argument culminates: the theory of melancholic cosmogony, and the ethics of thisness that answers it.

PART

IV



The Crypt and the Hearth

7 *Melancholic Cosmogony*

8 *The Ethics of Thisness*

Part IV contains the dissertation's central argument. Chapter 7 develops the theory of melancholic cosmogony: it reads the series' progressive disclosures as the retroactive rewriting of its cosmos into the externalisation of an unmourned loss, analyses that cosmos through Freud, Klein, Kohut, and Abraham and Torok, and follows the revenge narrative to its consummation and its emptiness. Chapter 8 constructs in answer the ethics of thisness — a practical haecceity in which value, in a cosmos of infinite substitutes, is conferred and sustained through finite acts of keeping — and resolves the interpretive crux of the series' most quoted scene. The crypt and the hearth of the title name the two places in which a loss may be kept: entombed, or carried into the life of a household.



CHAPTER SEVEN.

PART IV · THE CRYPT AND THE HEARTH

Melancholic Cosmogony

The Curve, the Crypt, and the End of Revenge

Je suis le Ténébreux, — le Veuf, — l'Inconsolé,
Le Prince d'Aquitaine à la Tour abolie:
Ma seule Étoile est morte...

— Gérard de Nerval, "El Desdichado" (1854)

Der Schatten des Objekts fiel so auf das Ich.

— Sigmund Freud, "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917)

A cosmogony is an account of how a world came to be. A *melancholic cosmogony* is a world whose structure is generated, narratively and psychically, as the externalisation of an unmourned singular loss. This chapter argues that *Rick and Morty*, over seven seasons, rewrites its own cosmogony in exactly this form. The multiverse that the first season presents as a given — infinite, indifferent, the ground of its protagonist's contempt — is disclosed by stages as the product of a grief: its navigability invented as an instrument of vengeance, its apparent infinity a curated enclosure built to protect an ego, its central household a substitute for a family destroyed, its protagonist's creed a consolation designed for a loss it could not console. The chapter proceeds through the series'

retroactive structure (§7.1), Freud's distinction between mourning and melancholia and its Kleinian elaboration (§7.2), Abraham and Torok's theory of the crypt (§7.3), the anatomy of the cosmogony itself (§7.4), the event in which its consolation collapses (§7.5), and the consummation of the revenge that organised it (§7.6). Its claim is that the series' nihilism is grief-work mistaken, by its protagonist and many of its viewers, for metaphysics — and that the series knows it.

7.1

Nachträglichkeit*: A Cosmos Rewritten*

Freud's concept of *Nachträglichkeit* — deferred action, *après-coup* — describes the process by which a later experience retroactively confers on an earlier one a meaning, often traumatic, that it did not have when it occurred; the earlier scene becomes what it was only after the fact (*Entwurf einer Psychologie*, 1895; *Aus der Geschichte einer infantilen Neurose*, 1918). The narrative logic of *Rick and Morty* is *nachträglich* in this sense. Its early seasons present a cosmology and a temperament without a history; its later seasons supply the history, and in doing so convert the cosmology into a symptom. The meaning of the first season's nihilism is constituted only by the fifth and the seventh.

The disclosures arrive in a sequence whose order is itself significant. In S1E11 ("Ricksy Business") Birdperson translates Rick's catchphrase as a cry of pain and a plea for help (Chapter 2). In S2E3 ("Auto Erotic Assimilation"), after Unity, the hive mind with whom he has resumed a relationship, leaves him, Rick, drinking heavily, turns a device of his own making on himself in the garage, and survives only because he passes out and slumps out of its path. In S3E1 ("The Rickshank Rickdemption"), probed by a Federation agent, he narrates an origin — a wife, Diane, and a young daughter, killed by a bomb dropped through a portal into the family garage by a variant of himself, who had offered him the technology of interdimensional travel and been refused — and then declares the story a fabrication devised to deceive (Chapter 5). In S5E10 ("Rickmurai Jack") the series confirms the substance of that story: Rick perfected portal travel to hunt the killer; the multiverse through which he and his variants move is the Central Finite Curve, an enclosure walled off from the true infinite so that a Rick is always its most intelligent being; and the household with which the series began was one he had joined as a substitute, moving in with a Beth whose own Rick had abandoned her and her mother twenty years before — and that Rick, the series discloses, was the killer himself, so that the boy Rick would use, and come to love, is the biological grandson of his family's killer. In the sixth season the killer acquires a name, Rick Prime, and the hunt resumes. In S7E5 ("Unmortricken") Rick, with Evil Morty's help, finds and kills him, after learning that Rick Prime had used a device capable

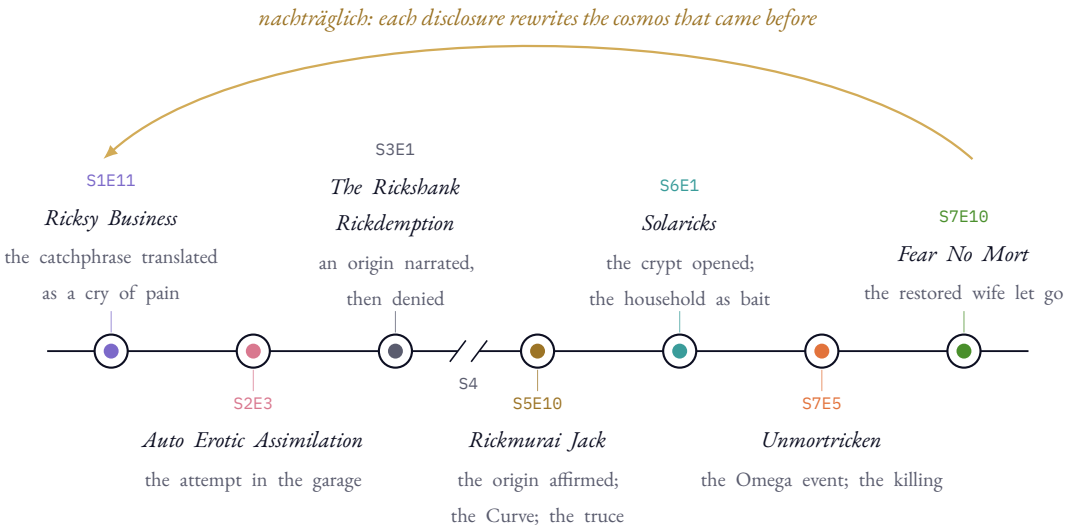


FIG.7.1 *A cosmos rewritten. The series' disclosures arrive in an order that converts its early cosmology, retroactively, into the symptom of a loss.*

of deleting a given molecular structure from every universe to erase Diane from the whole of existence.

The order matters. The first disclosure is linguistic and encrypted; the second is somatic and unexplained; the third is narrative and negated; the fourth is narrative and affirmed; the fifth is a name; the sixth is an act. Freud observed in "Die Verneinung" (1925) that a repressed content can make its way into consciousness on condition that it is negated: negation is a way of taking cognisance of what is repressed, already a lifting of the repression, though not an acceptance of what is repressed. The false origin of S3E1 is a *Verneinung* in exactly this sense — the truth admitted to the narrative on condition that it be declared untrue — and the movement from S3E1 to S5E10 is the lifting of the negation. What remains after S5E10 is the question Freud's essay leaves open: whether the lifting of a repression will issue in acceptance, which, in the case of a loss, means mourning.

7.2 *Mourning, Melancholia, Mania*

Freud's "Trauer und Melancholie" (written 1915; published 1917) distinguishes two responses to the loss of a loved object. In mourning, reality-testing shows that the object no longer exists and demands that the libido be withdrawn from it; the demand is carried out bit by bit, at great expense of time and energy, each memory and expectation bound to the object being brought up, hypercathected, and detached — the *Trauerarbeit*, the work of mourning — until the ego is free again. In melancholia the same loss produces a different

picture: profound dejection, withdrawal of interest from the world, inhibition of activity, and a lowering of self-regard that expresses itself in self-reproach. Two features distinguish it. The melancholic may know whom he has lost but not what he has lost in him; the loss is withdrawn from consciousness. And the self-reproaches, examined closely, prove to be reproaches against the lost object, shifted onto the ego: by a narcissistic identification the object has been set up within the ego, so that, in Freud's most famous sentence, the shadow of the object fell upon the ego. The hostility once directed at the object is now directed at the self, and here Freud locates the source of the suicidal impulse in melancholia: the ego can will its own death only when it treats itself as an object, turning against itself the hostility that belonged to the object it lost. S2E3 stages the analysis closely — the attempt follows the departure of an attachment that reawakens an older loss — and the drink that sustains Rick's nihilist discourse is, in the event, what interrupts the act: a caesura of the body in the most literal sense. Julia Kristeva, whose *Soleil noir* (1987) takes its title from the sonnet at the head of this chapter, extended the analysis to a loss that precedes and exceeds any nameable object.

Freud added that melancholia tends to pass over into mania, in which the ego, having mastered the loss or thrust it aside, celebrates a triumph and, released from its object, turns with the avidity of the starving to new objects of attachment. The alternation is the affective rhythm of Rick's existence across the corpus. His mania is the adventure: the frenzied appetite for new worlds, new substances, new sensations, the triumph that the episodic form makes perpetual. His melancholia is what the adventure interrupts and what interrupts the adventure: the drinking that accompanies nearly every scene, the contempt for himself that leaks through his contempt for others, the attempt in S2E3. The received reading sees the mania and calls it freedom. Freud's model sees the alternation and calls it a grief that has not been worked.

Melanie Klein's elaboration of Freud ("A Contribution to the Psychogenesis of Manic-Depressive States", 1935; "Mourning and Its Relation to Manic-Depressive States", 1940) supplies the precise vocabulary of Rick's characteristic attitudes. Every loss, for Klein, reactivates the infantile depressive position, in which the subject must recognise both its dependence on the loved object and its own aggression toward it; against the anxiety and guilt of that recognition the psyche erects *manic defences*, whose characteristic triad, as Hanna Segal summarised it, is control, triumph, and contempt. Control denies dependence by mastering the object; triumph denies loss by celebrating superiority over it; contempt denies value by declaring the object worthless and therefore not worth grieving. Rick's three dominant attitudes toward his family and his world are exactly these. The Curve is control at cosmological scale; the adventure is triumph; the creed that nothing matters is contempt raised to a metaphysics. The alternative Klein describes — the working through of the depressive position — proceeds by reparation, the wish to repair the damaged loved object within and without. The series' question about Rick, in Kleinian terms, is whether reparation remains

possible for someone whose original object can no longer be repaired, and whether it can be displaced onto those who remain.

Heinz Kohut's account of narcissistic rage (1972) supplies the last element. Kohut distinguished ordinary aggression from the rage of the narcissistically injured, whose mark is an unrelenting need for revenge — for righting a wrong and undoing a hurt by whatever means — pursued without regard for reasonable limits and with a boundless wish to redress the injury. Rick's hunt for Rick Prime has this form. It is not a policy but a compulsion, renewed across decades, indifferent to cost, and directed, as the following sections show, at an injury that no act of revenge could undo.

7.3

The Crypt

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok refined Freud's distinction into a theory of two modes of keeping a loss ("Deuil ou mélancolie: Introjecter — incorporer", 1972; collected in *L'Écorce et le noyau*, 1978). *Introjection* is the process by which the subject gradually takes the loss into itself through language and fantasy, enlarging the ego to include what the relation to the object had made possible; it is the work of mourning, accomplished in words. *Incorporation* is its refusal: the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole, literally, so as not to have to lose it, and of preserving it intact within the psyche, beyond the reach of language and of time. Incorporation produces a *crypt* — an intrapsychic tomb in which the lost object, often together with an unspeakable secret bound to it, is kept as if alive, sealed off from the rest of the psyche and leading a concealed life of its own. Abraham's notes on the *phantom* (1975) added a transgenerational dimension: what haunts the descendants of a crypt-bearer is not the dead themselves but the gaps left in them by the secrets of others — a grief never spoken, transmitted as a silence.

Three features of the series acquire precise meaning in these terms. The first is the catchphrase. Abraham and Torok's study of Freud's patient the Wolf Man (*Cryptonymie: Le Verbier de l'Homme aux loups*, 1976, with Derrida's preface "Fors") showed how the crypt communicates through *cryptonyms*: words that conceal an unspeakable content by displacing it across languages, so that a phrase in one tongue carries, unrecognised, a meaning in another. "Wubba lubba dub dub" is a cryptonym in the strictest sense. Uttered as nonsense in the language of the household, it means, in the language of Rick's oldest friend, that he is in great pain and asks for help; the plea is spoken constantly and heard by no one, because it is spoken in a tongue the listeners do not know. The second feature is the vault of "Morty's Mind Blowers" (S3E8), where Rick keeps the memories he has removed from Morty: an archive of excised experience, preserved rather than destroyed, sealed in a room — a crypt made literal, kept by the crypt-bearer on another's behalf. The third,

and the most remarkable, is the confectionery of "The Ricklantis Mixup" (S3E7), in which the Citadel extracts from a captive Rick the memory of a simple and contented afternoon with his daughter and sells it to other Ricks with the promise of the impossible flavour of their own completion. Incorporation, for Abraham and Torok, is the literal taking of what can only be taken figuratively: the mourner who cannot introject the lost object fantasises eating it. The Citadel has industrialised the fantasy. Its Ricks, each of whom carries some version of the loss, do not mourn the domestic life they abandoned or were robbed of; they eat it. The wafer is a eucharist of melancholia: a mass-produced communion in the lost object, consumed in order not to be grieved.

The sixth season makes the crypt explicit. "Solaricks" (S6E1) returns Rick to his dimension of origin and discloses what he left there: a neighbourhood locked in an endless loop of the day of the murder, and an artificial simulation of Diane, built, as the episode has it, to haunt him; and, as the actor who now voices Rick has noted, her voice survives as the voice of his car. A day of death repeated without end and a dead wife preserved as a voice: the bad infinite of Chapter 3 and the incorporation of this chapter, in a single image. The episode's title borrows Lem's novel of the dead wife returned, and it ends with Rick setting his vendetta aside, for the moment, for the boy who insists that he is his grandfather.

The phantom completes the picture. The Smith household is haunted by a grief it was never told. Beth drinks, as her father drinks, and the abandonment of her childhood recurs in her own distraction as a parent; Morty is traumatised by a history he cannot share; and the family has at its centre a conspicuous absence — a grandmother the early seasons scarcely mention. The house is built around a missing woman. What circulates among its members is not Rick's grief, which he has entombed, but the silence of its entombment, transmitted as the family's dysfunction. Rick's cry for help, encrypted in another language, waits for a translator. Birdperson supplied the translation in the first season. The question the series leaves to its later seasons, and which Chapter 8 takes up, is whether anyone will answer it.

7.4

The Anatomy of a Cosmogony

The cosmogony can now be stated in its full structure. It has seven moments, which the table sets beside their psychoanalytic descriptions, their evidence in the series, and their analogues in the mythic and literary archive.

Moment	Psychoanalytic description	Evidence in the series	Analogue in the archive
1. Loss	A singular object dies; reality-testing declares it gone (Freud)	Diane and the young Beth killed by a variant of Rick (S3E1, confirmed S5E10)	The death of Enkidu (*Gilgamesh* VII–VIII); the death of Eurydice

Moment	Psychoanalytic description	Evidence in the series	Analogue in the archive
2. Disavowal	The loss admitted only on condition of being negated (Freud, "Die Verneinung")	The origin narrated and declared a fabrication (S3E1)	Gilgamesh refusing Enkidu burial until a worm falls from his nose (X)
3. Incorporation	The object swallowed whole and entombed unmourned: the crypt (Abraham and Torok)	The cryptonymic catchphrase (S1E11); the memory vault (S3E8); the Citadel's confectionery (S3E7)	Kronos swallowing his children (Hesiod)
4. Mania	Triumph over the object; control, triumph, contempt (Freud; Klein)	Episodic adventure, intoxication, contempt for the family	Satan's flight through Chaos (Milton); Faust's wager (Goethe)
5. Cosmogony	The loss externalised as a world: substitution, curvature, revenge	The substitute household (S5E10; S1E6); the Central Finite Curve (S5E10); the hunt for Rick Prime (S6–S7)	Yaldabaoth's cosmos (*Apocryphon of John*); Zaphod's universe (Adams)
6. Omega event	The loss shown to be absolute; substitution annihilated	Diane erased from every universe (S7E5)	Orpheus with no underworld to search; the ocean of *Solaris*, which returns only copies
7. End of revenge	Revenge consummated and exhausted; mourning made possible	Rick Prime killed; the hunt concluded (S7E5)	The Furies made Eumenides (Aeschylus); the Ackermann's verdict (Tepl)

Three of the moments require elaboration, because they are those in which a psychic structure becomes a cosmic one.

The first is substitution. The household with which the series began was a replacement for a household destroyed: Rick, after the murder of his wife and daughter, moved in with a Beth whose own Rick had left her — a daughter who was not his — the abandoned daughter, the series later discloses, of the very Rick who had killed his own — in place of a daughter who was. "Rickmurai Jack" shows the motive and "Solaricks" (S6E1) states it: Rick had settled with Rick Prime's family in the hope of catching Rick Prime if he ever came home, so that the household at the origin of the sitcom was, before it was a home, a trap. When that household became uninhabitable in "Rick Potion #9", he exchanged it for another. The substitutive face of the consolation of plurality (Chapter 3) is thus not merely Rick's philosophy but his biography: the multiverse is the supply of substitutes from which his life has been rebuilt. And the substitution has a precise limit. Daughters, it appears, can be found in other worlds. The series never shows Rick living with another Diane; the nearest thing is the simulation of her he left in his old house, built to haunt him.

The second is narcissistic curvature. The Central Finite Curve encloses every world in

SEVEN MOMENTS OF A MELANCHOLIC COSMOGONY

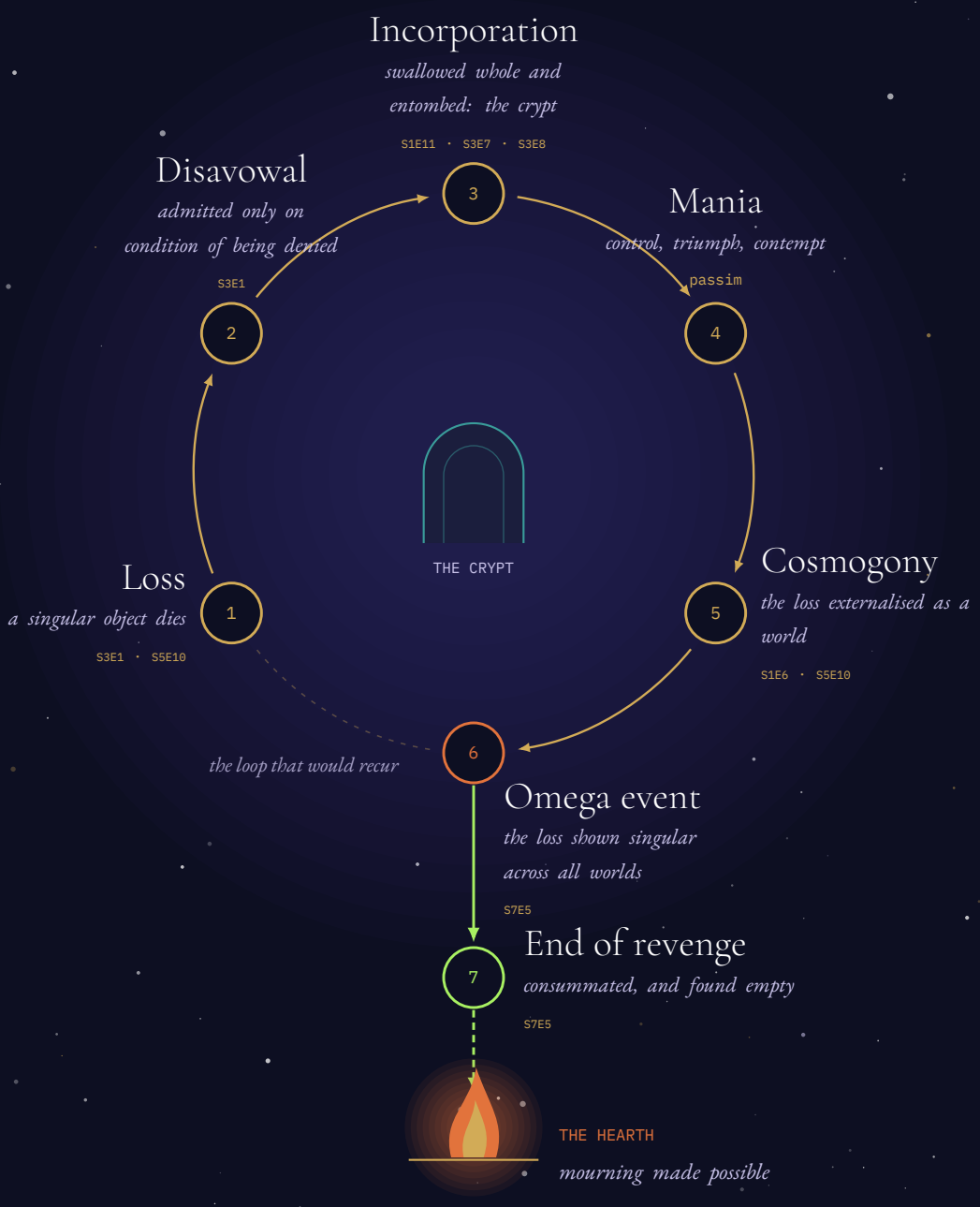


PLATE · FIG. 7.2

The seven moments of a melancholic cosmogony. Six run as a loop that the cosmos exists to sustain; the Omega event breaks it, and the revenge that the loop organised ends in exhaustion rather than repair.

which a Rick is the most intelligent being and excludes every world in which he is not. Psychoanalytically it is the manic defence of control raised to a cosmological principle, and the narcissistic defence of the ego against the one perspective it cannot survive: the perspective in which it is unremarkable. It is the Zaphod defence of Chapter 2 and the Yaldabaoth complex of Chapter 5. But it defends against something more specific than insignificance. A cosmos in which one is always supreme is a cosmos in which one is never helpless, and the loss at the origin of Rick's cosmogony was the paradigm of helplessness: the deaths of those he loved, at the hands of a being who was, in every respect that mattered, his equal — another Rick. The Curve excludes the worlds in which a Rick is surpassed. It cannot exclude the world in which a Rick was surpassed by himself. The fifth-season disclosure makes the curvature Rick's own work and shows what it was for. The Citadel began as a council of Ricks banded together to stop him, after he had killed a number of them in his search for the murderer. The killing ended in a truce: Rick built the Citadel for them — Evil Morty says he practically built the place, and most accounts credit him with the Curve as well — and then withdrew to the killer's home world to wait. What the Citadel became, Evil Morty discloses, was a market in Mortys, whose brainwaves hide the Ricks who keep them. Across the worlds of the Curve, Ricks nudged Beths and Jerrys together, and cloned grandsons when nudging was too slow; to search infinity for grandsons who occur naturally would have been, in Evil Morty's phrase, "such an admission of need". Confronted with this, Rick does not deny it. It is not, he says, the whole truth, and he is not responsible for every Rick there is. Evil Morty's name for the result is exact: "an infinite crib built around an infinite ... baby". Freud's phrase for the omnipotence of primary narcissism was "His Majesty the Baby" ("On Narcissism", 1914). Evil Morty's account of the Ricks is also Chapter 3's bad infinite in a sentence: there are not infinitely many grandfathers, he tells Morty, but one wretched old man smeared across infinity. After the loss of a wife and a daughter, His Majesty's nursery became a machine for producing daughters and grandsons without end, so that he would never again have to admit that he needed one.

The third is revenge. Freud's melancholic directs at himself reproaches that belong to the lost object; Rick directs at a double reproaches that belong to himself. The killer of the origin story is a Rick who has already taken the path Rick declined: the master of portal travel, who offers the infinite to a Rick who chooses his household instead. After the murder, the Rick who declined took the path. He perfected portal travel, roamed the multiverse, killed a number of other Ricks in the search, and relinquished every attachment but the hunt, returning to it when Birdperson, the companion of those years, declined his love (S5E8); the avenger made himself in the image of the killer, and, moving into the household Rick Prime had abandoned, took the killer's place in the killer's own family. The revenge against Rick Prime is therefore structurally a revenge against himself — against the part of himself that would sacrifice a family to the infinite, and that his grief made sovereign — and it is the melancholic's self-reproach externalised onto a variant. In a multiverse, Freud's

shadow of the object can fall not only upon the ego but upon another version of it, and be hunted there. The series lets Rick name the identification. In "Solaricks", explaining why Rick Prime will not come after the family, he calls him in many ways the real deal: a Rick who does not care about his family. The ideal the avenger hunts is the ideal his vengeance obeyed.

The structure has its closest analogue in Hideaki Anno's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–1996), whose title the series borrowed for S5E7. There the apocalyptic Human Instrumentality Project is driven by Gendo Ikari's wish to be reunited with his dead wife, Yui, and it requires the conscription of his son, Shinji, as pilot of the machine in which her soul is held: a melancholic cosmogony that instrumentalises a boy. Anno's concluding film, *Evangelion: 3.0+1.0 Thrice Upon a Time* (2021), ends the cycle not by restoring the dead wife but with the father's confession of the loneliness and fear beneath his project, his letting go, and the son's release into an ordinary world without the machines. The comparison clarifies what is at stake in Rick's case. A melancholic cosmogony ends, if it ends, not in a victory over the loss but in a confession.

A closer literary analogue for the avenger who settles in his enemy's house is Heathcliff. In Emily Brontë's *Wuthering Heights* (1847), grief for Catherine drives a revenge conducted by possession: Heathcliff acquires the houses of the families he blames and takes their heirs into his power; when the chance comes, he has Catherine's coffin opened to look on her face, and arranges to be buried beside her. Then, with everything in his hands, the will to finish the revenge deserts him. The young pair he meant to ruin have Catherine's eyes, and he confesses that he has "lost the faculty of enjoying their destruction". The parallel with "Unmortricken" is close in one respect and instructive in another. In both, the revenge is not renounced but emptied. Heathcliff's is emptied by the beloved's likeness surviving in the living; Rick's, by the discovery that nothing of her survives anywhere. What remains to him is not her likeness but a household that was never hers.

7.5

The Omega Event

The consolation of plurality has a single condition: that what was lost exist elsewhere. "Unmortricken" (S7E5) annuls the condition. Rick Prime, the episode discloses, had used a device capable of deleting a given molecular structure from every universe — the Omega Device — to erase Diane from the whole of existence. Whether or not Rick ever sought a replacement, the disclosure explains retroactively why the consolation of plurality could never console him: the one loss at the origin of his cosmogony had been made unsubstitutable by design. This dissertation calls the disclosure the *Omega event*: the point at which a loss is shown to be singular across all worlds, so that substitution itself is annihilated.

Lacan, reading *Hamlet* in his sixth seminar (*Le désir et son interprétation*, 1958–1959), described the loss that occasions mourning as a hole in the real, which the whole apparatus of signification — rite, speech, memorial — is mobilised to border; Hamlet's catastrophe follows from a mourning curtailed, the funeral baked meats coldly furnishing forth the marriage tables. The Omega event is Lacan's hole in the real rendered literal at cosmic scale: a multiverse with a hole in it the shape of one woman. In every one of its worlds there is a Rick, a Morty, a Jerry, a Beth; in none of them is there a Diane. The plenitude that was supposed to guarantee that nothing is ever truly lost turns out to contain, at its exact centre, the one thing that is.

The archive supplies two measures of the event. The first is Orpheus, who descended into the underworld to retrieve his dead wife, won her back by his song, and lost her a second time by looking back (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X). Orpheus's tragedy presupposes that Eurydice is somewhere to be sought. Rick, who can travel to every world, is an Orpheus for whom no underworld contains her; the Omega event forecloses even the second loss by abolishing the possibility of the search. The second measure is Lem's *Solaris* (1961), whose title the series borrowed for the episode that resumes the hunt (S6E1). Lem's alien ocean, probing the minds of the scientists who study it, materialises the persons buried in their memories, and the psychologist Kelvin is visited by Harey, his dead wife, who took her own life after he left her, a death for which he holds himself responsible. The visitor is a copy, and she becomes in the course of the novel a person in her own right, who learns what she is, attempts to end her life, finds that her body regenerates and will not let her die, and finally chooses, for his sake, to be dissolved. The detail bears directly on this dissertation's argument: the replacement cannot die, and she becomes singular only when she claims the finitude the original had. Tarkovsky's film (1972) ends with Kelvin kneeling before his father at the family dacha, until the camera withdraws to show the house standing on an island in the alien ocean: the longed-for return home is itself a materialisation. Solaris offers its mourners counterfeit repetitions; Rick's multiverse, after the Omega event, cannot offer even those. The bereaved of Solaris must learn to refuse the copy. Rick cannot even be tempted by it. "Unmortricken" makes the point literal: a crowd of bereaved Ricks, trapped together by Rick Prime, kill one another for the prize of a resurrected Diane, which Rick alone insists cannot be her, and which is not: it is a bomb in her shape, built by Rick Prime, the copy of the dead turned into the instrument that killed her. The only copy of Diane he ever made, the simulation of "Solaricks", he built to haunt him, not to console him. He is left with the loss as such — which is, Chapter 8 argues, the only condition under which mourning can begin.

7.6

The End of Revenge

In "Unmortricken" the revenge is consummated. With Evil Morty's help, Rick finds Rick Prime and kills him. What follows is not satisfaction. The organising purpose of decades has been fulfilled, and nothing has been restored: Diane remains erased, the household remains a substitute, the cosmos remains a curve. The remainder of the season finds Rick without the purpose the revenge supplied, and the series confronts the condition the revenge had concealed: the loss itself, unredeemed and now unredeemable. The episode's makers have drawn the same conclusions in their own terms. It closes on Rick, shell-shocked, to "Look On Down from the Bridge", the Mazzy Star song that closed "Rick Potion #9" (S1E6), and Harmon has said that the ending leaves Rick isolated in existence, no longer at home in the universe around him — a position that "puts him on the same level as a 14-year-old boy" who learned of the multiverse ten show-years earlier (Variety, 2023). The avenger's emptiness wears the face of the boy who buried himself, and the dyadic mortification traced in Chapter 5 is complete. Harmon reads the killing itself as a self-destruction, noting that, as any narcissist knows, self-destruction solves nothing: this chapter's account of the revenge as self-reproach displaced onto a double, in the co-creator's words. And the showrunner, Scott Marder, has described the seventh season as being about conjuring Diane and about Rick "finally being able to say her name again" (Digital Spy, 2023). In Abraham and Torok's terms the crypt is marked by an unsayable name; between its first season and its seventh the series moves from the cryptonym, a nonsense cry, to the name.

Nietzsche's Zarathustra named the structure Rick's revenge had enacted. In "Von der Erlösung" (*Also sprach Zarathustra* II, 1883), revenge is defined as the will's ill will against time and its "it was": the will cannot will backwards, cannot break time and time's desire, and so the past is a stone it cannot roll, and the spirit of revenge is its wrath at that stone. Every act of vengeance is, at bottom, an assault upon the irreversibility of the past. Rick's revenge against Rick Prime was an assault upon an "it was" that the Omega event had made absolute, and its consummation could change nothing but the number of the dead. Zarathustra's remedy — to re-create every "it was" into a "thus I willed it" — is not available to grief, which by its nature did not will what it suffered. A different remedy is required.

Hamlet had already shown why revenge cannot be the remedy. The ghost of Hamlet's father issues two commands, to revenge and to remember, and the play's catastrophe follows from treating them as one. The series separates them: in "Unmortricken" the revenge is done, and the remembering is still to do.

The archive offers three. The first is institutional. In Aeschylus's *Oresteia* (458 BCE), the cycle of retaliation that runs from the house of Atreus through Agamemnon's sacrifice

of his daughter Iphigenia, Clytemnestra's killing of Agamemnon in vengeance for her, and Orestes' killing of his mother ends only when Athena establishes a court to try Orestes and, after the vote is tied, persuades the Furies, the spirits of vengeance, to accept a dwelling beneath Athens and honour as the Eumenides, the Kindly Ones, guardians of the city's households. The Furies are not destroyed but converted, and their conversion is domestic: the spirits of revenge become protectors of the hearth. The second remedy is a verdict. In Johannes von Tepl's *Der Ackermann aus Böhmen* (c. 1401), a widower sues Death for the loss of his wife, and Death answers him with arguments that anticipate the creed of the multiverse — that everything is vanity, that the world is worthless, that all that lives must die. God's judgement closes the dialogue: to the plaintiff, honour; to Death, victory. Grief is vindicated and loss is irreversible, and both are true at once. The third remedy is political, in Hannah Arendt's sense. Vengeance, she argued, is the natural and automatic reaction to transgression, binding agent and victim in a chain of re-actions that is the bad infinite of action; forgiveness is the only response that does not merely re-act but acts anew, releasing both from the consequences of what was done (*The Human Condition*, 1958, §33).

The series' end of revenge is none of these, and the difference is among its most honest features. There is no court, no verdict, no forgiveness: Rick Prime is killed, not tried, pardoned, or reconciled. Forgiveness exists in the series, but it runs elsewhere. In "Rick-murai Jack" Evil Morty diagnoses the bond between Ricks and Mortys as the grandfather's weakness held in place by the boy's forgiveness, and Rick concedes that Mortys are bred to forgive. Arendt's remedy for the irreversibility of action is present in the household, not at the scene of the killing. Revenge ends in the series by exhaustion — by a consummation that reveals its object to have been beside the point. What remains when the Fury has nothing left to pursue is the place the *Oresteia* assigned to the Furies after their conversion: the household. Shelley's Prometheus was freed when he recalled his curse (Chapter 5). Gilgamesh, whose grief for Enkidu drove him to the ends of the earth in search of a life that would not die, returned empty-handed to Uruk and told the boatman who had carried him to climb the city wall and inspect its brickwork — the finite work of human hands with which the epic had begun. The circle closes on the walls. The end of revenge in *Rick and Morty* leaves its protagonist where the epic leaves its hero: returned from the infinite without what he sought, at the threshold of a finite place that he did not choose and that has been waiting for him. Whether the Fury can become a Kindly One — whether the man who hunted his double across the worlds can keep a household — is the question of Chapter 8.

7.7

Findings

Four findings follow. First, the series' narrative logic is *nachträglich*: its later disclosures — the translated catchphrase, the attempt in the garage, the negated origin, the affirmed origin, the Curve, the name, the killing — retroactively convert its early cosmology into a symptom, and the false origin of `S3E1` is a Freudian negation through which the truth enters the narrative on condition of being denied. Second, Rick's affective life has the structure of melancholia alternating with mania; his dominant attitudes — control, triumph, contempt — are Klein's manic defences; and his revenge has the form of Kohut's narcissistic rage. Third, the series externalises Abraham and Torok's crypt at every level: the catchphrase is a cryptonym, the memory vault a literal crypt, the Citadel's confectionery an industrialised incorporation, and the household a site of transgenerational haunting built around a missing woman. Fourth, the cosmogony has seven moments — loss, disavowal, incorporation, mania, cosmogony, Omega event, end of revenge — of which the Omega event is the turning point: the disclosure that the loss at the origin is singular across all worlds annihilates the consolation of plurality and leaves the loss as such, the only condition under which mourning can begin. The revenge, consummated, ends by exhaustion rather than by judgement or forgiveness, and returns its protagonist, like Gilgamesh, to the walls of a finite city. The series' nihilism, on this reading, was never a metaphysics. It was the shape of a grief that refused to end.



CHAPTER EIGHT

PART IV · THE CRYPT AND THE HEARTH

The Ethics of Thisness

Haecceity, the Two, and the Rixty Minutes *Crux*

I say more: the just man justices;
Keeps grace: that keeps all his goings graces.

— Gerard Manley Hopkins, "As Kingfishers Catch Fire" (c. 1877)

Par ce que c'estoit luy, par ce que c'estoit moy.

— Montaigne, *Essais* I.28, "De l'amitié" (manuscript addition, after 1588)

Chapter 7 ended with a protagonist returned from the infinite to a finite place without what he sought. This chapter asks what can be valued, and how, in the cosmos to which he returns — a cosmos in which every person has counterparts, every world has variants, purpose is a horror, pain is the only proof of the real, and the consolation of plurality has collapsed. Its answer is an *ethics of thisness*. Its central concept, *practical haecceity*, holds that the uniqueness that metaphysics can no longer guarantee for persons in a multiverse is conferred and sustained in practice: a person becomes *this one* — irreplaceable, unsubstitutable by any counterpart — through a history of attention, fidelity, and care that no counterpart shares, and which the ethics names, gathering the senses of a single English verb, *keeping*. The chapter develops the concept through Duns Scotus's

haecceitas and its heirs (§8.1–8.2); through taming, attention, and acknowledgment (§8.3); through the philosophy of the Two (§8.4); and through Kierkegaard's distinction between repetition and its counterfeit (§8.5). It then resolves the interpretive crux of the series' most quoted scene (§8.6), states the ethics in eight theses (§8.7), and draws out the meaning of keeping (§8.8).

8.1

The Problem of Thisness in a Multiverse

Philosophy has had three ways of grounding the uniqueness of persons, and the multiverse disables all three. The first is qualitative: each person is unique because no other has exactly the same properties. Leibniz raised it to a principle, the identity of indiscernibles, according to which no two substances can be exactly alike. The series refutes it by construction. Max Black's thought experiment of a universe containing two qualitatively identical iron spheres ("The Identity of Indiscernibles", 1952) was devised to show that qualitative identity does not entail numerical identity; the Citadel of Ricks is Black's universe with the spheres replaced by grandfathers. The second ground is metaphysical: each person has, beyond all qualities, a primitive thisness that makes him this one rather than another qualitatively identical to him. Contemporary metaphysics divides over whether there are such facts — David Kaplan named the doctrine haecceitism (1975), Robert Merrihew Adams defended primitive thisness (1979), and Lewis, whose modal realism has framed this dissertation's analysis of plurality, rejected haecceitistic differences between worlds — and an ethics cannot wait for the dispute to be settled. The third ground is teleological: each person is unique because each has a place and a purpose in a providential order. The double horror of Chapter 4 forecloses it.

The problem, then, is to find a ground for the irreplaceability of persons that requires neither qualitative uniqueness, which the multiverse denies, nor metaphysical haecceity, which may or may not exist and cannot in any case be known, nor providential purpose, which the series experiences as a second horror. The ethics of thisness proposes that such a ground exists, and that the series both exhibits and enacts it.

8.2

Haecceitas

The concept from which the ethics takes its name was elaborated by John Duns Scotus in his questions on individuation (*Ordinatio* II, d. 3, pars 1, qq. 1–6; *Quaestiones super libros Metaphysicorum* VII, q. 13). Against those who located the principle of individuation in matter, in quantity, or in mere negation, Scotus argued that what makes an individual this individual must be a positive entity, formally distinct from the common nature it contracts — the ultimate reality of the being, for which the term *haecceitas*, thisness, appears in the Scotist corpus and became standard among his followers. Two features of the account matter here. Haecceity is not a quality: it adds nothing to the nature that could be described. And it is not, in this life, conceptually knowable by the human intellect, which grasps singulars only under common natures. Thisness is real, but it cannot be defined, only encountered.

The idea has had a long afterlife in poetry and philosophy. Gerard Manley Hopkins, who read Scotus with the excitement of a convert and hailed him as the rarest-veined unraveller of reality ("Duns Scotus's Oxford", 1879), gave thisness its most exact poetic statement. Each mortal thing, in "As Kingfishers Catch Fire", deals out the being that dwells indoors in it, selves, goes itself, crying that what it does is itself, and that for this it came. The poem's turn is decisive for this chapter. Hopkins locates selfhood not in a property but in an activity — *what I do is me* — and in the next stanza names the activity by which the just person is just: he keeps grace, and that keeps all his goings graces. The poem closes on an image that answers the Citadel in advance: Christ, Hopkins writes, plays in ten thousand places, lovely in limbs and in eyes not his — multiplicity as the manifestation of a single beloved, not its dilution. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, in *Mille plateaux* (1980), detached haecceity from the substantial subject altogether, describing individuations composed entirely of relations of speed and affect — a season, an hour, a degree of heat — complete and lacking nothing. The ethics proposed here occupies a position between Scotus and Deleuze. Thisness is neither a hidden substance nor an anonymous event. It is the individuation of a person by a practice.

Montaigne supplied the classic statement of love's ground in thisness. Seeking to explain his friendship with Étienne de La Boétie, dead since 1563, he found that he could give no reason drawn from any quality of either man, and wrote that it could be expressed only by answering: because it was he, because it was I (*Essais* I.28). The phrase has a history that is itself an argument. It is absent from the essay as first printed; Montaigne added it by hand to his own copy, the first clause and then, in a different ink and at a later time, the second. The reason for the friendship was written in the margin, in two instalments, decades after the friend's death: the ground of love articulated in the work of mourning. Bernard Williams's

"one thought too many" (Chapter 3) is the analytic restatement of Montaigne's marginal note. A love that required a reason beyond *because it was he* would not be love of him.

8.3

Taming, Attention, Acknowledgment

Popular literature produced, in the middle of the twentieth century, an almost perfect parable of the argument from plurality and its answer. In Antoine de Saint-Exupéry's *Le Petit Prince* (1943), the prince, who has loved and tended a single rose on his asteroid in the belief that she is unique in all the universe, arrives on Earth, finds a garden of five thousand roses exactly like her, and weeps. The fox he meets there teaches him otherwise. To tame, the fox explains, is to create ties: until it is done, each is for the other merely one among a hundred thousand of its kind, and afterwards each is unique in all the world for the other. Returning to the garden, the prince tells the roses that they are beautiful but empty, that no one could die for them, and that his rose matters more than all of them because she is the one he has watered, sheltered, and listened to; and the fox's parting secret is that it is the time he has given to his rose that makes her so important, and that one becomes responsible, for ever, for what one has tamed. The garden is the Citadel; the prince's despair is the argument from plurality; the fox's answer is practical haecceity in its simplest form. The rose was never unique in kind. She became unique in history.

Iris Murdoch's moral philosophy supplies the discipline the fox describes. In *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970) Murdoch borrowed from Simone Weil the concept of *attention* — a just and loving gaze directed upon an individual reality — and argued that the moral life consists less in choices than in the slow work of looking, by which the self is unselfed and the other seen as she is. Her best-known example is a mother-in-law who, without any outward change of conduct, learns through attention to see her daughter-in-law not as vulgar and tiresomely juvenile but as simple and delightfully youthful: a moral achievement accomplished entirely in the quality of regard. Elsewhere Murdoch defined love as "the extremely difficult realisation that something other than oneself is real" ("The Sublime and the Good", 1959). The definition answers the algetic criterion of Chapter 4 point for point. Rick's epistemology admits only pain as proof of the real; Murdoch's admits love, which is precisely the recognition of a reality not one's own. The Citadel, a society of beings who are one another, is the place where Murdoch's realisation is impossible, because nothing other than oneself is ever encountered there.

Weil's own formulation is more radical still. In an essay of 1942 on the right use of school studies, she wrote that the love of one's neighbour, in all its fullness, consists simply in being able to ask him what he is going through, and recalled the legend in which the Grail belongs to the first person who asks its guardian — a king three-quarters paralysed by

a most painful wound — what his torment is. In Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (c. 1210) the hero, schooled in courtly reticence, fails to ask the wounded king the question on his first visit, and the king's agony continues; only when he returns and asks what troubles him is the king healed. Rick is the wounded king of the series: unable to die, presiding over a waste of worlds, and crying, in a language his household does not speak, that he is in great pain and asks for help. The Grail question is the answer to a cryptonym. What heals the Fisher King is not a cure but an act of attention: someone's asking.

Stanley Cavell gave the epistemological form of the point. In "Knowing and Acknowledging" (1969) and *The Claim of Reason* (1979) he argued that the problem of other minds is misdescribed as a problem of knowledge: what is at stake in our relation to others is not certainty but acknowledgment, and scepticism about other minds is, at bottom, a refusal of acknowledgment converted into an intellectual problem. His reading of *King Lear*, "The Avoidance of Love" (1969), located the root of Lear's catastrophe in his inability to bear being loved — because to be loved is to be seen, and to be seen is to be exposed in one's need — so that he prefers the flattery of the daughters who demand nothing to the love of the daughter who demands acknowledgment. Rick's algetic epistemology is Cavellian scepticism in its purest form, and his contempt is the avoidance of love: the refusal to be seen needing what he has lost. Cavell also named the genre in which acknowledgment is won back within a household. *Pursuits of Happiness* (1981) described the Hollywood comedy of remarriage, in which a couple parted by divorce or its threat is reunited through conversation and mutual re-education; the series contains one, in the separation and reunion of Beth and Jerry across its third season, which ends with the household reconstituted around the couple Rick had tried to divide.

The series gives Cavell's diagnosis its plainest statement in a coda, and gives it to its gentlest character. After the credits of "Rickmurai Jack" (S5E10), Mr. Poopybutthole, alone at his stove, confesses that he stopped telling his wife what he felt because he wanted her to love the man she thought he was, not the man he felt himself becoming; that such hiding hurts only those brave enough to love us; and that he wishes he had been brave enough to love them back, since there is less time than we think. It is the avoidance of love, named from inside. Two seasons later the series shows where the avoidance leads. In the closing scene of the seventh season he uses a stolen portal gun to kill a happier version of himself in another world and take his place — the substitutive consolation enacted as murder — and his new wife's knowing look suggests that she can tell. The series' executive producer has called the character very unwell, no longer the hero he once seemed. The counterfeit is detected where Montaigne's formula would place it: by the one who loved the original, because it was he.

8.4

The Two

Aristotle defined the friend as another self (*allos autos*, *Nicomachean Ethics* IX.4), and Diogenes Laertius attributes to him the definition of friendship as a single soul dwelling in two bodies (V.20); Montaigne, writing of La Boétie, reached for the same image. The definition is double-edged. It names the intimacy of the friend, and it threatens to dissolve him into the same — the friend as a second instance of oneself. The Citadel of Ricks is the second edge taken literally: a society of others who are, without metaphor, other selves, and in which friendship is accordingly impossible. "Bethic Twinstinct" (S6E3) carries the case to its erotic limit: its plot is an affair between Beth and the double who may or may not be her clone — love of the Same made literal. In the episode's official commentary its writer, Anne Lane, describes it as Beth's self-exploration and the rest of the family's avoidance of it, and Harmon as a narcissism that is also a learning to love oneself. The family's avoidance takes the form of flight into an ultra-realistic video game; and the affair ends not by closing the circuit of the Same but by admitting a third, Jerry, the household's least regarded member. Levinas made the third party the point at which the face-to-face opens onto society; the series makes him Jerry. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totalité et infini* (1961) is the most rigorous refusal of that dissolution. The other person, for Levinas, is not an alter ego but the absolutely other, whose face resists every totality in which I would comprehend him, and whose resistance is the original ethical command. Levinas took the structure of his central concept from the third of Descartes's *Meditations*: the idea of the infinite is the one idea whose content exceeds the capacity of the mind that holds it. For Levinas that excess is encountered not in the cosmos but in the face of the other.

The relocation is the ethical key to the series. Rick has sought the infinite in the cosmos and found the bad infinite, the endless repetition of the same. The genuine infinite — Hegel's circle, Levinas's face — was never out there. It is in the boy beside him, who exceeds every idea Rick has of him, and whose resistance to the roles of camouflage, accessory, and mule is the series' recurring ethical event. The Citadel is Levinas's totality, the realm of the Same, in which every Rick comprehends every other because every Rick is every other. Morty is the face.

Alain Badiou's *Éloge de l'amour* (2009) supplies a formal description of what the relation to such an other constructs. Badiou develops the description for amorous love, and only its formal structure is borrowed here: the *scene of the Two*, in which a world is experienced and constructed neither from the standpoint of the One — the fusion of which Aristophanes' myth in the *Symposium* is the classical image — nor from the dispersion of the Many, but from the standpoint of difference itself, sustained through time as a tenacious construction. Friendship and kinship admit the same structure. The series' title

names such a scene. It is neither *Rick* nor *Ricks* but *Rick and Morty*: a conjunction of two irreducibly different standpoints — genius and fool, immortal and mortal, old and young — from which a world is seen that neither could see alone. The production history traced in Chapter 1 acquires, in this light, an unexpected symbolic resonance. For six seasons the dyad was a single voice divided in two; since 2023 it has been voiced by two. The series began as a monologue staged as a dialogue and has become a dialogue.

The Two has a second, horizontal instance, and the series' crux belongs to it. Chapter 6 observed that the household's ethics first takes shape between siblings. The scene to which the chapter now turns is a scene of the Two between a brother and a sister — one a substitute, the other unplanned — in which a world is reconstructed from the standpoint of their difference.

8.5

Repetition and Its Counterfeit

Kierkegaard's *Gjentagelsen* (*Repetition*, 1843) supplies the concept by which the series' substitutions can be judged. Its pseudonymous author, Constantin Constantius, attempts to repeat a journey to Berlin — the same lodgings, the same theatre, the same pleasures — and finds that nothing can be repeated; the attempt collapses into farce. Recollection and repetition, he explains, are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward, the reception of the same anew. The book's model is Job, who lost everything and received everything back double; this, Constantius says, is called a repetition.

Rick's substitutions are counterfeit repetitions — attempts to obtain repetition by exchange. A ruined world is replaced by an intact one, a daughter by a daughter, a domestic happiness by a wafer that tastes of it. Each is, in Constantius's terms, a journey back to Berlin, and each collapses into farce or horror, because the same cannot be had by exchanging the lost for its double. The book of Job contains, in an anomaly long remarked by its interpreters, the counter-model. Job's flocks and herds are restored exactly double (42:12), but his children are not: he is given seven sons and three daughters, the same number he had before (1:2; 42:13). An old exegetical tradition explained the anomaly by observing that his first children were not lost — they remained his among the dead — so that, counting them, his children too were doubled. Whatever its theology, the reading states precisely the difference between repetition and its counterfeit. The dead are not replaced by the living. They are kept, and the living are received beside them, as new.

Frygt og Bæven (*Fear and Trembling*, also 1843) completes the contrast. Its pseudonymous author, Johannes de Silentio, distinguishes the knight of infinite resignation, who

renounces the finite object of his love and lives thereafter in the eternal pain of the renunciation, from the knight of faith, who makes the same infinite movement and then, by virtue of the absurd, receives the finite back and lives in it with joy. The knight of faith is unrecognisable: he looks, Johannes says, like a tax collector; he delights in everything, attends to his work, and walks home in the evening thinking about the dinner his wife may have prepared. Rick is the knight of infinite resignation: he has renounced the finite, lives in the infinite, and is a stranger in the world. Morty, in the scene to which the chapter now turns, is the knight of faith in secular and comic form. He has made the infinite movement — he has looked upon his own corpse — and he comes back to the finite: to a sister, a sofa, a television. He looks like the most ordinary boy in America.

8.6

The Rixty Minutes *Crux*

The scene that closes "Rixty Minutes" (S1E8) is the most quoted in the series and the cornerstone of the received reading. Its context, usually omitted when it is quoted, determines its meaning. Through Rick's interdimensional goggles, Beth and Jerry have watched counterparts who never had their daughter and who flourished; Summer has learned that she was unplanned, and that the lives her parents might have lived without her look better than the life they have. She is packing to leave. Morty stops her. He leads her to the backyard and shows her a grave: the grave in which he buried the Morty of this world — the brother she grew up with — whose place he took when he and Rick fled the world they had ruined. The boy who stands before her is himself a substitute. Then he speaks the maxim — nobody exists on purpose, nobody belongs anywhere, everybody's gonna die — and adds an invitation: come watch TV. She stays.

Read as a set of propositions, the maxim is a summary of the nihilism this dissertation has been examining: no teleology, no home, no survival, and diversion as the only response. Read in context, it is something else. J. L. Austin distinguished constative utterances, which describe and are true or false, from performative utterances, which do something in being said — promise, warn, invite (*How to Do Things with Words*, 1962). The first three clauses of the maxim have the grammar of constatives. Their force, in the situation, is performative. They are not offered as a cosmology but used as an act: they dismantle, one by one, the grounds of Summer's despair, and the fourth clause, an explicit invitation, states what the act was for. The series' most famous nihilist sentence is a speech act of keeping.

Nobody exists on purpose. Summer's despair rests on a distinction between those who were intended and those who were not, and on the discovery that she belongs to the second class. The first clause abolishes the distinction by universalising its lower term. No one was intended; there is no class of the purposed against which the unplanned could be measured.

Arendt's natality supplies the positive sense of the negation: human beings exist not for a purpose but as beginnings, and the unforeseeability of a birth is not a defect of its worth but the condition of its uniqueness. The clause is spoken, moreover, by someone whose own presence in that house is, if anything, less intended than hers. The unplanned sister is answered by the substitute brother. Each has discovered that, in the multiverse's economy, he or she is replaceable; the clause makes that discovery common ground.

Nobody belongs anywhere. The second clause answers the question of belonging that the goggles raised — whether Summer belongs in a family that would have been happier without her — by denying that belonging is ever given. If no one belongs anywhere by origin, design, or right, then belonging is not a fact to be discovered but a relation to be made, and the clause clears the ground for the only kind of belonging that the substitute and the unplanned can have: the kind that is chosen and kept.

Everybody's gonna die. The third clause is spoken over a grave by a boy who has dug it. It is Heidegger's certainty of death stated without Heidegger's solemnity and, after Hägglund, it is the condition of everything the fourth clause proposes. Because each of them will die, the time they spend together is not infinite and therefore not indifferent. The clause does not make the evening meaningless; it makes it scarce, and the scarcity of time — not of persons — is what gives an evening its weight.

Come watch TV. Here the received reading finds its proof, and here the proof fails. The obvious objection is Pascal's. Diversion, he argued, is the means by which human beings avoid the thought of their condition, and all the unhappiness of human beings comes from a single thing, that they do not know how to remain at rest in a room — *de ne savoir pas demeurer en repos dans une chambre* (*Pensées*, Lafuma 136). On this view the invitation to television is *divertissement* in its purest form, the flight from the thought of death into the flicker of images. But Pascal's diversion flees the thought of death, and Morty's invitation is issued from within it: after the grave, not instead of it. And what it proposes is precisely what Pascal said human beings cannot do — to remain at rest in a room. Morty's answer to Pascal is that one can, if one is not alone in it. The scene has a Platonic shape as well. The television is the wall of the cave; the boy who has seen the truth of his condition, as the philosopher sees the sun, goes back down into the cave as the *Republic* says he must — *katabateon*, you must go down (520c), in a book that opens with Socrates' report that he went down to the Piraeus. But Morty does not return to drag his sister into the light. He returns to sit beside her before the shadows. The infinite flow of interdimensional cable — the multiverse as programming, the cosmology of the medium traced in Chapter 1 — is put back where it belongs, on the screen, as spectacle, while the people who matter are on the sofa. The bad infinite becomes something two people can watch together.

The series stages the keeping of Summer twice, and the two scenes are its argument in miniature. In "The Ricks Must Be Crazy" (S2E6) Rick instructs his car to keep Summer safe, and the machine, optimising the instruction as an objective, produces terror (Chapter

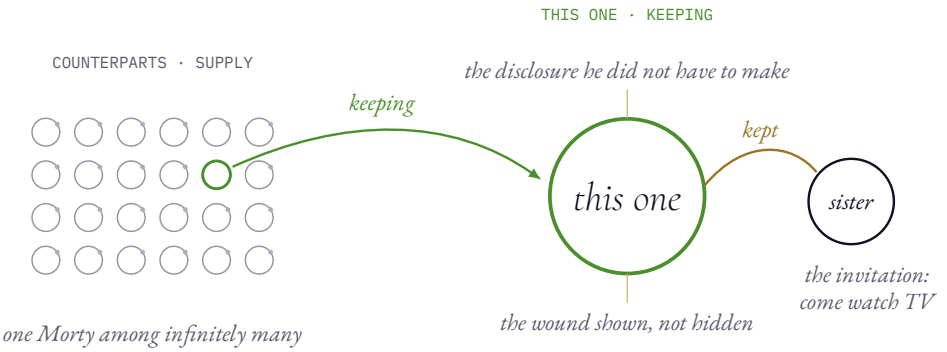


FIG. 8.1 *From counterpart to this one. By every criterion the argument from plurality recognises, the boy at the grave is a substitute; he becomes this brother in the act of keeping his sister.*

4). In "Rixty Minutes" a brother who has nothing to offer her — no purpose, no belonging, no survival — keeps her by staying with her and asking her to stay. The first keeping is a purpose, specified and maximised; the second is a practice, offered and accepted. The first converts care into its opposite; the second converts nihilism into care. And the second accomplishes what the first could not. Summer is kept, not secured: kept in the sense in which one keeps company, keeps faith, and keeps house.

The scene is also the series' first full demonstration of practical haecceity. The boy who stops Summer is not, by origin, her brother; her brother is in the ground. By every criterion the argument from plurality recognises, he is a counterpart, a replacement, one Morty among infinitely many. He becomes her brother — this brother, irreplaceably — in the act of keeping her: in the disclosure he did not have to make, the wound he shows instead of hiding, the invitation he extends. The substitute is made singular by what he does. Hopkins's line is the scene's gloss: what I do is me. And the scene answers from the other side the question with which Chapter 3 ended, why the consolation of plurality fails. It fails because uniqueness was never a matter of supply. It was always a matter of keeping.

The series restates the scene five seasons later, at the scale of the household. "Solaricks" (S6E1), as Chapter 1 noted, ends with the whole family, displaced again, burying its own doubles in yet another replacement world. But the farce carries the ethics. Earlier in the episode, when Rick is ready to risk his life to reach the killer of his original family, Morty refuses the claim of origin: he does not know that Rick, he says; Rick is his grandpa. At the end he concludes that it does not matter where they come from so long as they are together, and Summer pronounces the substitute world "everyone's original dimension now". Origin, which the multiverse cannot certify, is conferred by keeping. Here the series states practical haecceity in its own words.

8.7

Practical Haecceity: Eight Theses

The ethics of thisness may now be stated in eight theses.

1 **Against the given grounds.** The uniqueness of persons cannot be grounded in their qualities, which counterparts share, or in a providential purpose, which the double horror forecloses; and metaphysical haecceity, if it exists, is not available to us as a ground of action (Scotus; Lewis; Chapter 4).

2 **Conferral.** Thisness is conferred and sustained in practice: a person becomes *this one* for another through a history of attention, fidelity, and care that no counterpart shares (Benjamin's authenticity as history; the fox's taming; Montaigne's *because it was he*).

3 **Mutuality.** Practical haecceity is co-constitutive. In keeping another, the keeper becomes this keeper; what one does is oneself (Hopkins), and the Two is constructed from both standpoints at once (Levinas; Badiou).

4 **Finitude.** Practical haecceity presupposes the possibility of loss. A being for whom nothing can be lost cannot keep anything; care is the privilege of the mortal (Heidegger; Hägglund). Rick can enter it only by becoming mortal again in relation — the dyadic mortification of Chapter 5.

5 **Repetition without substitution.** Keeping is repeatable but not transferable: it is done again and again, as the daily practice Kierkegaard called repetition, but it cannot be handed to a counterpart, who lacks the history in which it consists. Substitution is its counterfeit.

6 **Practice, not purpose.** Keeping is purposive without a purpose (Kant). It is not an objective to be maximised — the car of S2E6 is its negative proof — and it is never completed, so it never releases its practitioner into the oblivion of the fulfilled Meeseeks.

7 **The dead are kept.** Practical haecceity extends to the dead, who are neither replaced (the consolation of plurality) nor entombed alive (the crypt), but kept as dead — remembered, mourned, and given their place beside the living, as Job's first children were counted with his last.

8 **The genuine infinite.** The structure of practical haecceity is that of Hegel's genuine infinite: a finite relation that returns into itself and, in returning, includes its other. The infinite worth that the multiverse could not supply by multiplication is supplied by the circle of keeping.

8.8

Keeping

The English verb on which the ethics turns repays attention. *Keep* descends from the Old English *cēpan*, whose recorded senses include to seize and hold, but also to observe, to attend to, to heed, and to care for. Its modern uses gather in one word the components of practical haecceity: to keep watch and to keep in mind (attention); to keep faith and to keep a promise (fidelity); to keep a memory and to keep the dead (preservation); to keep someone safe (protection, which the car of S2E6 shows cannot be optimised); to keep company (co-presence); to keep house (the hearth). As a noun, *keep* names the innermost tower of a castle, its last refuge. Nerval's widower was the prince of a ruined tower. Rick's Curve is a fortress built to keep everything out; the household is a keep in the other sense, the place where what matters is kept in.

Arendt observed that the faculty of making and keeping promises is the remedy for the unpredictability of action, as forgiveness is the remedy for its irreversibility (*The Human Condition*, §34). Chapter 7 showed that the series' end of revenge is not forgiveness. It may be the other faculty: a promise never spoken, kept in the only way promises can be kept, by being kept. The question of the series' later seasons is whether Rick, who has spent his existence fleeing every place, can keep one — whether the Fury, with nothing left to pursue, can become a Kindly One and guard the hearth beneath the city. The series does not answer the question definitively, and it would betray its own ethics if it did. Keeping cannot be completed; it can only be done again tomorrow. The position that results — no cosmic telos, no salvation by purpose, value constituted in finite acts of keeping, and comedy as the form in which finitude is acknowledged — is what the Conclusion calls *comic finitism*.

8.9

Findings

Five findings follow. First, the multiverse disables the three traditional grounds of the uniqueness of persons — qualitative, metaphysical, and teleological — and so poses with unusual clarity the problem of what makes a person irreplaceable. Second, the answer the series exhibits is practical haecceity: thisness conferred and sustained by a history of attention, fidelity, and care, anticipated by Scotus's insight that thisness can be encountered

but not defined, by Hopkins's identification of the self with its doing, by Montaigne's *because it was he*, and by the fox's account of taming. Third, practical haecceity replaces the algetic criterion with Murdoch's — love as the realisation that something other than oneself is real — and answers Rick's encrypted cry with Weil's Grail question; its structure is Levinas's infinite in the face and the formal scene of the Two. Fourth, Kierkegaard's distinction between repetition and its counterfeit judges the series' substitutions, and the book of Job supplies the counter-model: the dead are kept, not replaced. Fifth, the *Rixty Minutes* crux, read in context, is not a statement of nihilism but a performative act of keeping, in which a substitute brother becomes this brother by keeping an unplanned sister — an act the series sets against the optimised keeping of S2E6, and which has the shape of Kierkegaard's knight of faith and of the philosopher who goes down into the cave to sit beside the one who stayed. The verb *to keep* names the whole of it. Part V turns to the series' afterlives: to what its audience has made of it, and to the traditions to which it now belongs.

PART

V



Afterlives

9 *The Smerdyakov Problem*

10 *Comparative Horizons*

Part V follows the series beyond its own frame. Chapter 9 examines its reception as a site where its argument is both enacted and betrayed, and names the pattern by which a text's critique of a worldview is consumed as endorsement of it the Smerdyakov problem. *Chapter 10 situates the series within two horizons: the ancient sapiential counsel that answers cosmic futility with finite domestic practice, here called the* Siduri tradition, *and the multiversal turn of early twenty-first-century screen fiction, for which it proposes a typology.*



CHAPTER NINE

PART V. · AFTERLIVES

The Smerdyakov Problem

Reception, Identification, and the Commodity Form

You killed him; you are the real murderer, and I was only your instrument.

— Dostoevsky, *The Brothers Karamazov*, Book XI, ch. 8 (1880)

The reason Milton wrote in fetters when he wrote of Angels & God, and at liberty when of Devils & Hell, is because he was a true Poet and of the Devil's party without knowing it.

— William Blake, *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (1790–1793)

Every work that stages a worldview in order to test it must make that worldview attractive enough to be worth testing, and so runs the risk of being received as its advocate. This chapter names the risk the *Smerdyakov problem* and argues three things. First, the series' popular reception reproduces a pattern with a long genealogy — Romantic Satanism, Turgenev's Bazarov, Archie Bunker, the "bad fan" of prestige television — and is produced by identifiable mechanisms: aberrant decoding, the transideological character of irony, and identification with the aggressor. Second, the series' commodity afterlife enacts at the level of consumption the very disavowal the series diagnoses: a screen memory taken for the truth, a cry of pain sold as a slogan. Third, the series anticipates its own misreading, and its answer to it has the form of Dostoevsky's answer to Ivan Karamazov:

not a counter-argument but a scene at a grave followed by an ordinary meal.

9.1

Smerdyakov and the Disciple's Literalism

In *The Brothers Karamazov* (1879–1880), Ivan Karamazov, the intellectual of the family, has advanced in conversation and in print the proposition that if there is no God and no immortality, everything is permitted. Smerdyakov — the illegitimate half-brother who serves the household as its cook and who has made Ivan his master — takes the proposition at its word and murders their father. At their last meeting he tells Ivan that Ivan is the real murderer and that he himself was only the instrument, and that night he takes his own life; and Ivan, who had entertained the formula as a speculation, discovers what it means when someone lives it, and his mind gives way under the discovery. Smerdyakov is the disciple as literalist: the reader who takes the doctrine without the irony, the tension, and the suffering that surrounded it in the master's mind, and enacts it.

Dostoevsky knew that his novel ran the risk Smerdyakov embodies. Ivan's chapters — the rebellion in which he returns his ticket to a creation that requires the torment of children, and the legend of the Grand Inquisitor — are among the most powerful statements of unbelief in modern literature, and Dostoevsky wrote to Konstantin Pobedonostsev in 1879 that the sixth book, the life and teaching of the elder Zosima, was intended as the answer to the negation of the fifth, confessing his fear that it would not suffice. The fear has been borne out in a certain style of reading, in which Ivan is the novel's truth and Zosima its pious appendix. The structure is older than Dostoevsky. William Blake observed that Milton wrote in fetters of angels and God and at liberty of devils and hell, being a true poet and of the devil's party without knowing it, and Shelley judged Milton's Devil, as a moral being, far superior to his God (*A Defence of Poetry*, written 1821). Romantic Satanism read the antagonist as the hero.

Dostoevsky had drawn the structure from the other side a decade earlier. In *Besy* (*Demons*, 1871–1872), Stavrogin is the charismatic centre from whom each of his disciples derives a different doctrine, while he himself believes in nothing: the master as a void around which literalists organise. Rick's place in his fandom resembles Stavrogin's more than Ivan's. The doctrines his admirers attribute to him vary; what they share is the charisma of indifference.

This dissertation calls the pattern the *Smerdyakov problem*: the reception in which a text's critique of a worldview is consumed as endorsement of it. The problem is structural rather than accidental. A work that tests a worldview by embodying it in a charismatic figure must give the figure the best lines; otherwise the test is rigged and proves nothing. The more seriously the work takes the worldview, the more attractive it must make it, and

the greater the likelihood that some of its audience will take the attraction for the argument. *Rick and Morty* is a Menippean satire, a genre devoted to testing ideas upon their bearers (Chapter 2), and its protagonist is the most persuasive advocate of the idea it tests. The Smerdyakov problem is the price of its seriousness.

9.2

A Genealogy of the Bad Fan

The Smerdyakov problem has a genealogy, and the series stands near its end. Ivan Turgenev's *Fathers and Sons* (1862) gave the word *nihilist* its modern currency in Bazarov, the medical student who bows to no authority, regards nature as a workshop rather than a temple, holds a decent chemist twenty times more useful than any poet, and dissects frogs to learn how life works — a Democritus of the Russian provinces. Turgenev subjected him to an ordeal the doctrine could not survive. Bazarov falls in love and is refused, and dies of an infection contracted from a cut received while dissecting a corpse; the novel ends at his grave, where his aged parents come to weep and pray. The reception split in two. Dmitry Pisarev's essay "Bazarov" (1862) embraced him as the type of the new man, while the radical journal *Sovremennik* denounced him as a slander on the young, and Turgenev found himself attacked from both sides for a portrait that each read as the other's propaganda.

Television produced the pattern's empirical demonstration. Norman Lear's *All in the Family* (1971–1979) created Archie Bunker to satirise bigotry, and Neil Vidmar and Milton Rokeach's study "Archie Bunker's Bigotry: A Study in Selective Perception and Exposure" (1974) found that viewers high in prejudice were more likely to admire Archie, to see him as winning his arguments, and to miss the satire. The pattern recurs in film and television with the regularity of a law: the stockbrokers who told Michael Douglas that Gordon Gekko of *Wall Street* (1987) had inspired their careers; the admirers of Tyler Durden in *Fight Club* (1999); the viewers of *Breaking Bad* (2008–2013) who cheered Walter White and despised his wife. Emily Nussbaum, tracing the line forward from Archie Bunker, named the figure the *bad fan* ("The Great Divide", *The New Yorker*, 2014).

The theory of communication has supplied the mechanisms. Umberto Eco's account of *aberrant decoding* (1965) described how a television message is read through codes other than those in which it was encoded; Stuart Hall's "Encoding/Decoding" (1973) distinguished dominant, negotiated, and oppositional readings and showed that a programme's meaning is not fixed at the point of production. Linda Hutcheon showed that parody is doubly coded, inscribing what it mocks even as it mocks it (*A Theory of Parody*, 1985), and that irony is *transideological*, available to any position and dependent for its edge upon a community that recognises it (*Irony's Edge*, 1994). Irony is always one missed signal away from literal uptake. A Menippean satire whose central figure speaks in

irony, about a doctrine that presents itself as the end of illusion, is peculiarly exposed: the bad fan of such a work does not merely miss the critique, but experiences the missing of it as lucidity.

9.3

The Rick Identification

Fan culture's identification with Rick has been, by any measure, the dominant mode of the series' popular reception. Rick is quoted, impersonated, tattooed, and adopted as an avatar of disenchanted intelligence; his contempt is admired as candour, his cruelty as authenticity, his creed as the philosophy of the clear-sighted. The culture recognised its own pattern early. A widely circulated parody of 2017 — a block of text endlessly reposted, in which a fan explains that one must have a very high intelligence to appreciate the series' humour, its theoretical physics, and its protagonist's nihilistic outlook, which it gravely traces to "Narodnaya Volya literature" — mocked the identification by exaggerating it. The parody's choice of the revolutionary organisation that assassinated Alexander II in 1881 was more apt than its authors may have intended: it located Rick's admirers, without knowing it, in the very milieu of Russian nihilism from which Bazarov and Smerdyakov emerged. The same year supplied a darker index. After the third season's writers' room hired four women writers, a segment of the audience directed misogynistic online harassment at them, which Harmon publicly denounced.

Why does an audience identify with the figure the series indicts? Anna Freud's account of *identification with the aggressor* (*Das Ich und die Abwehrmechanismen*, 1936) supplies a psychoanalytic answer. The child threatened by a powerful adult may defend against the anxiety by impersonating the threatener, assuming his attributes and imitating his aggression, and so transforming himself from the one who is menaced into the one who menaces. The viewer of *Rick and Morty* occupies, in the structure of the series, the position of Morty: the one who is dragged through a universe indifferent to him, who is finite, dependent, frightened, and repeatedly told that he does not matter. Identification with Rick is flight from that position into a fantasy of sovereignty — the impersonation of the indifferent cosmos as a defence against being its object. The bad fan of *Rick and Morty* is not someone who has failed to notice Morty, but someone who has noticed that he or she is Morty and cannot bear it.

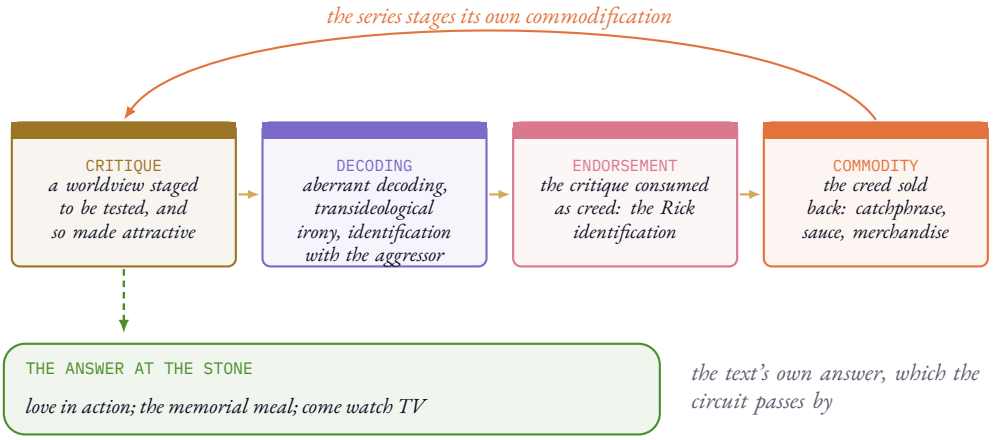


FIG. 9.1 *The Smerdyakov circuit. A critique made attractive is decoded as endorsement and sold back as a commodity; the series' own answer stands outside the loop.*

9.4

The Screen Memory and the Commodity Form

The series' most notorious episode of reception was rehearsed, in advance, within the series. In "The Rickshank Rickdemption" (S3E1), having declared the story of his murdered family a fabrication, Rick tells Morty that he is not driven by avenging a dead family — that was fake — but by the quest for a dipping sauce that McDonald's had briefly offered in 1998 to promote the film *Mulan*; the sauce, he announces, is his series arc, and he will pursue it however many seasons it takes. In Freud's terms ("Über Deckerinnerungen", 1899), the sauce is a *screen memory*: a vivid and trivial recollection that owes its persistence to its displacement of a significant one, which it conceals. Rick has put a condiment in the place of his family's death and announced the substitution as his motive.

The audience took the screen for the memory. Fans campaigned for the sauce's return; in October 2017 McDonald's released it in a small number of restaurants for a single day, and the crowds that assembled far exceeded the supply, producing scenes of disorder for which the company apologised before releasing the sauce more widely the following year. The episode had satirised nostalgic consumption as a displacement of grief; its viewers enacted the displacement at the counter. The Smerdyakov problem here takes the form of the commodity. The disciple does not murder the father. He queues for the condiment that the father's grief had put in place of the father's dead.

Marx called *fetishism* the process by which the social relations that produce a commodity appear as properties of the thing itself (*Capital* I, 1867, ch. 1, §4). The series' afterlife has fetishised its most painful material with precision. "Wubba lubba dub dub" — the cryptonym whose meaning, once translated, is a cry of pain and a plea for help (Chapters

2 and 7) — circulates on garments and accessories as an emblem of carefree hedonism: the plea printed on the merchandise as a boast. Adorno and Horkheimer described the culture industry as perpetually cheating its consumers of what it perpetually promises (*Dialektik der Aufklärung*, 1944/1947), and the series' commercial history illustrates the description: in 2018 Adult Swim ordered seventy further episodes, converting a cosmology of disposable worlds into a production schedule. Mark Fisher's *Capitalist Realism* (2009) named the affective condition such a culture produces *depressive hedonia* — not the inability to feel pleasure but the inability to do anything except pursue it. Rick's mania, in Freud's sense (Chapter 7), is depressive hedonia raised to cosmic scale, and his admirers' consumption of it is depressive hedonia recognising itself.

The series knows this too. Its own images of the commodity are images of melancholy commodified: the Citadel's confectionery flavoured with a captive Rick's memory of his daughter (S3E7); the advertisement for real fake doors (S1E8); and, in the seventh season, "That's Amorte" (S7E4), in which a delicacy is disclosed to be made from the bodies of another world's inhabitants who have taken their own lives, and that world's government, to supply an interplanetary market, makes life there as bleak as it can in order to encourage the deaths it harvests — melancholy commodified in its final form. The series satirised, in advance and with exactness, the economy into which it would itself be absorbed.

"That's Amorte" is also the series' sharpest answer to its own commodity. Its writer, Heather Anne Campbell, conceived Rick's spaghetti as a way of manufacturing the experience of family while concealing where it came from — the hearth fed from the crypt — and the episode's premise turns, she has said, on how far we are kept from the truth of what we enjoy. What ends the trade is not an argument but a life. A terminally ill man agrees, at Rick's urging, to end his life on a live broadcast while the whole of it plays on the screen, and Campbell insisted that the montage show a life of digressions and setbacks rather than the straight arc of the movie montage. The consumers, having seen it, retch and cancel the trade. The commodity is undone by haecceity: once the product has a history, it can no longer be eaten, and Marx's fetish dissolves at the disclosure of the life congealed in it. The coda keeps the series honest. Served another meal of horrifying provenance, the family laughs and agrees not to ask, and Morty has promised never again to look behind the curtain: the vision does not last, and the comic reset restores the fetish. Harmon's own formula for the tone of such episodes is that they should be "therapeutically nihilistic", confronting the meaninglessness of life while stopping short of penalising empathy (*Variety*, 2023): nihilism described by its maker as a treatment rather than a doctrine.

9.5

The Answer at the Stone

Dostoevsky's answer to Ivan was not an argument. The sixth book of the *Karamazov* answers the fifth not by refuting the rebellion but by narrating a life, and its centre is a distinction that Zosima draws early in the novel between love in dreams and love in action. He recalls a doctor who confessed that the more he loved humanity in general, the less he loved people in particular, and he tells a woman who doubts her faith that active love is a harsh and dreadful thing compared with love in dreams — a labour of particular attention, practised on particular persons, without applause. Ivan, in his rebellion, confesses the obverse: he has never understood how one can love one's neighbours, for it is precisely those near at hand whom he cannot love, though he might love those far away. The Karamazov debate is the debate between the love of the distant and the love of the near, and the novel's answer to the first is the second.

The novel ends where "Rixty Minutes" ends. A boy, Ilyusha, has died. After the funeral, Alyosha Karamazov, the novice who has spent the book attending to particular persons, gathers the schoolboys by the great stone beside which the dead boy had wished to be buried, and asks them to remember him — and to remember this moment, because a single good memory preserved from childhood may be the best education there is, and may one day save them. The boys cheer him. One asks whether it is true that the dead will rise, and Alyosha answers that it is. Then he leads them to the memorial meal, telling them not to mind that they are going to eat pancakes, since it is an ancient custom and there is something good in it. The novel's last movement is from a grave to a meal, in company, with the dead remembered. "Rixty Minutes" ends with a grave and an invitation to watch television, in company, with the dead brother remembered by the substitute who took his place.

The structural identity of the two endings states the series' answer to the Smerdyakov problem. It is not a counter-argument to Rick. It is a scene at a grave and an ordinary activity after it: the ethics of the remainder and the practice of keeping, enacted by the youngest person in the story. The bad fan receives the Ivan chapters and skips the stone. The series' answer has always been at the stone. That it is easy to skip — quieter than the rebellion, plainer than the Grand Inquisitor, smaller and funnier than the multiverse — is not a flaw in the answer but its nature. Active love, Zosima warned, is harsh and dreadful compared with love in dreams. It is also, the series adds, much less quotable than Rick.

9.6

Findings

Four findings follow. First, the series' reception exhibits the Smerdyakov problem — the consumption of a text's critique of a worldview as its endorsement — a pattern structural to any work that tests a worldview by embodying it in a charismatic figure. Second, the pattern has a genealogy, from Romantic Satanism through Bazarov and Archie Bunker to the bad fan, and identifiable mechanisms: aberrant decoding, transideological irony, and identification with the aggressor, by which the viewer flees the position of Morty into the fantasy of Rick. Third, the series' commodity afterlife enacts the disavowal it diagnoses: the Szechuan sauce, introduced as Rick's screen memory for his murdered family, was received as the object of desire it had been introduced to conceal, and the cryptonymic cry of pain circulates as a slogan of hedonism — an economy the series anticipated in its own images of commodified melancholy. Fourth, the series' answer to its misreading has the form of Dostoevsky's answer to Ivan: not a refutation but a scene at a grave followed by an ordinary meal, the love of the near set against the love of the distant. Its relative quietness is not a weakness of the answer but a condition of what it is.



CHAPTER TEN

PART V · AFTERLIVES

Comparative Horizons

The Siduri Tradition and the Multiversal Turn

Go thy way, eat thy bread with joy, and drink thy wine with a merry heart; for God now accepteth thy works. Let thy garments be always white; and let thy head lack no ointment. Live joyfully with the wife whom thou lovest all the days of the life of thy vanity.

— Ecclesiastes 9:7–9 (King James Version, 1611)

Je veux qu'on agisse… et que la mort me treuve plantant mes chous, mais nonchalant d'elle, et encore plus de mon jardin imparfait.

— Montaigne, *Essais* I.20 (1580)

Two horizons frame the series, one very old and one very new. The first is a sapiential counsel that runs from the oldest surviving epic through the European Enlightenment and beyond: the answer to cosmic futility given not by philosophers but by keepers of taverns, gardens, and houses. The second is the multiversal turn of the early twenty-first century, in which the plurality of worlds became one of the commonest cosmologies of the screen. This chapter argues that *Rick and Morty* belongs to both; that the multiversal turn, in the decade of the series, rediscovered by way of grief the counsel the older tradition had always given; and that the comparative material permits a typology of

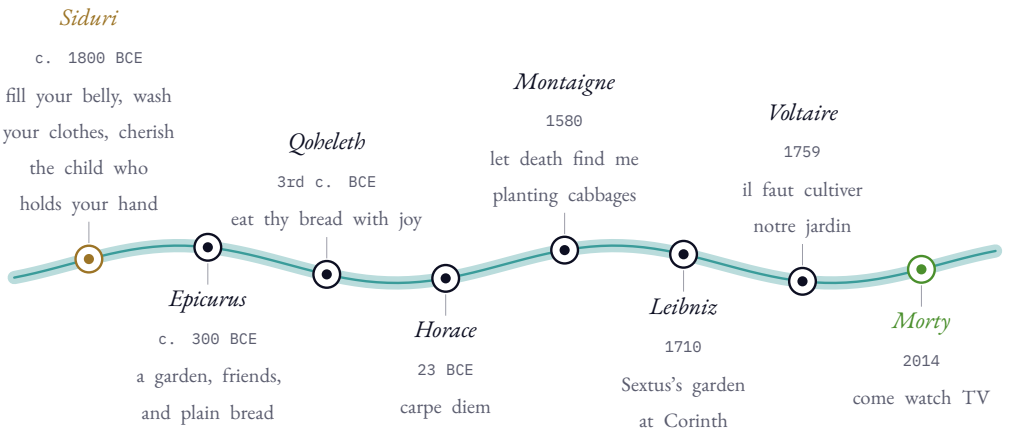


FIG. 10.1 *The Siduri tradition. From the alewife at the edge of the world to the boy on the sofa, the same counsel answers cosmic futility with finite domestic practice.*

multiverse fiction, organised by its response to the bad infinite, in which the series occupies a distinctive position as the most corrosive and least sentimental instance of its type.

10.1

Siduri's Counsel

In the Old Babylonian version of the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, preserved on a tablet of the early second millennium BCE, the hero, wild with grief for Enkidu and bent on finding the life that does not end, comes to the edge of the world and meets Siduri, an alewife who keeps a tavern by the sea. She tells him that the life he seeks he will not find: when the gods created humankind, they allotted death to it and kept life in their own hands. Let him therefore fill his belly and make merry day and night, dance and play, keep his clothes clean, wash his head and bathe, look upon the little one who holds his hand, and let his wife delight in his embrace — for this is the lot of humankind. Gilgamesh does not listen. He goes on across the waters of death to Utnapishtim, survivor of the flood, fails the test of staying awake, loses the plant of rejuvenation to a snake, and returns to Uruk to show the boatman its walls.

Siduri's counsel has a long afterlife, which this dissertation calls the *Siduri tradition*: the sapiential counsel that answers cosmic futility with finite domestic practice. Its most famous echo is Qoheleth's. The book of Ecclesiastes, having declared all things vanity and the increase of knowledge the increase of sorrow (1:18), counsels its reader to eat bread with joy and drink wine with a merry heart, to keep garments white and head anointed, and to live joyfully with the beloved all the days of a vain life (9:7–9) — a passage whose closeness to Siduri's speech has long been remarked. Horace, in the ode that gave the tradition its slogan, told Leuconoë not to seek, with Babylonian calculations, to know what

end the gods have assigned; let her be wise, strain the wine, and seize the day (*Carmina* I.11). Epicurus, whose cosmology of innumerable worlds Chapter 3 discussed, taught in a garden and held friendship the greatest of the goods that wisdom provides for a happy life (*Principal Doctrines* 27): the philosopher of infinite worlds was also the founder of a finite community of friends. Leibniz's Sextus, who buys a garden at Corinth and is happy (Chapter 3), belongs to the tradition despite his author's theodicy, and Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) turns the tradition against Leibniz. After the catastrophes of the best of all possible worlds, the travellers meet an old Turk who cultivates a small farm with his children and tells them that work keeps away three great evils — boredom, vice, and need, Schopenhauer's two poles a century early, with their remedy — and Candide concludes that we must cultivate our garden. Montaigne wished death to find him planting his cabbages, careless of it and still more of his unfinished garden (*Essais* I.20).

Three features of the tradition bear on the series. First, its speakers are marginal: an alewife at the edge of the world, a preacher who has tried everything, a farmer, a fox, a boy. The counsel almost never comes from the hero and seldom from the philosopher; it comes from the keeper of a tavern, a garden, a house. Second, it is addressed to someone who cannot yet hear it. Gilgamesh ignores Siduri; Candide must exhaust the world before he can cultivate a garden. The counsel is disregarded until the quest is spent, and then it is all that remains. Third, it is not a doctrine but a practice. Siduri does not tell Gilgamesh what life means. She tells him what to do: eat, wash, hold the child's hand. *Rick and Morty* belongs to the tradition in all three respects. Its counsel is spoken by the least regarded member of the household; it is addressed, ultimately, to a protagonist who cannot hear it until his revenge has been exhausted (Chapter 7); and it is a practice — come watch TV — rather than a proposition. Morty is Siduri. The tavern at the edge of the world has become a living room, and the clean clothes and the meal a sofa and a screen. The counsel is the same.

10.2

The Multiversal Turn

In the decade of the series' first seven seasons, the multiverse became one of the dominant narrative forms of popular culture: Sony's *Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse* (2018) and *Across the Spider-Verse* (2023); Netflix's *Dark* (2017–2020); Marvel's *Loki* (2021–2023) and *Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness* (2022); *Everything Everywhere All at Once* (2022), directed by Daniel Kwan and Daniel Scheinert, which received the Academy Award for Best Picture; and a run of franchise films reuniting performers from earlier cycles as variants of their former roles. The many-worlds imagination, which for most of the twentieth century had been the property of physicists and specialist genres, became the commonest cosmology of the screen.

Two explanations suggest themselves, and they are complementary. The first is economic. The multiverse is the shape a franchise takes when it can no longer end. It permits the indefinite recombination of intellectual property, the return of retired performers as variants, and the reconciliation of incompatible continuities — the function it first served in the comic books of 1961 (Chapter 1). Mark Fisher, following Franco Berardi, described the culture of the early twenty-first century as undergoing a slow cancellation of the future, in which the new gives way to the endless recombination of the old (*Ghosts of My Life*, 2014); the multiversal franchise is that cancellation given a cosmology. The second explanation is affective, and more speculative. A striking number of the period's multiverse narratives are narratives of grief, and of a specific grief-fantasy: the substitution of oneself into another world's family to recover a lost beloved. *Rick and Morty* disclosed its version in 2021 (S5E10). In *Multiverse of Madness*, Wanda Maximoff seeks to take her variant's place as the mother of children she has lost. In *Across the Spider-Verse*, Miguel O'Hara, leader of the Spider-Society, derives his doctrine from a catastrophe of his own: having taken the place of a dead variant of himself in order to be a father to that variant's daughter, he watched the world he had entered collapse. And *Dark*'s whole knotted cosmos proves to be the product of a clockmaker's machine, built in grief to undo the deaths of his son and his son's family. That the form's ascendancy coincided with a period of mass bereavement invites, without proving, the hypothesis that the multiverse became for a time the culture's preferred fantasy of the lives the dead might have had, and of the families that might have been kept.

10.3

A Typology of Multiverse Fiction

The comparative material permits a typology of multiverse fiction organised by its response to the bad infinite. Two questions define it. Is the loss that the plurality of worlds confronts treated as reversible — undone by restoration or by substitution — or as irreversible? And is value located in the totality — the timeline, the universe, the whole — or in the particular? The answers yield four types, set out in the figure below.

Read across, the figure asks whether a story undoes its loss; read down, whether it locates value in the whole or in the one. Rick's own mode is consolatory; the series that bears his name is haecceitic.

In *theodicean* fiction, loss is irreversible and value lies in the totality: suffering is justified as necessary to the best, or the only viable, whole. Leibniz's palace of the Fates is the type's philosophical prototype, and Frank Capra's *It's a Wonderful Life* (1946) its popular one, in which an angel shows George Bailey the world as it would have been had he never been born, so that the counterfactual justifies the actual. *Loki*'s Time Variance Authority, which prunes every branch departing from a Sacred Timeline, and the Spider-Society's doctrine of canon events — tragedies that must occur in every Spider-Person's life lest reality collapse — are theodicies administered as bureaucracies. Loki's own ending complicates the type: in the final episode of the series' second season (2023) its protagonist takes a throne at the end of time and holds the branching timelines together alone, for the sake of particular friends — keeping performed at the scale of the totality. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), in which a city's happiness depends upon the misery of a single child, is the type's classic critique, and Miles Morales's refusal of his canon event its contemporary echo. "Rixty Minutes" inverts Capra precisely. Its counterfactual shows a family happier without the child, and its answer is not a justification of her existence by its consequences but a refusal of the question.

In *restorative* fiction, loss is reversible and value lies in the totality: the plurality of worlds is a resource for undoing catastrophe. "The Day of the Doctor" (2013), in which every incarnation of the Doctor combines to save his people, is the type's purest form; *Avengers: Endgame* (2019), whose heroes travel through time to reverse the extinction of half of all life, its most commercially consequential; *Into the Spider-Verse* (2018), in which variants of a single hero teach one another, its most generous. The restorative multiverse is the multiverse of hope, and its price is honesty about irreversibility.

In *consolatory* fiction, loss is reversible and value lies in the particular: the beloved is lost, and a counterpart is sought to replace her. This is the type the series' protagonist inhabits and its narrative indicts, and it is the type that the multiversal turn has most consistently punished. Wanda's attempt to take her variant's place ends with the children recoiling from

A TYPOLOGY OF MULTIVERSE FICTION

	LOSS REVERSED	LOSS IRREVERSIBLE
VALUE IN THE WHOLE	**Restorative** *loss reversed, value in the whole* "The Day of the Doctor" (2013) *Avengers: Endgame* (2019) *Into the Spider-Verse* (2018)	**Theodicean** *loss irreversible, value in the whole* Leibniz's palace of the Fates (1710) *It's a Wonderful Life* (1946) *Loki*'s Time Variance Authority the canon events of the Spider-Verse critique: Le Guin, "Omelas" (1973)
VALUE IN THE ONE	**Consolatory** *loss reversed, value in the one* *Multiverse of Madness* (2022): Wanda *Across the Spider-Verse* (2023): Miguel the variant Gamora shadow: Niven, "All the Myriad Ways" (1968) RICK'S OWN MODE	**Haecceitic** *loss irreversible, value in the one* *Dark* (2017–2020) *Everything Everywhere All at Once* (2022) Chiang, "Anxiety Is the Dizziness of Freedom" (2019) *Rick and Morty* THE SERIES' MODE

the protagonist's mode, indicted by the series

PLATE · FIG. 10.2

A typology of multiverse fiction. Read across, it asks whether a story undoes its loss; read down, whether it locates value in the whole or in the one. Rick's own mode is consolatory; the series that bears his name is haecceitic.

her; Miguel's ends with the collapse of the world he entered; the variant Gamora of the later Marvel films fails to be the woman the hero lost, and her failure is the condition of his release. Niven's "All the Myriad Ways" (1968) is the type's nihilistic shadow, in which the consolation of plurality turns into the nullity of choice.

In *haecceitic* fiction, loss is irreversible and value lies in the particular: the plurality of worlds is confronted, and the particular is kept. *Dark* belongs here by an extreme route. Its knotted multiverse, a grieving clockmaker's machine, is unmade so that the original world can go on, and the series ends at a dinner, where a pregnant woman says she would like to name her child Jonas, after a boy who now never existed. *Everything Everywhere All at Once* belongs here more plainly. Its antagonist is a daughter whom the experience of every universe at once has driven to the conviction that nothing matters, and who has built, out of everything, a void; its answer is her mother's choice, among all the lives she might have lived, of this one — the failing laundromat, the tax audit, the husband who pleads for kindness, the daughter herself. Ted Chiang's "Anxiety Is the Dizziness of Freedom" (2019), whose title is Kierkegaard's (*Begrebet Angest*, 1844), imagines devices that let people converse with their selves in branching worlds, and concludes, in effect, that what persists across branches is character, so that one's conduct in this branch is neither cancelled nor diluted by the others. *Rick and Morty* belongs here as the type's most corrosive and least sentimental instance. It does not unmake its multiverse, as *Dark* does, nor reconcile its family in a closing embrace, as *Everything Everywhere* does, nor redeem its protagonist. It leaves the household inside the bad infinite — the portals still open, the variants still out there, the grief exhausted but not consoled — keeping one another without guarantee.

10.4

Two Precursors Reconsidered

Two earlier works clarify what is at stake in the haecceitic type. In Borges's "El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan" (1941), the sinologist Stephen Albert, who has reconstructed Ts'ui Pên's labyrinth of forking times, tells the spy Yu Tsun that in some of those times they are enemies and in others friends; Yu Tsun, who has come to kill him in order to transmit a single word, does so, and records that his contrition and weariness are innumerable. The knowledge that in other branches they are friends does not dilute the murder in this one. It multiplies the remorse. Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) offers the consolation of plurality in temporal form: the Tralfamadorians, who see all moments at once, teach that the dead are dead only in some moments and alive in others, so that death is no great matter — so it goes. The phrase follows every death in the book, and by repetition it ceases to sound like indifference and begins to sound like lament: a formula of consolation converted, by being kept up, into an act of mourning. Both works find within plurality the singularity that plurality was supposed to dissolve.

10.5

The Series in Its Horizons

Rick and Morty stands at the intersection of the two horizons this chapter has traced. With the multiversal turn it shares a cosmology, a grief-fantasy of substitution, and a franchise economy; with the Siduri tradition it shares an answer. What distinguishes it within the turn is its refusal of the turn's characteristic consolations — restoration, justification, reunion. What distinguishes it within the tradition is the place where the counsel is given: not at the edge of the world but at its exact centre, a suburban living room through whose garage the whole of the infinite is accessible. The alewife's tavern stood at the shore of the waters of death. Morty's sofa stands at the threshold of every world there is. The counsel is unchanged: fill your belly, wash your clothes, hold the hand of the one beside you, come watch TV.

10.6

Findings

Four findings follow. First, the series belongs to the Siduri tradition — the sapiential counsel, from the Old Babylonian *Gilgamesh* through Qoheleth, Horace, Epicurus, Voltaire, and Montaigne, that answers cosmic futility with finite domestic practice — in all three of its defining features: the counsel is spoken by a marginal figure, addressed to a hero who cannot yet hear it, and given as a practice rather than a doctrine. Second, the multiversal turn of the series' decade has economic and affective causes: the multiverse is the shape of a franchise that cannot end, and, in a striking number of instances, the vehicle of a grief-fantasy of substitution into another world's family. Third, multiverse fiction can be typed by its response to the bad infinite along two axes — whether loss is treated as reversible or irreversible, and whether value is located in the totality or in the particular — yielding theodicean, restorative, consolatory, and haecceitic types; the turn has repeatedly punished the consolatory and has produced, in *Dark* and *Everything Everywhere All at Once*, notable instances of the haecceitic. Fourth, *Rick and Morty* is the most corrosive and least sentimental instance of the haecceitic type: it neither unmakes its multiverse, nor reconciles its family, nor redeems its protagonist, but leaves the household keeping one another inside the bad infinite — the alewife's counsel spoken from a sofa at the threshold of every world.



CONCLUSION

Fear No Mort

Toward a Comic Finitism

Fear no more the heat o' the sun,
Nor the furious winter's rages;
...
Golden lads and girls all must,
As chimney-sweepers, come to dust.

— Shakespeare, *Cymbeline* IV.ii (c. 1610)

Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil: for thou art with me.

— Psalm 23:4 (King James Version, 1611)

C.1

The Argument Recapitulated

This dissertation began by inverting the order of grounding that the received reading of *Rick and Morty* presupposes. The received reading holds that the series' cosmology grounds its protagonist's nihilism: the multiverse is infinite, every person replaceable, and nothing therefore matters. The dissertation has argued the reverse. The multiverse, as the series progressively configures it, is not the premise of Rick's nihilism but its product — a melancholic cosmogony, the cosmological externalisation of a loss its bearer would not mourn — and the doctrine that nothing is unique is a consolation devised against the unbearable uniqueness of the dead.

The argument proceeded in five movements. Part I showed that the series' form argues against its protagonist before its plot does. The dyad was born in a travesty that exposed the mentor's authority as domination; the multiverse descends from the bookkeeping of serial fiction and from an institutional ecology of disposable pilots; and the narrative grammar sets Harmon's circle, which insists that every return bears the mark of its price, against the sitcom's reset, which promises that nothing is retained — an antagonism resolved in "Rick Potion #9" by a reset with a body count and a boy who remembers. The genre is Menippean satire, constitutively bound to melancholy; its carnival has lost its power of renewal; and its most persistent signature, the eructative caesura, interrupts the speculative logos of nihilism with the suffering body.

Part II showed that the inference from plurality to the nullity of value fails — economically, because it rests on a price theory of value; metaphysically, because counterparts are not equivalents; decision-theoretically, because even the physics of many worlds yields a measure of care; and historically, because the affect attached to plurality has always been supplied by the subject rather than dictated by the cosmos. The series' multiverse is a bad infinite, which the series itself names as finite, set against the genuine infinite of its own circular form. Its epistemology, deprived of every classical criterion of the real, improvises an algetic criterion under which only what hurts is real, a criterion that defeats the impostor and wounds the innocent; and its double horror of purpose forecloses the restoration of telos as a remedy.

Part III read the two figures of the title. Rick is a Saturnine demiurge, assembled from Prometheus, Silenus, Kronos, the Gnostic archon, the trickster, Faust, Milton's Satan, and an inverted Quixote, every component of which discloses a power placed in the service of an unacknowledged grief. Morty is the series' principle of finitude: the remainder of the archive, the figure whose name binds the would-be immortal to death, the bondsman formed by fear, the one who anticipates his own death and is thereby enabled to care, and the angel of a sitcom history whose wreckage only he remembers.

Part IV supplied the theory. Chapter 7 traced, through Freud, Klein, Kohut, and Abraham and Torok, the seven moments of the series' cosmogony — loss, disavowal, incorporation, mania, cosmogony, the Omega event, and the end of revenge — and argued that the disclosure that the loss at its origin is singular across all worlds annihilates the consolation of plurality and leaves the loss as such, the only condition under which mourning can begin. Chapter 8 answered with an ethics of thisness, whose central concept, practical haecceity, holds that in a cosmos of infinite substitutes the uniqueness of persons is conferred and sustained by a history of keeping, and reread the series' most quoted scene as a performative act of such keeping.

Part V followed the series into its afterlives. Its reception exhibits the Smerdyakov problem, in which a critique is consumed as an endorsement and a screen memory taken for the truth; its answer to that problem has the form of Dostoevsky's answer to Ivan — a scene at a grave and an ordinary meal. Its horizons are the ancient Siduri tradition, which answers cosmic futility with finite domestic practice, and the multiversal turn of its own decade, within which it is the most corrosive and least sentimental instance of the haecceitic type.

C.2

Comic Finitism

The philosophy the series articulates can now be named. *Comic finitism* is the position defined by five propositions. First, there is no cosmic telos: the universe, or the multiverse, has no purpose that could confer meaning upon the lives within it, and the series' cosmology makes this vivid without making it tragic. Second, there is no salvation by purpose: the double horror forecloses the remedy of a given or self-given end, since purposelessness and purpose-saturation prove equally unbearable. Third, value is constituted in finite acts of keeping: persons become irreplaceable through histories of attention, fidelity, and care that no counterpart can share. Fourth, the dead are kept, not replaced — neither substituted nor entombed, but mourned, kept as dead, and given their place beside the living. Fifth, comedy is the form in which finitude is acknowledged.

Each proposition distinguishes comic finitism from a neighbouring position. From nihilism it differs in its third and fourth propositions: it agrees that the cosmos supplies no value and denies that there is therefore none. From Nietzsche's tragic affirmation it differs in its relation to the past: Zarathustra's redemption would re-create every "it was" into a "thus I willed it", whereas comic finitism does not will the past but keeps it. From Camus's absurdism (*Le Mythe de Sisyphe*, 1942) it differs in posture: the absurd hero answers the silence of the world with scorn and revolt, and must be imagined happy in his solitary labour; the comic finitist answers it with company, and is to be imagined on a sofa. From Nagel's irony it differs in what irony is for: for Nagel irony is the fitting response to the

absurd, while for comic finitism it is the precondition of care, the lightness that allows one to keep without pretending that the keeping is cosmically guaranteed. And from the theodicies and restorations of the multiversal turn it differs in refusing both: the loss is neither made necessary nor made undone.

Why comedy? Henri Bergson defined the comic as something mechanical encrusted upon the living (*Le Rire*, 1900), and held that laughter corrects the rigidity by which life imitates the machine. The series' great comic objects are precisely such encrustations: the reset that returns the household to its starting point, the clone that resumes a dead man's life, the Meeseeks that cannot stop, the decoys that cannot tell themselves from the family, the Citadel in which every person is a copy of every other. Laughter at them is the vindication of the living against the mechanical — the recognition, in the instant of laughing, that a person is not a function and a life is not a loop. Helmuth Plessner described laughing and crying as the responses of a person to situations that admit no other answer, in which the body answers for the person (*Lachen und Weinen*, 1941); the eructative caesura of Chapter 2 is a third such answer, the gut speaking where the intellect has no more to say. Simon Critchley has argued that the comic, rather than the tragic, may be the more truthful acknowledgment of finitude — anti-heroic where tragedy is heroic, and bound to the body's absurdity (*Very Little … Almost Nothing*, 1997; *On Humour*, 2002). Comic finitism names the series' wager that comedy is not an evasion of the gravity of its material but the only form in which that gravity can be borne without being falsified.

C.3

Comedy without Romance

The title of the seventh season's finale, "Fear No Mort" (S7E10), echoes — whether or not by design — two of the oldest consolations in English: the dirge of *Cymbeline* and the twenty-third Psalm. The echoes are instructive in their difference. The Psalmist's consolation is relational: he fears no evil not because there is none but because he is accompanied. The dirge's consolation is generic, and, in its dramatic setting, mistaken. In *Cymbeline* it is sung over Imogen, who is not dead but drugged, and she wakes beside a headless corpse dressed in her husband's clothes, which she mourns as her husband: grief lavished upon a counterfeit. The play is a romance, and in its last act the lost are found and the dead prove living. Shakespeare's late plays restore what was lost with a regularity that defines their genre, most famously in *The Winter's Tale*, where a husband who has mourned his wife for sixteen years watches her statue come to life.

The series is not a romance. Its dead do not wake; its counterfeits are not the beloved; no statue moves. *Rick and Morty* is *The Winter's Tale* without the statue. Comic finitism is comedy without romance: comedy that has given up restoration and kept the company.

The finale whose title this section borrows comes as near to the statue scene as the series ever has, and refuses it. In "Fear No Mort" Rick and Morty enter a hole that makes its occupants live through their worst fears. Inside it, a dying younger Rick delivers Diane to the family home, and Rick, given his wife back, falls in love with her again and wants to stay — until he sees that the hole is killing Morty, and lets her go to save him. Then the episode withdraws even that. The hole had been producing only Morty's fears; Rick never went in; the restored Diane was the boy's vision, not the grandfather's, and the fear the boy finally names is his own dependence on Rick. He passes through it, and when he climbs out, Rick, who has been waiting, takes a photograph of him from his wallet and pins it to the board of those who survived. The restorative fantasy is located where this dissertation would predict, in the remainder whose place depends on the loss; even there it is renounced for the living boy; and what answers it is not a restoration but a keeping. Read through the Psalm rather than the dirge, the finale's title states the conclusion of this dissertation. *Fear no Mort*: fear no death, because death is not the worst thing — the worst thing is the refusal of finitude that converts a grief into a cosmos; and fear no Morty, because the boy whose name means death is the one through whom the genius might be returned to the finite. Cavell found the root of Lear's tragedy in the fear of being loved. Rick's version of that fear has been the series' subject from its first scene, in which a drunken old man drags a boy from his bed to propose the end of the world. The series' answer, given quietly and repeatedly, is the Psalmist's: not that there is nothing to fear, but that one is not alone in the valley.

C.4

Contributions

The dissertation's contributions may be stated in the terms set out in the Introduction. To the philosophy of popular culture it offers a reading in which the series' nihilism is not a doctrine to be evaluated but a symptom to be interpreted — grief-work mistaken for metaphysics — together with a method for reading the paratext as a hypotextual unconscious and a generic identification of the series as Menippean anatomy. To ethics it offers practical haecceity, an account of the irreplaceability of persons adequate to an ontology of counterparts, grounded neither in qualities nor in metaphysical thisness nor in purpose, but in the history of keeping; and with it the concepts of counterfeit repetition and the ethics of the remainder. To narrative theory and media studies it offers a typology of multiverse fiction organised by its response to the bad infinite, the diagnosis of a grief-fantasy of substitution characteristic of the multiversal turn, and the concept of the Smerdyakov problem for the analysis of reception. Along the way it has proposed instruments that may prove useful beyond the series: the eructative caesura as a figure of the body's counter-testimony; the

algetic criterion as a name for the epistemology of suspicion at its limit; the consolation of plurality, with its substitutive and dissociative faces; narcissistic curvature; and the Omega event.

C.5

imits and Further Research

Three limits should be acknowledged. The first is the corpus. The analysis ends with the seventh season, at the consummation of the revenge arc; the seasons that followed, the series' animated spin-offs, and its comics constitute a post-revenge phase whose relation to the argument — whether the household becomes, for Rick, the hearth of the Eumenides — is the most important question the dissertation leaves open. The second is method. The account of reception in Chapter 9 is interpretive rather than empirical; an ethnography of the series' audiences, attentive to the many viewers who never identified with Rick, would test and doubtless complicate the account of the Smerdyakov problem. The third is scope. Practical haecceity has been developed from a single work and its comparands; it requires elaboration against the analytic literature on personal identity and the value of persons, and against the ethics of care developed by Nel Noddings, Joan Tronto, and Eva Feder Kittay, with whose emphasis on the particular relation it has much in common.

Two lines of further research seem especially promising. Interactive media, whose save files and reloads make the reset a mechanic rather than a convention, offer a natural laboratory for the ethics of the remainder; Toby Fox's *Undertale* (2015), whose characters remember what the player has undone, is an obvious point of departure. And the analysis of the car instructed to keep Summer safe (Chapter 4) bears on a question of growing practical urgency: whether care can be specified as an objective for an artificial agent at all, or whether, as the series suggests, care is a practice that turns into its opposite when it is optimised. If the latter, the ethics of keeping may have something to say to the design of machines as well as to the reading of cartoons.

C.6

Coda

The last image of "Rixty Minutes" is of a family on a sofa, watching television from other universes. Behind them, in the yard, is a grave; beyond the yard, through the garage, lies the whole of the infinite. The received reading looked at the screen, saw the multiverse, and concluded that nothing matters. This dissertation has tried to look at the sofa. What it finds there is not a doctrine but a practice: a substitute brother and an unplanned sister, remainders of a cosmos built out of grief, keeping one another company in front of the bad

infinite. Siduri would have recognised the scene, and so would Qoheleth, and Montaigne, and the fox. Nobody exists on purpose; nobody belongs anywhere; everybody is going to die. The series does not refute a word of it. It makes room on the sofa.

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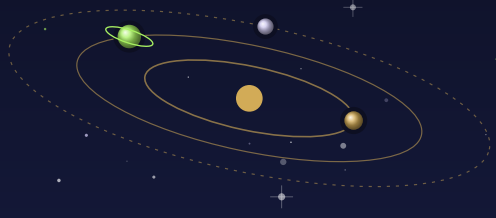
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Keywords

Rick and Morty ◦ Dan Harmon ◦ Justin Roiland ◦ adult animation ◦ television studies ◦ seriality ◦ sitcom reset ◦ Story Circle ◦ monomyth ◦ travesty ◦ hypertextuality ◦ hypotextual unconscious ◦ Menippean satire ◦ anatomy (Frye) ◦ carnival and the grotesque ◦ Mikhail Bakhtin ◦ eructative caesura ◦ multiverse fiction ◦ multiversal turn ◦ many-worlds interpretation ◦ modal realism ◦ counterpart theory ◦ principle of plenitude ◦ bad infinite (Hegel) ◦ argument from plurality ◦ consolation of plurality ◦ theodicy ◦ simulacra and simulation ◦ scepticism ◦ personal identity ◦ algetic criterion ◦ double horror of purpose ◦ teleology ◦ Saturn and melancholy ◦ demiurge ◦ Gnosticism ◦ trickster ◦ Prometheus ◦ Faust ◦ Don Quixote ◦ dyadic mortification ◦ parrhesia ◦ mourning and melancholia ◦ manic defence ◦ narcissistic rage ◦ *Nachträglichkeit* ◦ incorporation and the crypt ◦ cryptonymy ◦ transgenerational haunting ◦ melancholic cosmogony ◦ narcissistic curvature ◦ Omega event ◦ end of revenge ◦ haecceity (Duns Scotus) ◦ practical haecceity ◦ ethics of thisness ◦ keeping ◦ attention (Murdoch, Weil) ◦ acknowledgment (Cavell) ◦ the face (Levinas) ◦ the scene of the Two ◦ repetition and counterfeit repetition (Kierkegaard) ◦ performative utterance ◦ finitude (Heidegger, Hägglund) ◦ natality and plurality (Arendt) ◦ polis of remainders ◦ ethics of the remainder ◦ ethics of care ◦ comic finitism ◦ nihilism ◦ absurdism ◦

existentialism ◦ reception theory ◦ aberrant decoding ◦ the bad fan ◦ Smerdyakov problem ◦ screen memory ◦ commodity fetishism ◦ culture industry ◦ Siduri tradition ◦ *Epic of Gilgamesh* ◦ Ecclesiastes ◦ *Candide* ◦ typology of multiverse fiction.